The Forgotten Wisdom

Living with Nature: Real Life Experiences, Demonstrating the Skills and Knowledge of the Great Lakes Anishinaabe.

Michael Antonio Filippi

The Forgotten Wisdom: Book Two of The Forgotten Series

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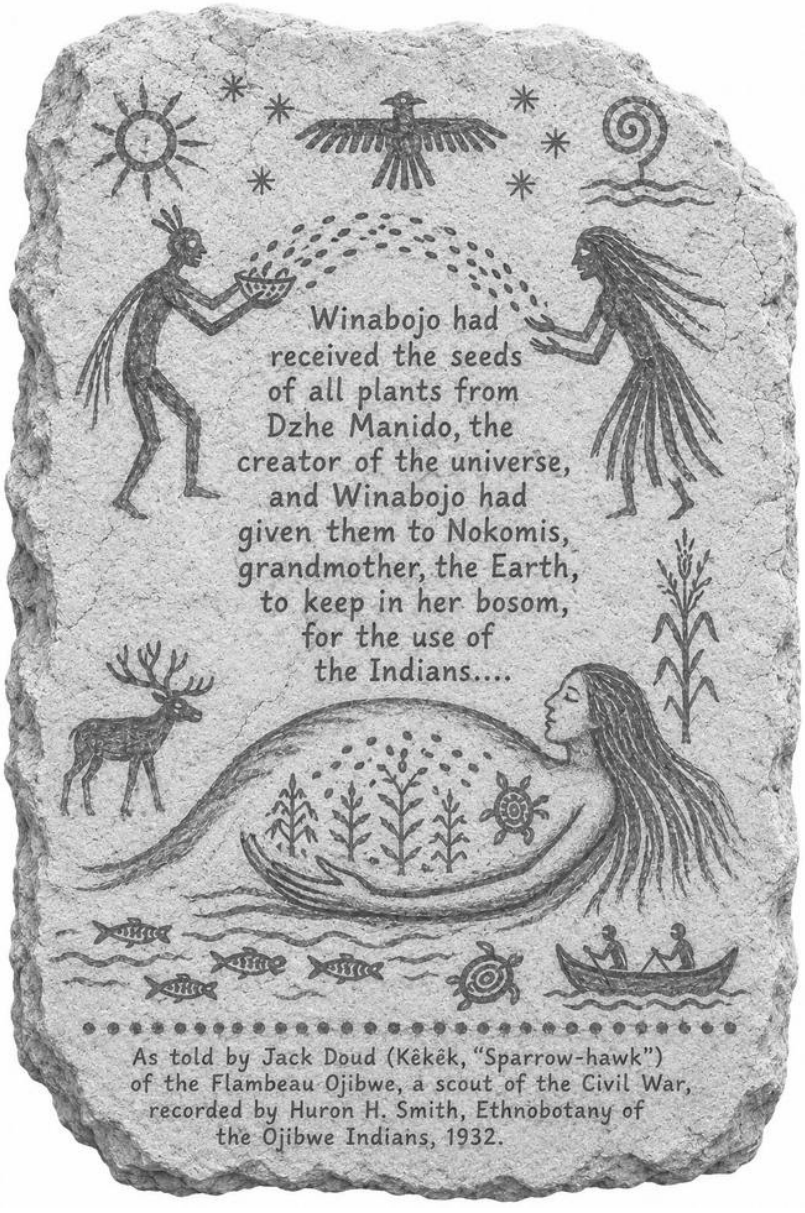
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This book is a work of history. Every skill, food, medicine, and craft described in it is drawn from the documentary record and is presented as an account of how the peoples of the Great Lakes lived, not as instruction or advice.

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To all the people of Earth who would rather be subjected to the cruelties of nature, as harsh as nature can be; than be trapped in a world where corporate greed, in their insatiable pursuit of resources, destroys the very ecosystems that make any life possible.


Winabojo had
received the seeds
of all plants from
Dzhe Manido, the
creator of the universe,
and Winabojo had
given them to Nokomis,
grandmother, the Earth,
to keep in her bosom,
for the use of
the Indians....
As told by Jack Doud (Kêkêk, "Sparrow-hawk")
of the Flambeau Ojibwe, a scout of the Civil War,
recorded by Huron H. Smith, Ethnobotany of
the Ojibwe Indians, 1932.

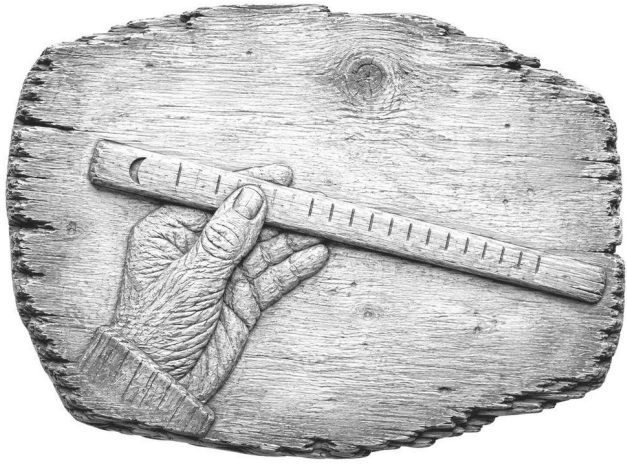
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Book Two: The Seasons

The Turning of the Year



How a person marks the turning of the year is a matter of culture, not of nature. The first of January opens our year for reasons that have nothing to do with the cold or the crops. It comes down to us from the politics of ancient Rome and the reforms of the Roman calendar: the month of January itself added, by tradition, at the decree of a Roman king. The Indigenous peoples of the Americas chose their year's beginning for more practical reasons. Theirs was chosen for environmental reasons, reflected in the ecology of the world itself, and for the Ojibwe of the western Great Lakes the year began not in the dead of winter but in the fall.

An old woman named Nodinens, of the Mille Lac band, once told how the year used to be organized. She was seventy-four when she said it, remembering back to her girlhood. "When I was young everything was very systematic," she began. "We worked day and night and made the best use of the material we had." Then she told how her father literally held the year in his hand. "My father kept count of the days on a stick. He had a stick long enough to last a year and he always began a new stick in the fall. He cut a big notch for the first day of a new moon and a small notch for each of the other days." And she chose where to start. "I will begin my story," she said, "at the time when he began a new counting stick."

So will this book. The year began in the fall, when the rice and the sugar and the dried meat were put away and a new stick was notched, and it came around through winter and spring and summer to the fall again. The people who lived it were the Ojibwe of the western Great Lakes, in the country of woods and water that runs from Lake Superior down into the upper Mississippi. They did not keep a modern calendar, instead they would organize the months by the phases of the moon: lunar months. The moons were named for what each time of the year brought to the people from their natural environment. The names reflected seasonal variance and depending on where they were located, on this vast continent, their time for gathering a particular crop varied from one community and one stretch of country to the next. When this book names a moon it names one people's, not a calendar every Ojibwe kept. They kept it by the work each moon required, and by a notched stick, and the work changed as the year progressed, and the progression was recurrent every year.

We can follow that year closely, and in the people's own words, because some of them recorded their traditions and their wisdom. Nodinens related the whole of it for Frances Densmore, an outsider who came with a notebook and, to her credit, wrote the elder woman's account down as she gave it. And William Warren, born at La Pointe in 1825, was a man of the boundary between two peoples. His father was a white fur trader from New England; his mother was three-quarters Ojibwe, descended through the Cadotte traders from a hereditary chief of La Pointe. Warren grew up in his mother's world and spoke Ojibwe from childhood, and his father saw to it that he was given an English schooling in the East. He gathered the larger history of his people from the old men before it could be lost, and wrote it down in English. "Around whose lodge fires I have passed many a winter evening," he wrote of his grandfathers, "listening with parted lips and open ears to their interesting and most forcibly told tales." When Warren was still young, the aged Pillager chief Flat Mouth traveled from Leech Lake to sit with him and tell him what he knew. He called him grandson: an indication of how close the two became during their years together. Between the old woman's vividly described year

and the young man's gathered history, the turning of the year comes down to us from the people who lived it.

Nodinens's father's stick began when the cold season was imminent, so too does her tale begin there. When her mother had put away the wild rice and the maple sugar and the winter's food and made new bulrush mats for the sides of the wigwam, the family made ready to move. "My home was at Mille Lac," she said, "and when the ice froze on the lake we started for the game field." Six families went together into the deep woods and made a winter camp, the wigwams set in a circle and banked with evergreen boughs and snow; a drying rack for meat over the fire in the middle. They snared rabbits and partridges and froze what they did not need, and her father, a good hunter, sometimes killed two deer in a day. That was the winter work, and it held them until the cold began to break.

Then, in Nodinens's telling, her father would say, "one month after another month has gone by. Spring is near and we must get back to our other work." They packed the dried meat and the furs and set out. "We started off in the snowstorm and went to the sugar bush." At the sugar camp the women took the birch-bark dishes out of storage and began tapping the trees, and near the camp was a food cache opened after the winter, holding, she remembered, cedar-bark bags of rice and cranberries sewn into birch-bark makuks and long strings of dried potatoes and apples.

Warren observed the same season play out among his people, and described the scenes with equal clarity: the women in the sugar bushes among the maples, the men scattered after the furred animals whose pelts were best in that season, and then, when the ice and snow had gone, the scattered families gathering again at their villages, and "the time for recreation, ball-playing, racing, courtship, and war, had once more arrived." Spring was also the season of the sacred Midewiwin rites, and of the young men's fast ball game, (a game that is still played today called lacrosse), and of the first canoes loaded with pelts setting off for the trading posts on the Great Lakes.

Summer was the season of the gardens and the making. The families lived along the lake shore, each with its own garden of potatoes and corn and pumpkins, and the women made the mats and the bark bags and dried the berries as they ripened, blueberry and gooseberry and June berry along the shore. Warren, in the diction of his century, called summer the women's season of rest, and then in the same breath named the incredible amount of work involved: the lodge coverings and the mats for the coming winter and the berries picked and dried. The "rest" was his word for it, but not the reality of it. The mats were the winter's shelter and the berries were the winter's food, and the women made them both.

Then, as the year turned hard again, the people directed their efforts to the coming rice harvest. "Next came the rice season," Nodinens said. "The rice fields were quite a distance away and we went there and camped while we gathered rice." Warren put the same turn in the historian's frame: the hard work "again commences in the autumn, when the wild rice which abounds in many of the northern inland lakes becomes ripe and fit to gather. Then, for a month or more, they are busied in laying in their winter's supply." When the rice was in, the gardens were harvested and the crops were stored in caches near the gardens, the men went off to the fall trapping, and the women fished on into the first snow. And when the men came back the family started once more for the winter camp, and the father cut the first big notch in a new stick. The year had come around to where Nodinens chose to begin it.

That is the wheel this book turns on. Winter and its hunt, spring and its sap, summer and its gardens and making, the fall harvest and the rice, and around again. Each of the chapters that follow takes up one turn of it, and the plants and the skills and the daily work that belonged to each season.

A word about the voices. This book keeps the people's own wherever it can. Where a woman like Nodinens articulated the daily tasks of the year, or where men like Warren, or Copway and Blackbird and Jones after him did so, their words lead, and they are named. Where only the outsiders wrote things down, the

ethnographers who came later with their notebooks, their record fills in the craft the people did not pause to explain. And where one of those voices judges through the lens of its own time, as Warren does when he calls his people a doomed race, or calls a woman's year-long labor rest, the book keeps the judgment as that writer's own. What is left when the judgments are set aside is the year itself, kept by an elders notched stick and told by an elder who had lived every season of it.

How the Wisdom Was Given



This book emphasizes the skills that it took to survive as one with the environment; but more than that it highlights the wisdom of living in harmony with the natural systems that provide the sustenance. The reality of any culture is that living on the land is not all "roses". To live in nature is a balance between symmetry and tension, unity and strife. How to tie a rice sheaf, tan a hide, read a winter sky, tap a maple, set a snare, treat a wound or trade with a neighbor: the daily knowledge that turned a hard country into a living. But to the people who held it, none of this was merely technique. Every skill came from somewhere, and everything it took from the world was owed something in return. Before the skills, then, it is worth saying where the knowledge was understood to come from, and the one rule that governed the use of all of it.

It was believed that the world and its gifts were not of the people's own making. They were given. Behind everything stood the creator, who had made the world and set the people in it with what they needed to live. And much of the shaping of that world, and the teaching of the crafts, was laid to Wenabojo, the great figure of the old stories, who had walked the earth when it was new. It was Wenabojo, the people said, who taught them to make the canoe; it was Wenabojo who put the labor into the maple so the sugar

would not come too cheap. The knowledge had a giver, and that mattered, because a gift is not the same as a possession. A gift carries an obligation.

Knowledge reached a person along two roads. The first was the elders, the long handing-down described in another chapter, the whole body of skill carried in the memory of the old and passed to the young by watching and doing. The second road was the dream. At the edge of adulthood a young person went out alone, blackened the face, and fasted for days, waiting for a vision. In that vision came a guardian spirit, a manidoo, and often a direction for life, a power, a song that belonged to that person alone. Children were told from the first, "Try to dream, and to remember what you dream." A dream was not idle. It was a way of knowing, taken as seriously as the tracks in the snow, and a hunter's dream of where the game would be was acted on like a fact.

And over all of it lay a single rule. We call it reciprocity; the people understood it in plainer terms: nothing was taken from the land without something given back to the land, in thanks and in offering. When the world gave, the people answered with a gift. A medicine root was not dug until tobacco had been laid in the ground beside it and the plant spoken to. A bear was not killed without an apology to it, and its bones were not treated casually. The first berries, the first rice, the first of every food of the year, were offered before the people ate freely. Rice was left standing to seed the bed again, and bark was taken without killing the tree. This is the heart of the whole book. The people did not stand outside the natural world and use it. They lived inside it, in a relationship of exchange, and the relationship had to be kept, season by season, or the land would fail to provide.

The keeping and the deepening of this understanding had its own institution, the Midewiwin, the Grand Medicine society, which held the plant lore and the sacred history on birch-bark rolls. Its members understood it not as the worship of anything but as a way of living long and well. "The Midewiwin," one of them told Densmore, "is not so much to worship anything as to preserve the knowledge of herbs for use in prolonging life," and life was

prolonged "by right living, and by the use of herbs." What went on inside the medicine lodge was not for outsiders, and it is not set down here. But its purpose was of a piece with everything else: knowledge, received as a gift, and used with care.

So the wisdom in the chapters that follow was not, to the people, a bag of clever tricks. It was received, from the creator and from Wenabojo, from the elders and the dream, and it was held under an obligation to give back. The skills are the outward form of that relationship. When a woman laid tobacco beside a root, or a hunter spoke to the bear he had killed, that was not a quaint custom added onto the practical work. That was the practical work, understood rightly: a life lived not against the land but in agreement with it.

Part One: The Ricing Moon



Whose Water



The year began here. The Overture left an old man notching a new counting stick as the cold came on, and the first work the new year asked was the taking of the rice. These people did not cut the year into four seasons the way a later calendar would; they kept it by the moon, thirteen of them to the turning year, each named for what it brought. The first moon of the new year was the Wild Rice Moon, and when it came, at the close of the warm months, the families left the lake shore where they had spent them and moved to the rice lakes. The working unit was the family, or the group of near relatives who camped and worked together the year around.

William Warren, the Ojibwe historian, saw one of these camps himself. In the fall of 1850 he came to Prairie Rice Lake, a shallow, miry-bottomed water so thickly grown with rice that canoes had to be worked through it by cut lanes, and found it, in his words, "occupied by fifty wigwams of the Ojibways, numbering over five hundred souls," who "were busily employed in gathering the rice, camping separately in spots where it grew in the greatest thickness and abundance." Five hundred people had moved to one lake for the harvest. To the Indigenous people who lived during that time, the rice fields were a natural extension of the village... it was the village making the rice field, their new moons cycle, home.

A great deal was left in the water, and it is worth being careful about why, because it is easy to tidy into a lesson the record does not support.



A woman tying the standing rice into small sheaves, the sign that this stretch of water was already spoken for.

Densmore recorded that a portion was allowed to fall, or was sown on the water as seed. Albert Jenks, who watched the harvest at Lac

Courte Oreilles in 1899 and set down a whole study of it, saw the same thing from a different angle and gave the plainer metric. By his reckoning only three or four percent of a stand's grain was actually gathered. The rest fell. Some of it the harvesters could never have caught: for the ripe, dry fruit shattered at a touch and the wind took more. Some of it the ducks and other waterfowl took, and in the taking scattered and sowed it by happenstance. And some of it people did sow by hand, though Jenks was careful to say they did so, where they did it at all, presumably from plain economic motive, to keep a good bed producing, and not from any rule about leaving a share behind.

So the grain on the water was not mainly a gift returned to the lake. It was mostly that which could not be caught, reseeded by the birds that fed on it, with deliberate hand-sowing a smaller and practical part of the picture. Jenks called the general shortfall underproduction, not restraint, and left the motive at that. What the record will carry is narrower and truer than a conservation ethic: the people took what they could use and could catch, the lake and the ducks did the rest, and where a family sowed a bed by hand it did so to keep the bed feeding it. One people, the Menomini, refused to sow the rice at all, holding it wrong to plant what the spirit had given, and their refusal is its own answer to any single tidy account of what these harvests meant.

A rice lake was not open water taken by whoever came first, and it was not owned the way a later deed would mean it either. It sat between the two, and more than one observer across two centuries described the same in-between agreement. Before anyone claimed it, the rice was common. What made a part of it a family's was the marking, and the marking was done days ahead, in plain sight, not in a race on the morning of the harvest. A woman went out before the grain was ripe and tied the standing stalks into small sheaves, and the tied bundles stood in the water as a sign that this stand was spoken for. Jonathan Carver saw it in the 1760s and wrote that each family, "being able to distinguish their own property by the manner of fastening the sheaves, gathers in the portion that belongs to them." Near Green Bay, Ellis put the principle exactly: twisting the standing stalks into bunches "gives the party twisting

the bunches a kind of pre-emption to so much of the rice, which before was all common." Densmore, recording the Minnesota Ojibwe a century and a half after Carver, gave the same practice and added the detail that a woman went out about ten days ahead. The particular ten days was her own note. The principle underneath it, the tying, the pre-emption, the common rice made someone's by the work of marking it, runs through account after account, the earliest of them, among the neighboring Dakota, set down as far back as 1671.



Wild rice bound and tied off, the mark a family made to claim a stand of the grain before it ripened.

This was not ownership by grant or allotment. Albert Jenks, who studied it, called it property by preoccupation: certain fields were habitually worked by the same families, who camped at them and came back to them year after year, and, in his words, "no one disputes their ownership, unless an enemy from another tribe, in which case might establishes right." Within a people it was orderly and uncontested. Between peoples it was a border like any other, and the rice country was fought over. William Warren, of these

people himself, confirms the settled side of it in a single line: at the great Prairie Rice Lake camp the five hundred gatherers were "camping separately in spots" of the lake, each family to its own water. And a sharing lay under the whole arrangement that made the claiming less hard than it sounds. The Potawatomi chief Pokagon, writing of wild rice among his own people, put it plainly: "Our people always divide everything when want comes to the door." A family held its portion, and a family that lost its portion was fed by the rest. How much of this working order survived once the newcomers came and began carving the whole country into property that could be bought and sold is another matter, and one the old accounts do not follow.

The first collection of the season was prepared complete, with songs to the deities and a ceremonial feast, before the general harvest began. Smith recorded that this was done, but wrote no more than that. No song was written down, no feast described, no speaker named. Densmore, who recorded the gathering ceremonies for birch and cedar in some detail, does not report this one. What was sung over the first rice of the year did not reach the page: a history, long forgotten like the rice harvest itself and so too, the people whose lives depended upon it.



A rice lake at harvest time, the shallow water grown thick with grain.

The same grain that was a traditional lived experience for the people and opened with a ceremonial event also became a trading commodity with a price. For countless generations wild rice was a highly prized item that could be traded with other tribes not so fortunately situated or equipped: later it was sold to the new

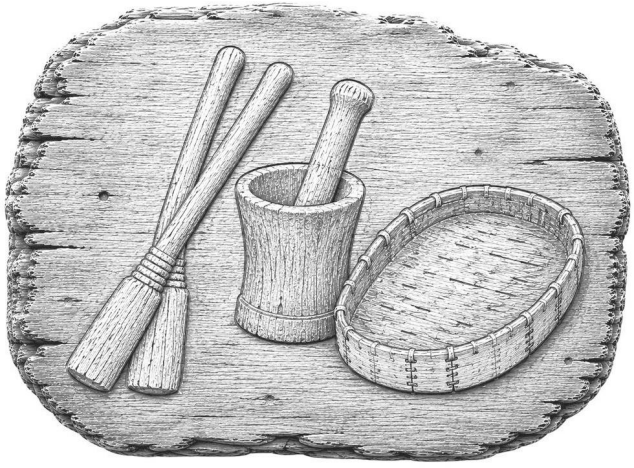
European arrivals. Smith recorded wild rice selling in the Milwaukee market at a dollar and five cents a pound, and some of the harvest was sold. All things were of necessity or convenience in the same season; the harvest, the trade... and the record holds them together without apology. Densmore noted the practical root of it: rice dried hard, prepared a certain way, kept indefinitely and could serve as seed. A food that stores is a food that can be traded. But this fact was not just "the way of the people" it is the way of all people throughout the ages.

Manoomin sits at the heart of the Anishinaabe story. In the migration history the people were told to travel until they reached the place where food grows on the water, and where they found the wild rice, they stayed. The grain on the water marked the end of a long road, and it remains central to the homelands and identity of the Anishinaabe, its harvest still bound up with season, with care, and with law.

What the fall harvest held, set down plainly, is this. In late summer the families camped on lakes they had a recognized claim to, waited on the grain to ripen, and took it in a way that let them return in a few days and take more. They did not take all of it. They opened the season with a ceremony that no one wrote down, dried and parched and pounded and trod and winnowed the grain through the whole craft of keeping, and packed it away for winter, while some of it went to market by the pound.

> *"It was not the intention, however, to harvest all the rice, a portion being allowed to fall into the water, or being sowed on the water as seed." (Frances Densmore, Uses of Plants by the Chippewa Indians, 1928)*

The Tools of the Wild Rice



Frances Densmore, recording Chippewa practice in the early twentieth century, visited and photographed three rice camps, and her account is the fullest that survives. A camp was set up on the shore of a lake where the rice stood thick. What the families carried with them was particular, and the list is worth reading closely, because it shows how much of the harvest was planned rather than improvised: a canoe with a pole for pushing, two rice-beating sticks, birch-bark rolls the size of a wigwam cover, a kettle for parching, a paddle shaped for stirring rice and nothing else, a barrel sunk in the ground for the first pounding and the pestles to work it, winnowing trays of birch bark, and, in the older days, storage bags woven of cedar or basswood bark.

Nearly every tool on that list was another plant. The rice harvest ran on birch, cedar, and basswood before a single grain was taken.



Gathering wild rice: a canoe is worked through the bed while the grain is bent over the side and knocked into the boat.

The canoe was pushed through the standing rice with a forked pole. This was heavy work, and usually a man's, while a woman sat in the stern and took the grain. Huron Smith, working among the Wisconsin Ojibwe a few years later, recorded three to a canoe, two women and a man.

The taking was done with the two sticks. The woman bent a sheaf of stalks down over the side with one and struck it with the other, a sweeping but gentle stroke, and the ripe grains fell into the boat. She worked both sides of the canoe and used either hand. The canoes went out in the early morning and came back by mid-afternoon: and only when a canoe was full, was it counted as a day's gathering.



A bark bag of the kind the finished rice was stored in for the winter.

The precision of a woman's touch upon the rice plants was an art form and a true skill. A good gatherer freed the ripe grains without knocking loose the green ones, so the same stretch of water could be worked again three or four days later, when more had ripened. A stand stripped bare in one pass gave up its ripe grain and spilled the rest into the lake, and there was nothing to come back for. The anticipation necessitated preparations that had begun at an earlier stage of ripening. The families camped when the grain stood at the milk stage, still soft, and made trial collections to judge when it was ready. The lake set the date, not the people. Colder water meant a later harvest and so areas of the lake near cold streams were left for last. The best weather was warm and still, for wind or rain shook the grains down before anyone could catch them.

Green rice will not keep, and the work that turned a canoe-load into a winter store ran through several stages, each with its own tools kept at the ricing camp.



A canoe among the standing rice at the harvest.

1. Drying. The fresh grain was spread a few inches thick on mats of woven reed, cedar, or basswood bark, and turned so it cured evenly.



The rice camp, where the gathered grain was cured, parched, and packed away.

2. Parching. Before metal, the rice was parched over a slow, carefully tended fire, laid on those same mats on a low scaffold so the heat reached it without scorching. Parching loosened the hull, brought up the nutty flavor and dark color, and was what let the grain keep. Only after iron came did the common way become a kettle propped at a slant over the fire, the grain stirred with a special paddle.

3. Pounding. The parched rice was given a first pounding to crack the hulls, worked with wooden pestles in a hollowed-log mortar, in later times a barrel, sunk in the ground.



Working the rice at the camp.

4. Treading. The last chaff was trodden out, in the old days in a clay-lined or hide-lined pit, later in a small sunk barrel, the worker steadied on two upright bars and treading in clean moccasins.

5. Winnowing. The grain was tossed in shallow birch-bark trays so the breeze carried the loosened chaff away and left the clean kernels of rice behind.

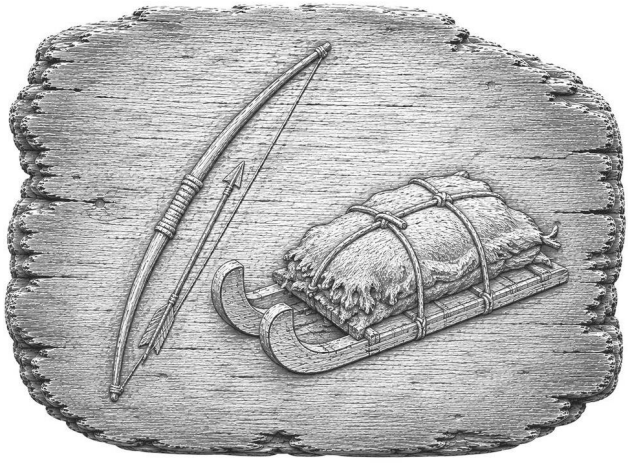


A stave-built tub of the kind sunk in the ground for pounding and treading the rice.

6. Storing. The finished rice was packed away for winter in bags of cedar or basswood bark and kept in caches, seasoned later with maple sugar or cooked into broth of duck or venison. Rice, maple, and game: the northern larder in a single bowl.

Densmore's photographs are the nearest thing to standing at the camp: a woman tying rice in her canoe in a heavy work waist, the stages of the tying in order, rice spread to dry, rice parching over a low fire, and a wooden mortar the caption calls formerly used in pounding rice. That last word carried its own quiet weight. In the same years that Densmore photographed women tying rice by hand in the old way, one part of the work had already slipped into the past tense.

The Fall Hunt



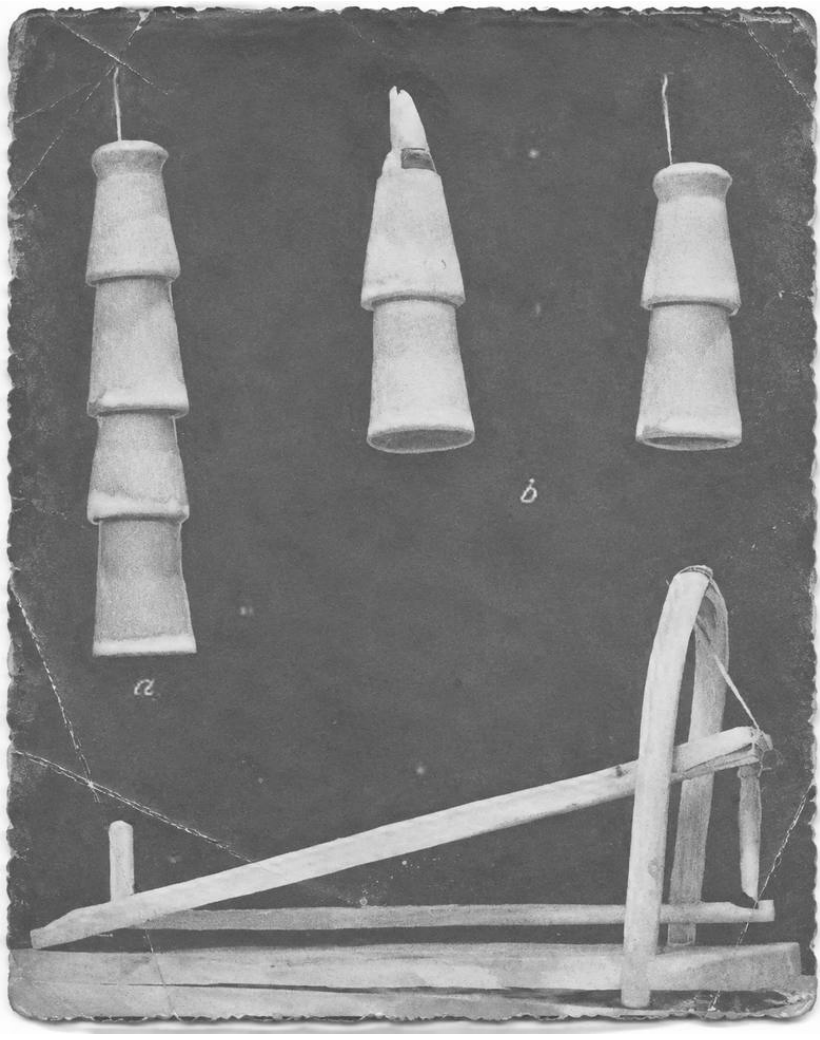
When the rice was cached and the gardens dug and the potatoes and corn and squash were down in their pits, the people turned from the harvest to the hunt. Nodinens marked the turn in a sentence: "By this time the men had gone away for the fall trapping," she said, and "the women began their fall fishing, often working at this until after the snow came." The Falling-Leaf Moon was the time of preparing and storing for winter. Families gathered from the woods and the water the meat, fat, and fur that would carry them through the cold before the lakes froze and the move inland began.

Deer provided the largest share of the meat, and hunting them was a skill refined over generations. A hunter's bow shot a flint point mounted in a shaft and bound with sinew. The binding was intentionally left loose so that a deer running through the brush would snap the shaft away, leaving the point in its body. The hunter then followed patiently, sometimes for a whole day, until the animal weakened from blood loss. The tracking rested on the hunter knowing the habits of a wounded animal. A deer trying to shake a hunter will jump, then trot, then walk a wide circle, and, the Chippewa said, it never crosses its own trail once the circle is closed. Knowing that, a hunter cut across outside the deer's circle and closed in, and often found it tired and lying down near where

the circle had begun. He carried his knife in a sheath on a basswood-bark belt, and if there was snow he carried a small toboggan on his back to bring the meat home. After dark he could hunt by a torch of twisted birch bark, which held the deer still in its light.

The animal the hunter most valued, and most honored, was the bear. A bear was fat in the fall, and its fat represented a year's cooking oil, rendered and stored and utilized for many purposes all winter. Bears were taken at the streams where they came to catch the suckers they were fond of, in a deadfall of a heavy suspended log, and Densmore set down the bait exactly: cooked fish, mashed and mixed with fish oil, or, when there was some to spare, maple sugar. The trap was walked every second day.

The fullest account of a bear taken and honored comes from a stranger who lived it. Alexander Henry, an English trader adopted into the family of the Ojibwe man Wawatam, wintered with them on the shore of Lake Michigan, and one January the family found a great pine torn by a bear's claws and hollowed near its top. They cut the tree down over two days with light axes, and when it fell and the bear came out, it was Henry who shot it. What the family did then was the honoring of the bear in a respectful ritual. "All my assistants approached," he wrote, "and all, but more particularly my old mother, took his head in their hands, stroking and kissing it several times; begging a thousand pardons for taking away her life; calling her their relation and grandmother; and requesting her not to lay the fault upon them, since it was truly an Englishman that had put her to death." Only then did they skin and butcher it, and the fat lay six inches deep. Back at the lodge the bear's head was set on a scaffold and dressed in the family's silver arm-bands and belts of wampum, with tobacco laid by its nose, and in the morning Wawatam lit the pipes and blew tobacco-smoke into the bear's nostrils and had Henry do the same. In the speech that followed, Henry wrote, Wawatam "deplored the necessity under which men laboured, thus to destroy their friends," and said the thing could not be helped, "since without doing so, they could by no means subsist." Then they ate.



Birch-bark calls used to bring deer within range, and a spring-pole trap for marten or beaver.

This was not sentiment laid over a killing. It was the shape of the whole relationship. The bear was a relation, addressed as a grandmother, killed because a family had to eat and acknowledged its sacrifice because it had died to feed them, and the remorse was stated aloud. The same understanding that closed the hunt opened it: when Wawatam brought his family to their winter ground, Henry watched him stop at the river's mouth, tie a dog's feet, and give it to the water with a long prayer to the Great Spirit for a

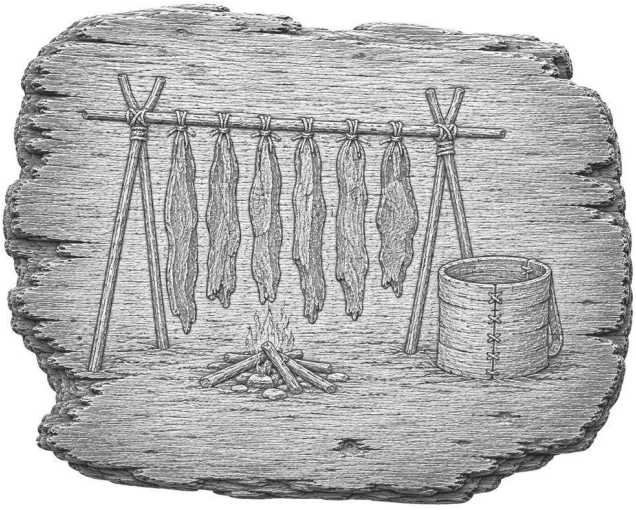
blessing on the chase. The people did not hunt as though the animals were things. They hunted as though they owed them something, and the debt was paid in tobacco and in apology, in the sacrifice of a venerated dog and in taking no more than the winter required.

What the bear provided was made use of with the same care as the rice was. Its fat was melted down and the oil was said to fill six porcupine-skins; strips of the meat were fire-dried and packed into the oil, where, Henry found, the meat stayed unspoiled "until the middle of summer." A skin of bear oil was the fat a winter's cooking relied on, and a fall that put a bear or two into the caches was a fall that provisioned the long, cold moons to come.

Meat was essential, but the other desirable product of the fall hunt was the fur. While the meat filled the larder, the trap lines filled the fur packs that would go down to the trader in the spring. Beaver were taken in the last of the open water by drifting: a canoe was worked several miles up a river before dark and then let go, to slide down the current without a sound, so the beaver coming out in the evening passed it within reach. Raccoon were run at night with dogs, and after the first snow a hunter needed only to follow the tracks. Beaver and raccoon and marten were meat and warmth first and trade goods second, and the fall was when they were gathered.

So the Falling-Leaf Moon filled the last of the year's stores. The women fished the shallows until the snow, the men worked the traps, the meat was dried and the fat was rendered and the furs were baled, and the bear's debt was paid. When the men came back from the trapping and the lakes had hardened, the family broke the summer ground for the last time and started inland for the winter camp, carrying its house, its fire, and now its winter's meat.

Making Meat Last



The fall hunt filled the drying racks, but fresh meat does not keep. The harder work was making it last. A family had to turn a season of hunting into food that would feed it through the five or six cold months ahead. They did this three ways: by drying, by fat, and by cold. European kitchens had an extra option available to them, that they used to accomplish the same end: salt.

Although traders from other tribes may have come through the Great Lakes region with salt to trade, there was never enough for preserving meat. A pre-contact woodland diet was not deficient in the essential mineral. If they kill a deer, the meat itself already contains sodium. Not a huge amount, but enough; fresh fish contain sodium; blood contained sodium, organs contained sodium. Wild plants contain potassium and small amounts of sodium. Added salt was simply not part of a pre-colonial diet. "Salt was unknown in the old days," Densmore was told. The Indigenous met their nutritional need for salt from the foods they ate. If you are eating whole animals and whole foods, your sodium intake is naturally higher than people often imagine.

Salt was never needed for the work or preservation or health. A diet of fresh meat, fish, and fat gave the body the sodium a diet of bread and grain lacks, so the hunger for salt that ran through

European history was simply not felt here. When salt did come, it came late, and as a trade good. A treaty at Leech Lake in 1855 promised the Minnesota people barrels of it, and on the Michigan shore Blackbird remembered it changing hands at a double handful for a beaver skin. Salt became a taste people acquired. It had never been a need.

Anyone who has made beef jerky knows salt is only one way to preserve meat, and its lack demanded the people use what methods were available to them. Meat and dried berries were seasoned with moose fat or deer tallow instead. Fish were "packed in layers without salt" and kept for months. Copway, remembering a hard season, said it plainly: they had no salt, and so they preserved their meat by drying it. A European stopped meat from spoiling by salting it. These people stopped it by drying it. The difference is worth a moment's reflection, because technologies are based on the available resources in any human population.

Meat spoils because it is wet and warm and open to the air. Take away the water, and it keeps. Take away the warmth, and it keeps. Drying took away the water, the northern cold took away the warmth, and fat sealed out the air. Drying was the base of everything else. Meat was cut into thin strips and hung on a rack over a slow fire, or spread in the sun, until it was hard and light. Fish were laid on a rack over a low fire, or strung on basswood cord and hung in the sun, then packed away hard in layers and tied in bundles. Dried this way, meat and fish weighed little and lasted long. A bag of dried venison was a week of meals a person could easily carry.

The most concentrated food was made by pounding meat. Densmore recorded the technique. "The meat of an entire deer was spread in layers on a tanned deer hide and pounded with a board until it was in shreds. It was then thoroughly mixed with hot deer tallow and put in a deer-hide bag. When desired for use it was cut in slices." Where there were berries, serviceberries or blueberries were pounded in with the meat and the fat. Another version was made by spreading dried meat on birch bark, covering it with more bark, and treading on it until it crushed. The people called

this "foot-trodden meat." This was the food the fur trade would later call pemmican, though the traders meant the buffalo kind. Here it was venison or moose, pounded and worked with fat. It needed no salt. The drying and the fat did the preserving, and a bag of it kept for months.

Fat was the second method, and a food in its own right. Tallow was rendered from the deer and the moose and poured hot into containers. Some went into birch-bark makuks. Some was poured, through a funnel of birch bark, into the cleaned bladder and the large intestine of the animal. Bear fat was the richest, and it was rendered into skin bags; the winter bear Henry helped take was reported to fill six of them. Meat packed down into fat kept well, because the fat closed out the air. Even the seasoning was fat. The bear's stomach was filled with rendered grease, called bear's grease, and used to flavor food where a European would have reached for the salt.

The third method was determined by the season. In the northern winter the cold did the preserving by both freezing and drying. Bear meat cut for winter use was "put on high racks to freeze," and frozen meat kept as long as the cold held, which was most of the hardest half of the year. A people who lived where the lakes froze solid had a larder that lasted from freeze-up to thaw. The same cold that made their winter hard had opportunities that were taken advantage of by the people.

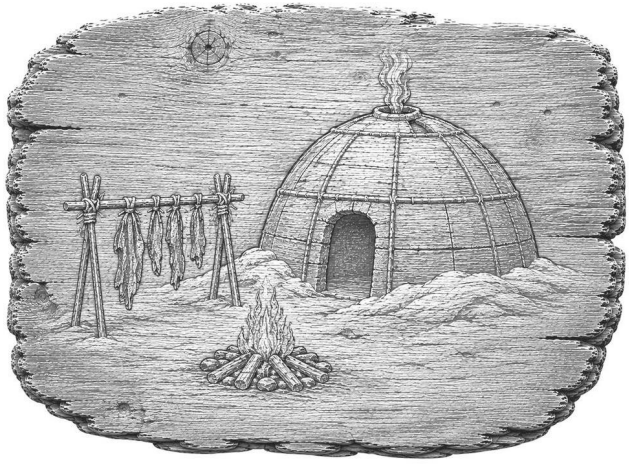
What was dried and pounded and rendered still had to be stored, and the cache was underground. Near the village the women dug pits about six feet deep and lined them with birch bark. The makuks of rice and sugar, the bags of dried meat, and the bundles of dried fish were stockpiled. The spaces were packed with hay, the top was closed with bark and laid-across beams, and a mound of earth went over all. Two or three families worked a cache together. Densmore's summary was descriptive: "The food kept perfectly, the pits were never disturbed." A cache was a pantry buried in the ground. A family could leave it for months, travel elsewhere, and return to find its contents still safe.

The fall hunt provided more than fresh meat. Venison was dried, fish packed, deer pounded into pemmican, and rendered fat sealed in containers of bark, bladder, and skin for the months ahead. Some of it froze or dried on the high racks. Some of it lay buried in the birch-lined pits. When the lakes hardened and the family started inland for the winter camp, it left a full cache in the ground behind it and carried its dried stores ahead. Those preparations made the difference between entering winter with confidence or entering it with uncertainty.

Part Two: The Freezing Moon



The Winter Camp



When the rice was cached and the lakes froze, the people went inland to the winter hunting grounds. This was the time of year that tested both the people and their strategies for survival. Regardless of whether the Indigenous people thought in these terms, the cold moons of winter were an unintended verdict that decided the effectiveness of their methods. They counted these moons by the cold and by hunger: the Freezing Moon, and, before the sap returned, the Hunger Moon. Where the warm-weather village had spread along the lake shore, family beside family, the winter camp was small and close, a few families in a ring in the deep woods, and everything in it was arranged around fire.



Nodinens of Mille Lac, whose first-person account of the year, recorded by Frances Densmore, threads this book.

Nodinens, the Mille Lac woman, remembered the shape of it from the inside. The wigwams stood in a circle, banked against the cold, with a rack for drying meat set over a fire at the center. "There was a big fire in the middle of the camp," she said, "and all the families did their cooking around this fire if the weather was not too cold,

but we always had a fire in the wigwam in the evening, so it would be warm for us to sleep. We always slept barefoot, with our feet toward the fire, and we loosened our other clothing." Through the day the women kept the central fire low and even to dry the meat, and spread sheets of birch bark over it if a snowstorm blew in. At night the men came back and built the fire up to dry their clothes, and, she remembered, "they sat around it, smoking and talking." Then the fire was banked with dry wood "so it would smolder all night." It never went out. In a Great Lakes winter the fire kept the family alive, and someone tended it every hour of the night.

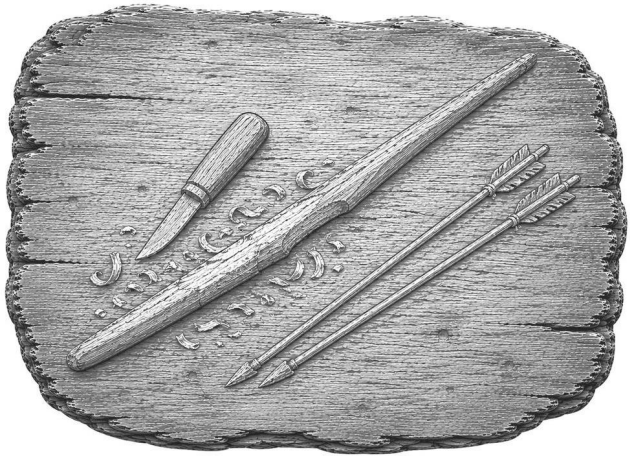
The winter work was divided between men and women, as the sugar-making and the rice harvest had been. The men hunted, and the women oversaw the camp: snaring rabbits and partridges, freezing what was not needed at once, drying the deer meat, mending the leather clothing that wore out fast in hard use. "My father was a good hunter," Nodinens said, "and sometimes killed two deer in a day." When a man killed more than he could carry, he brought back part of it and the women went out the next day and packed the rest home on their backs. William Warren, describing the same season farther west, set it in the frame of the year: the bands moved together onto the game grounds with the first fall of snow and hunted there through the cold until February. And everything the people of the winter camp ate was taken from carefully preserved fall caches and the frozen woods around them.



The open fire and kettle at the center of the winter camp.

The short days of the cold moons were filled with hunting and trapping and the constant work of keeping warm and fed. As the sun went down and the children tired of play and chores, the elders recited stories by the light of the flames. The long winter nights were spent wrapped warm in furs, beside the banked fire.

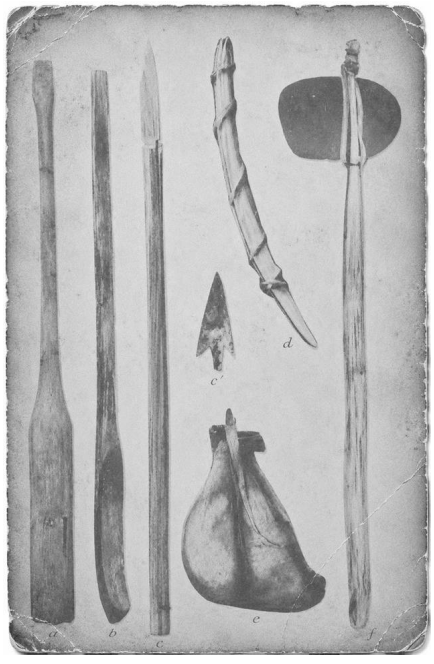
Making the Hunting Gear



Tools wear out during normal use, and the hunt was extremely hard on them. A bowstring broke, an arrow was lost, a snare rotted, a knife went dull. The time to make and mend the gear was the deep winter, when the camp was settled and the long nights kept a hunter indoors by the fire. Much of a family's toolwork was done then, in the coldest moons, when there was little else to do and every reason to be ready for the next hunt.

The bow came first, and it was made from a hard, springy wood, hickory where it grew. The maker was a true craftsman. Each hunter was capable of making his own, but as in any culture some of the people excelled beyond the average. In such situations trading skill for supplies was certainly common practice and some bows were true works of art. And whether of average workmanship or truly meticulous in design, every step of the work followed a method passed down through the generations. A real bow came from the trunk of a tree, not a branch. A branch might make a child's practice bow, but a bow for the hunt was split from a stave and worked down, the heartwood and the sapwood set so the two faces took the strain of the pull in different ways and together held the bend. The Great Lakes bow was a self bow, a single piece of wood shaped by hand. The sinew-backed and bone-strengthened bows of the Plains were another people's craft, made where good

bow wood was scarcer; in these hardwood forests, one good stave of hickory or ironwood was enough. The finished bow was often colored and marked. Densmore was told of a reddish color made from a black mud found near a certain spring: the mud was put on the fire, and the bow was held in the fumes until it took the color. Lines were etched into the wood with a hot pointed stone and filled with red paint.

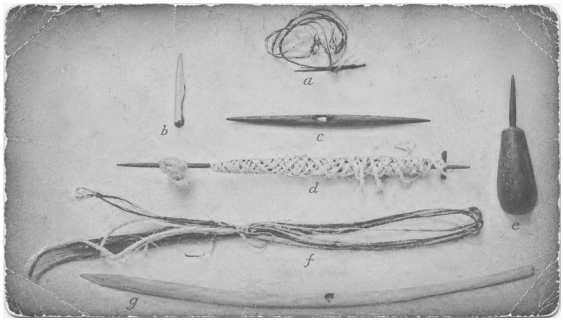


Worked wood and gear of the camp: arrows, a shaping tool, and a horn.

The string mattered as much as the bow, and only two materials were trusted to make a good one. The first was the fiber of the nettle stalk, twisted into cord and then rubbed with pitch to keep out the wet. The second was stranger and better: the neck of a snapping turtle. Densmore set the method down plainly. The Chippewa "cut off the neck of the snapping turtle close to its body, removed the skin and cut it round and round, making a long strip, which they twisted into a cord." A turtle-neck string, they said, "would neither stretch nor shrink, and lasted a long time." Sinew from a moose or deer would serve, but it was likely to break when it got wet, so the nettle and the turtle were preferred.

The arrow took more work than the bow, and it was made for the woods it was shot in. A Chippewa arrow was shorter than a Sioux arrow, because a long arrow was awkward among trees and because a hunter often shot from a crouch, "from the knee." The shaft was smoothed by rubbing it in the groove of a piece of sandstone. The point was set into a notch and bound with sinew. In the old days the point was bone, ground sharp; later it was iron, cut first from the hoop of a trader's pork barrel and then from worn frying pans. Feathers were bound to the shaft with sinew, and the ones most wanted were the eagle's and the hawk's. Every hunter marked his own arrows, with a certain feather or a line burned into the shaft, so a kill could be told by the arrow in it.

Some arrows were made for one quarry. Arrows for ducks were of pine or cedar, light enough to float, so a miss could be recovered from the water, and blunt enough not to tear the bird. An arrow for rabbits was tipped with the claw of a mud turtle. A claw made a narrow spike, and a spike punched through the fur where a broad, edged point would have caught in it.



Small tools of the women's work, among them an awl and a netting needle.

Making arrows well was a craft in itself, and some men made them for others. Tom Skinaway of Mille Lac told Densmore that as a young man he could make ten arrows in a day, complete with points and feathers, and that ten was the usual size of an order given to a worker in wood. A hunter might make his own arrows, or he might get them from the man who made them best.

Not all the hunt was done with the bow. Much of the winter's small game was taken in snares and deadfalls, and these too were made

by hand. A snare was a loop of nettle or basswood cord, set on a run where a rabbit or a partridge would put its head through it. A deadfall was heavier: a log propped to fall, held by a light trigger set against the bait, so that an animal nibbling the bait tripped the log down onto itself. A trap was made of cord, wood, and a carefully set trigger, and a family carried and reset it all winter.

The tools that made all of it were simpler than the things they made. Wood was shaped with a crooked knife, a blade bent at the tip for pulling toward the hand, and it was hollowed or hardened with fire where fire served better than a blade. Holes were made with an awl of bone, or of a hawthorn thorn for finer work. Stone is harder to find in the record, because iron had replaced it before anyone wrote these things down, but the old points were flint chipped to an edge, and the old knives and scrapers were stone and beaver tooth.

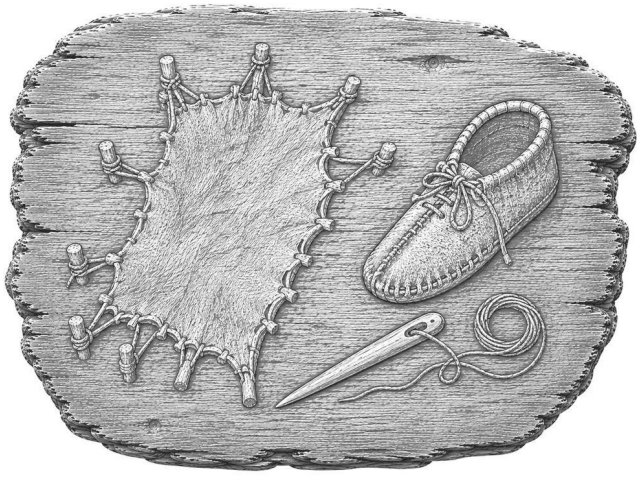


A garment of tanned fur, worn with the fur turned inward for warmth.

The making was taught early. A boy was given his first bow at five or six years old, a small thing about a foot long, strung with basswood twine and shot with blunt arrows. With it he began what Densmore's informants called the craft most necessary to a hunter. A boy learned to make and mend his gear at the same fire where he learned to use it.

The hands of the Indigenous people were seldom idle and the coldest moons were a time of making. While the snow lay deep and the hunting was hard, a hunter sat by the fire and made the year's arrows, twisted a new string, set a new trigger, and put a fresh edge on his knife. The gear was kept ready and in good repair, so the hunter would be prepared for the next day.

Hides and Sewing



The winter hunt gave a family two things: meat and hides. The meat was dried and stored. The hides were worked into leather, and working them was among the hardest and most skilled of the women's crafts. A raw deerskin is stiff, and it will rot. Turning it into soft, lasting leather took days of labor: impossible without a well provisioned tool kit. Most of it was done in the late winter and the early spring, when the winter's deerskins had piled up and there was time indoors to put on the finer details.

The work went in stages. First the hide was spread on the ground and the hair was sheared close with a sharp knife. Then it was soaked in clean water for a night or two. The soaked hide was laid over a smooth log, and the last of the hair was scraped away with a blade set in a handle. Before iron became available, materials were chosen that were found locally or traded from afar; copper, bone, horn, chert, flint or wood worked well to varying degrees and when a better tool was acquired it became their preferred and cherished implement. The same was true for the fleshing, which came next. The hide was hung over the top of a post so it fell loosely all around, and the fleshy tissue on the inside was cut and then worked off with a tool made from the leg bone of a moose, tied to the worker's upper arm by a thong.

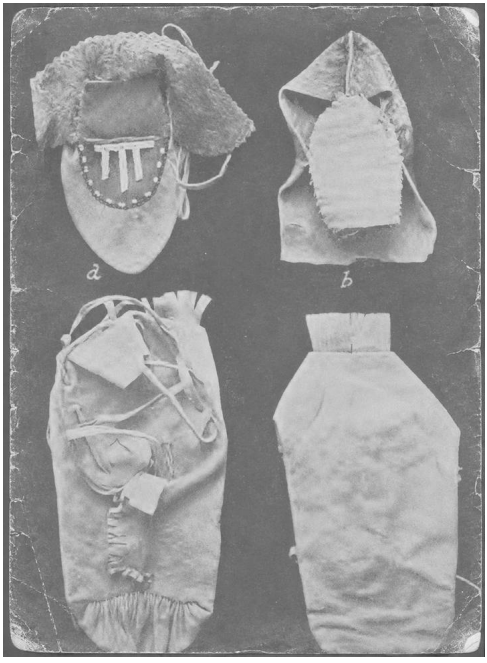


A woman scraping a hide over a log at Mille Lac, the very work this chapter describes.

The hide was then softened, and it was softened with the animal's own brains. Some peoples tanned leather with plant tannins drawn from bark or roots, but that was another tradition; the hides recorded here were softened with brains and finished with smoke, and the method was used above all on the deer. "The brains of the deer were rubbed on this hide to soften it," Densmore was told, "as the hide had very little oil in it." The point of the brains was softness. A deer hide is lean, and once its own oils had been scraped and soaked away it would dry as stiff as rawhide; the brains, rich in fat, worked oil back into the skin and made it soft and pliable. After the braining the hide was worked through a second bone tool, a deer's thigh bone with a hole cut in it, pulled back and forth until it was supple, and any rough spot was rubbed smooth with a small bone. Done well, the finished hides were "soft and colored a golden brown," and the tanning, Densmore wrote, was "the work of the women and was done in an expert manner."

The color came from smoke. Densmore watched a woman named Zozed do the smoking at Mille Lac. Zozed was in mourning, and

her hair hung loose. She dug a shallow pit, set a small frame of poles over it like a little tipi, and drew the hide down over the frame with its lower edge weighted flat to the ground. In the pit she lit a slow fire of dry corncobs. "This fire smolders slowly," Densmore recorded, "the smoke giving to the hide a golden yellow color. The hide is almost white before being colored in this manner." Several hides could be sewn into one cone and smoked together.



Moccasins and worked skins; the puckered seam over the toe is so characteristic it is traced to the name Ojibwe.

The sewing was done without needles. In place of a needle a woman used an awl. The awl made the hole, and the thread was then passed through the hole by hand. The oldest awls were the thorn of the thorn-apple tree or the splint bone of a deer, used just as they were; later ones were wooden, and later still a metal point set in a wooden handle. The thread was sinew. Deer sinew could be split into very fine strands for fine work, and moose sinew, coarser, did the heavy sewing. Every woman, Densmore noted, "kept a piece of dried sinew ready for work upon leather." One old

workbag that came to her, made of four deer hooves so it stood upright on the ground, still held its thorns and its sinew, "left by its former owner, dead these many years."

The leather became clothing, and the clothing was not a single garment but several separate pieces. A woman's oldest dress was two deerskins, one for the front and one for the back, tied together at the shoulders and held with a belt; a child's dress took one skin. A man wore a breechcloth, leggings, and moccasins, with a robe over all in the cold, and on the hunt a chest-piece of tanned muskrat worn with the fur against him for warmth. There was no single tailored hunting suit. There was a breechcloth, and leggings, and moccasins, and a robe, each made and mended on its own.



A flesher and a scraper, the tools used to clean a hide.

The moccasin was the most intricately made and most frequently mended equipment a person owned. It wore out fast and was replaced often. There were several patterns, and the puckered kind, gathered in a seam over the toe, was so characteristic that some have traced the name Ojibwe to it. Rabbit skin was not tanned at all. It was hung on the bushes until the wind blew the

loose hair away, and then used soft and warm, tucked into a cradleboard around a baby, or lining a child's moccasins and cap.

It can be said that for the Great Lakes region's Indigenous, a well made hide was of the greatest possible importance in all seasons. And like all things made, some people excelled at the task. A woman's labor: that of creating an outfit which exceeded the demands of an extreme environment and yet was also presented as a beautifully designed garment... brought the highest value in trade. So the winter's hides became the year's clothing, and surplus brought better tools. Hide by hide, in the late-winter lodge, the women made the clothes that would keep the family warm through the next year, out of the deer the men had brought home. When the sleds were packed for the sugar bush, the tanned skins went too, for no opportunity was wasted when living from the land.

The Fireside



The two moons the people called the Great Spirit Moon and the Little Spirit Moon arrived in the middle of winter. The cold was hardest then, and the nights were longest. It was in this deep cold that the Indigenous people lived closest to their stores and to their fires.

The day's work went on even so, and not all the winter's food came from the hunt. In these coldest moons, when the lakes lay under thick ice, the men fished through it. First the ice had to be opened. A man cut through it with an ice chisel, a heavy blade fixed to the end of a long pole, chopping straight down and lifting out the chips until he had a hole about two feet across. Then he lay down flat beside it, his face over the opening.

He pulled a blanket over his head and shoulders, held up on a small frame of sticks, so that no daylight reached the water. In that darkness, Kohl was told, a fisherman could see down forty or fifty feet into the still water. With one hand he worked a carved decoy, a small wooden fish weighted with lead and finished with a birch-bark tail, and made it swim as if it were alive. In the other he held a spear. Winter spears ran long, thirty-five to forty feet, to reach the fish far below. When one rose to the decoy, he struck. In

winter, Kohl wrote, this was "almost the sole mode of catching fish."

But the winter days were short and the nights were long, and families spent those long evenings gathered by the fire. When the day's work was done and the dark came early, the families drew in around the flames, and the winter evening became the great season of stories.

Some stories belonged to winter and were told only in the cold months. And they were not always just for entertainment. Copway remembered that his people had a different set of valuable lessons and legendary tales for each season. "In the Fall we have one class," he wrote, "in the Winter another, and in the Spring a third," and the winter class was the largest. A single cycle could run the whole season. The doings of Wenabojo, the central figure of the old stories, took an entire winter to tell, Densmore was told, "the story being begun each evening where it was left the previous evening." A storyteller might begin in October and not finish until spring, telling a new part every night. Warren, who grew up to write his people's history, remembered where he had first heard it all. It was at the winter fireside, he wrote, "around whose lodge fires I have passed many a winter evening, listening with parted lips and open ears to their interesting and most forcibly told tales."

The children came for it. When the storytelling began, Copway wrote, the young would "lay down the bow and the arrow and joyously repair to the wigwam of the aged man of the village, who is always ready to accommodate the young." Copway never forgot the fascination of it. "Night after night for weeks have I sat and eagerly listened to these stories," he wrote. "The days following, the characters would haunt me at every step, and every moving leaf would seem to be a voice of a spirit." He called the legends "a vast fund of winter evening instruction and amusement," and said the fire-blaze of those evenings stayed "endeared to them in after years by a thousand happy recollections."



A kettle hung over the fire that was kept alive day and night through the winter.

The word instruction is the point. The winter fire was the community's school. The stories carried the people's history, their understanding of the spirit world, and their knowledge of the animals and the land, and they carried the rules a child was meant to live by.

The teaching was not only in the stories. It ran through the whole evening, in the plain talk of the old people, and it was done mostly by example and persuasion rather than by punishment. Copway's father taught him at that hour. "As soon as it was dark he would call me to his side and begin to talk," Copway wrote, and the talk was about how to live. "He believed in persuasion." A boy heard the same counsel again and again. "If you reverence the aged, many will be glad to hear of your name," his father told him, and he was to "never kill any game needlessly." "Such was his language," Copway wrote, "when we were alone in the woods." A father told his sons not to rob birds' nests, because, he said, "the birds were put here for the good of the earth." Nodinens remembered her mother teaching her to work, and remembered exactly how the lesson was pressed home. "Always be industrious," her mother said. "Get up early and do your work. Do you hear me?" As she said it, "she took hold of my ear and pulled it hard."

Some of the teaching was a game. On a winter evening the old people would set a pile of small presents in the middle of the wigwam and start the game of silence, and the child who stayed quiet longest won the pile. It kept a crowded lodge peaceful, and it taught a child to hold still and listen.

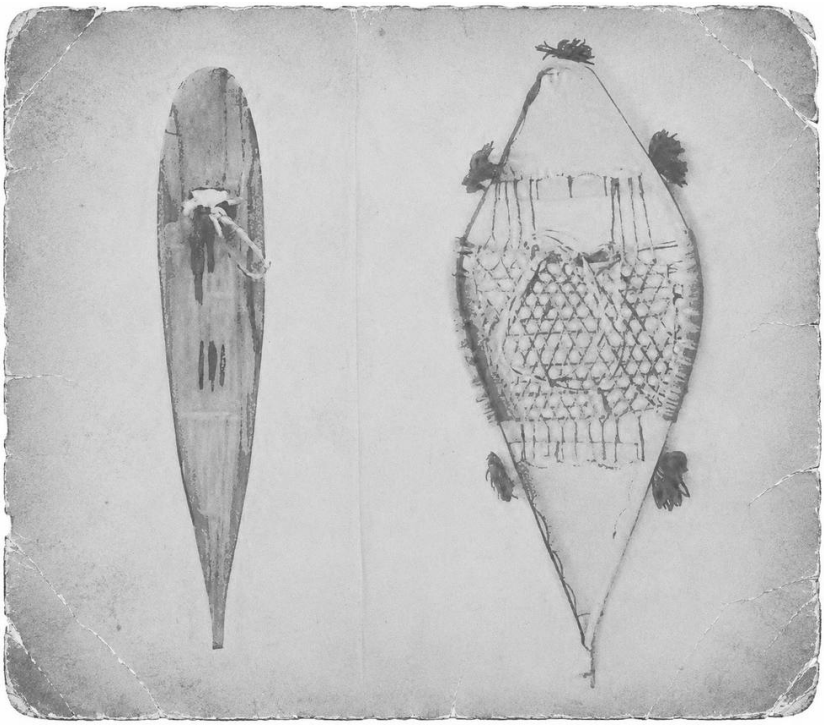
The most important lesson of all was sharing, and winter was the season that proved why. A hunt could fail. A family that kept its meat to itself in a hard winter might watch its neighbors starve, and be starved by them in turn. So the counsel the elders gave was direct. "When you kill a deer, or bear," they told the young, "never appropriate it to yourself alone, if others are in want." "Never pass by any indigent person without giving him something to eat." Food was pooled and divided as a matter of course. Where two families shared a fire, Jones wrote, "one family at each fire will cook at a time, and then divide the food with all belonging to the same fire." The sharing was the people's insurance against a bad year, and the winter fire was where a child first learned that it was not a kindness but a law.

So the winter nights were not empty. Through the long dark, by the fire, the old people handed down the stories, the manners, and the law, and the children took them in. But the stories could not fill the drying rack. That was the work of the day and the hunt, and in a hard winter, when the hunt failed, even the best-taught family came up against the hunger.

The Winter Hunt

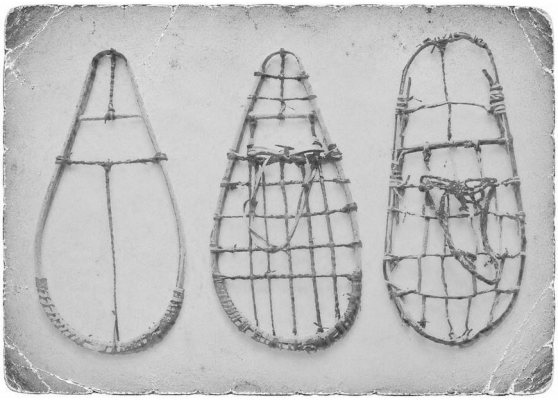


By day the men were out on the snow. The people called our February the Moon of Hard, or Crusted Snow, because by then the sun had glazed the snow with a crust. The crust changed the hunt. It would bear a man's weight, or a dog's, but not a deer's.



A snowshoe, the tool that let a hunter travel where the deer broke through the crust.

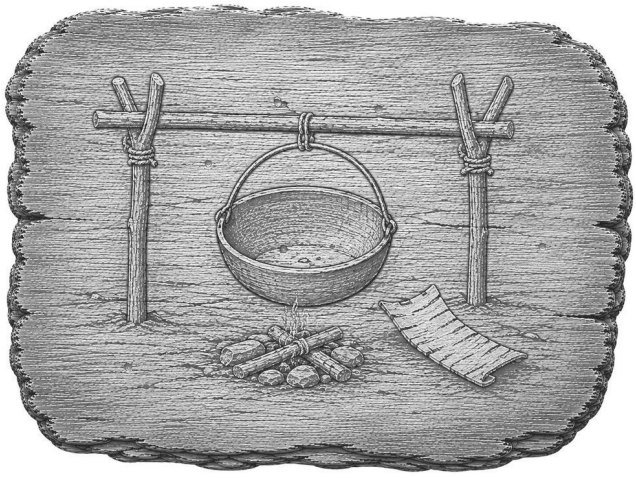
Alexander Henry, wintering with Wawatam's family, saw what that meant for the deer. "At this season," he wrote, "the stag is very successfully hunted, his feet breaking through at every step, and the crust upon the snow, cutting his legs, with its sharp edges, to the very bone." A hunter on wide snowshoes went where the deer floundered. Henry's family, in one such stretch, "killed twelve in the short space of two hours," and were soon "put into possession of four thousand weight of dried venison." The crust that cut the deer provided a bounty for the hunter.



Snowshoe frames, showing the bent-ash frame before its netting.

The success of a hunt depended on more than circumstance or luck: it required great skill. George Copway, the Ojibwe writer from Rice Lake in Canada, remembered hunting deer with his father on the river Trent by ear alone, in the dark. "The night was as dark as pitch," he wrote. They heard a deer moving and came near it, and the boy asked his father where to aim. The old man said, at the head or the neck. Copway fired at a sound he could not see, and when they found the animal he had "shot it just below the ear." Marksmanship like that, learned young and sharpened by need, fed a family through the winter. But the hunt also depended on the weather, and when the weather turned against them, even careful preparation offered only a narrow margin of safety.

The Hunger

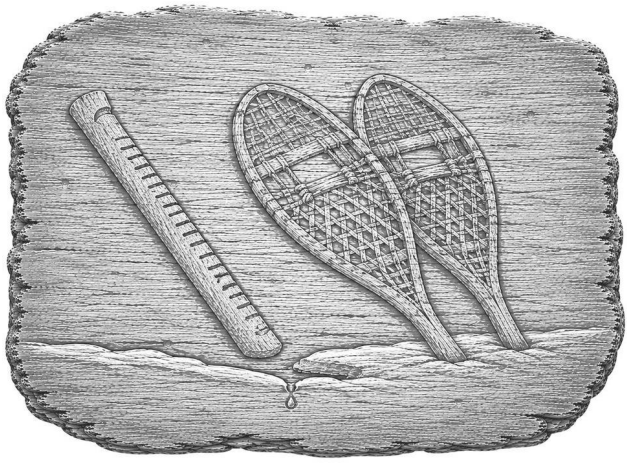


The winter hunt did not always feed the people. The last moon before the sap the people called the Hunger Moon, and in a hard year it earned the name. Weather is unpredictable and the best plans sometimes meet phenomena even the wisest cannot predict.

Copway lived through the narrow margin and wrote the hardest winter scene in any of these accounts. One fall his family and four others went up the river above Bellmont Lake to his father's hunting grounds, sixty miles from the nearest settlement. Deep in the winter the snow fell for days without stopping, so deep that no one could shoot or trap, and the food ran out. "The snow about five feet deep," he wrote, "our wigwam buried; the branches of the trees falling around us, and cracking from the weight of the snow." There was wood all around them and they were too weak to gather it. Here is what a starving winter camp ate when the stores and the weather both failed, in the words of a man who was a child in one: "Our mother boiled birch bark for my sister and myself, that we might not starve." When the birch bark was gone, "we parched beaver skins and old moccasins for food." The famine bark of the winter woods was not a figure of speech. It was a mother at a buried fire, boiling the bark of a tree and parching her old moccasins, so her children would live to morning.

Although her sacrifice did not go unnoticed, what saved Copway's family, it is said, was a dream. On the seventh day, with some of the party too weak to stand, Copway's father told him what he had seen in the night. As Copway set it down, in his father's voice, "this night in my dream I saw a person coming from the east, walking on the tops of the trees. He told me that we should obtain two beavers this morning about nine o'clock." Acting on the dream, and on the protecting spirit they believed had sent it, they went to a beaver lodge and set a gun tied to a stump, aimed at the air hole in the ice. The boy pulled the trigger string and killed a beaver, and then a second. The father said the Great Spirit had told him it would be so, and that they would see their relatives at Rice Lake again. They did. They reached home, Copway wrote, "just in time to save them from death." Copway was a Methodist convert by the time he wrote this, and the words he gives his father carry his own later faith. But the dream that told a hunter where the game would be, and the thanks that answered it, belonged to the older world he was born into, and in that world a winter hunter's dream was a kind of knowledge, taken as seriously as the tracks in the snow.

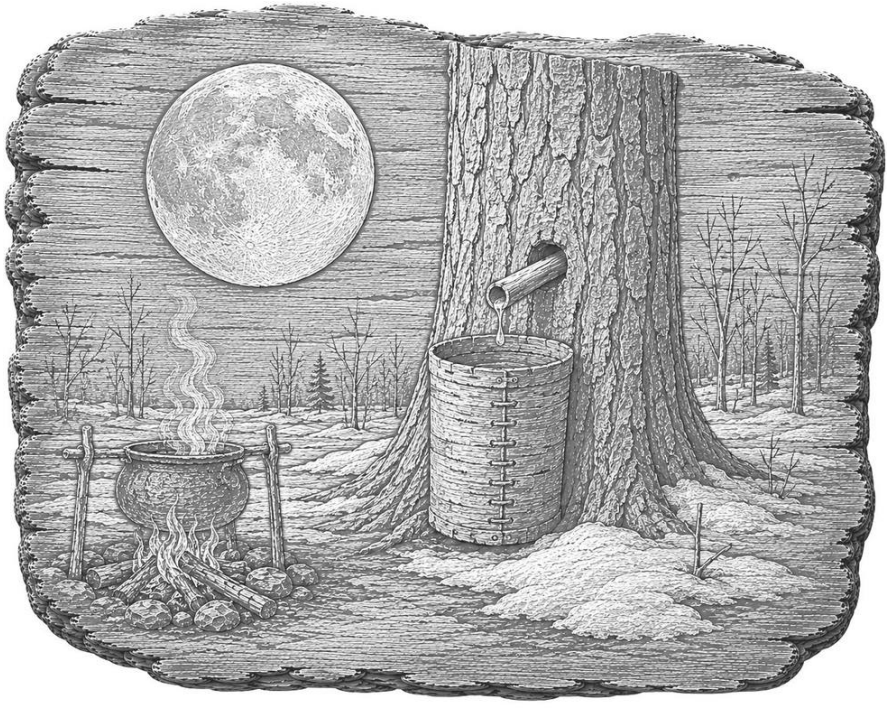
Winter's End



And then the snow began to recede. Nodinens remembered her father reading the turn off his counting stick and saying the words that turned the winter toward the spring. "One month after another month has gone by," he would tell them. "Spring is near and we must get back to our other work."

The family had come through the hunger. The meat was dried, the stories were told, and the gear was mended. It was time to pack the sleds and start off through the last snow. Ahead lay the sugar bush and the Sugar Moon, and the first made food of the new year.

Part Three: The Sugar Moon



The Sugar Moon Move



The wisdom of carrying a household across the last of the snow.

The people of the Great Lakes region did not stay in one place. A household moved as the year turned, from the winter game camp to the sugar bush, to the summer village on the lake shore, to the rice lakes, and back to the winter camp again, and the moving was itself a skill. There were two passages, and the time of year chose which route. "As the Chippewa lived along the lakes and watercourses," Frances Densmore wrote, "their summer transportation was by canoe, and in old times the winter transportation was by dog team and toboggan or sled." Water in the warm months, snow in the cold. The move out of the winter camp and across to the sugar bush, made while the snow still held, was a move on snow.

The lodge was built and at the end of the season it was vacated. A wigwam was a frame of bent poles under a skin of mats and bark, and when a family moved, the frame stayed where it stood. "The framework was left on a camp site," Densmore recorded, "and the coverings carried from place to place." A pole cut, bent, and lashed was a morning's work the woods would provide again at the next camp; the bulrush mats and the birch-bark rolls, made over many

days, were the part worth carrying. So the poles were pulled from their lashings and left leaning, and the covers were rolled.

The responsibility fell mostly on the women. Each woman carried two of the birch-bark roofing rolls and a girl carried one, and the mats went rolled with the blankets inside them. Nodinens, the before mentioned Mille Lac woman who gave her whole year to Densmore, remembered the packing exactly. "I carried half of the bulrush mats and my mother carried the other half. We rolled the blankets inside the mats; and if there was a little baby, my mother put it inside the roll, cradle board and all. It was a warm place and safe for the baby." The food that went was the food that weighed least: "We took only food that was light in weight, such as rice and dried berries, and we always took a bag of dried pumpkin flowers."

A person could not cross the spring snow on the bare foot. The moccasin was itself an innovation, cut and sewn to the foot with a bone awl and a thread of sinew, and over deep snow it needed the snowshoe. The snowshoe was a technology that made impassably deep snow a minor inconvenience. It was constructed from an ash frame bent by heat and strung with a net of rawhide, close-meshed for hard snow and open-meshed for soft, and the foot was bound to it in a way the German traveler Johann Kohl watched and set down better than anyone: the ball of the foot rode on a thong so the heel could rise and fall free, "the foot is fastened to the snow-shoe nearly in the same way as a piston with two arms," and the shoe "must not be lifted from the ground, but be dragged as gently as possible over it."

The snowshoe was also a thing a person had to be able to make on the spot. When a camp had to break in the middle of winter, everyone needed shoes at once, the girls and the children too, and a rough contrivance could be cut and laced from green branches in a night. Nodinens saw it done. "Once there was a fearful snowstorm when we were starting to go back," she said, "and my father quickly made snowshoes from the branches for all the older people." The snow named a moon for the wear it put on the netting: one late-winter moon was the Broken-Snowshoe Moon, for the crusted snow that cut the strings.

"Fire was the first and best tool that the Indians had," one of Densmore's people told her, and on a winter trail it was the difference between a night lived and a night not. Fire was raised in the old way by friction between a soft wood and a hard wood: a drill of ash spun on a hearth of cedar over a nest of shredded cedar bark to catch the spark, or two stones struck over the same tinder. (The flint and steel that many later carried was a trader's tool, and came after.) A person on the move invariably carried the required apparatus. John Tanner, taken as a boy and raised Ojibwe, learned "to kindle a fire by rubbing some dry cedar, which I was careful to carry always about me."

On the cold nights, once made, fire was not relit. In camp it was banked at night so it would last until morning, the men stoked it with dry wood, in Nodinens's words, "so it would smolder all night," and on the coldest nights an old person stayed awake to feed it. In the old understanding the fire in the lodge and the life in the body were held to be near the same thing, and the fire that died was not simply an inconvenience. A man alone on a winter trail relied on it for both protection and life-giving warmth: building a high bank of snow at his back against the wind and lying down between the snow and the flame.

On snow the load rode low. The toboggan was a plank or two of winter-cut hardwood, sapless and light, its front curled up by heat, and it is the one Ojibwe thing whose name the English language kept: nobigidaban, the flat drag. It "required only the width of a footpath," Densmore noted, "and its load was close to the ground, making it convenient in traveling through the woods," and a strap trailed from the back so the driver could hold it on a downgrade "to keep it from running on the dogs." Where the way ran over open lake ice a thin bent board eight feet long served as a sledge with no runners at all.

The one animal the people had trained to the work was the dog, harnessed to the toboggan for the winter move and carrying nothing in summer but itself, riding in the canoe with the family.

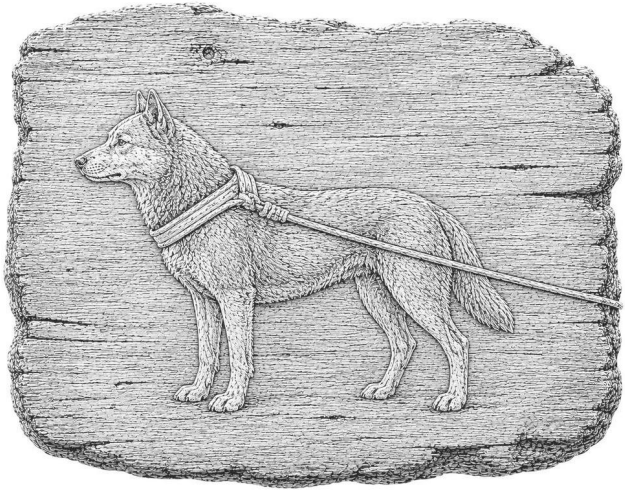
What the people did not have was the two-pole drag of the open country. Kohl looked for it and said plainly, "Among these forest

tribes, the Ojibbeways, I never saw any of these pole sledges." It was a horse's tool and a prairie's, made for a treeless land where a load must be dragged overland for want of a better road. These people had a better road. The forest was thick, and the country was laced with water, lake into stream into lake, much of it the beaver's own work, and a light bark canoe on that water carried more than any dragging poles could, at far less cost. Where there was water there was no reason to drag, and where there was snow there was the toboggan and the dog. The two pole travois were built for a country these people did not live in.

The moving family supplied itself as it went. It carried the light dried stores and took what the country gave, a snared rabbit, a partridge, and as the snow began to loosen it found the first green things, the curled fern and the wild leek, the first fresh food after a winter of dried meat and rice.

The whole family had set out, leaving only the frame of the old lodge behind. They carried with them the rolled mats, the fire, and the babies on the women's backs, while the dogs pulled toboggans laden with furs and dried meat. Nodinens remembered the going in the worst of it, the family starting off into a snowstorm to reach the sugar bush. At the far end the sugar camp was waiting, its tools stored from the year before and its cache of food in the ground ready to be opened, and the next work of the year could begin. By the time they reached the sugar bush, carrying their house, their fire, and their food across a hundred miles of snow, the people had already completed the year's first great labor.

The Dog



Of all the animals of the country, only one lived inside the circle of the people's camp as a matter of course, and it was the only animal they had ever tamed to their own use. The dog had been with them longer than any story reached back to say. It was not a gift of the traders or a creature of the treaty years. It had come into the country with the people themselves, in a time before the record begins, and it was theirs in a way nothing else on four legs was.

It earned its place with work. In winter it was the engine of the move. Three dogs made a team, harnessed in collars of flat rawhide wound so the edge would not cut, and they ran single file down a broken trail and could cover forty or fifty miles in a day. A good team drew a real load; Tanner, who lived much of his life among the people, said his dogs "were now so well trained that they could draw half a moose." The dog hauled the loaded toboggan across the last of the snow to the sugar bush, and in the open seasons it carried a pack on its own back and followed the hunt, and at all times it kept the camp, giving voice at the edge of the firelight when something moved in the dark.

It was more than a tool. An Ojibwe man told the traveler Kohl, plainly, what the dog was to them: "our domestic companion, our dearest and most useful animal." It lived among the family, and

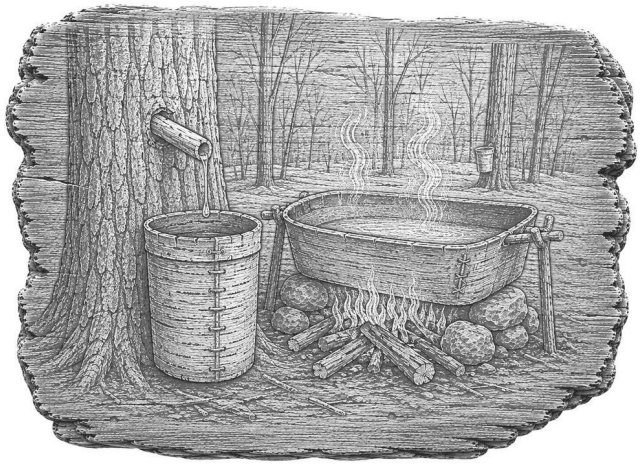
the young made favorites of the pups. A dog was fed and worked and known, and when it died it was mourned.

For that very reason, the dog was also the greatest thing the people could give. Of all the offerings a person could make to the powers, two were the most common, Kohl recorded: tobacco, which was strewn on every stone and grave and stretch of water that carried a holy meaning, and a dog. But where tobacco cost little, the dog cost much, and that was the whole point of it. "The dog is our domestic companion, our dearest and most useful animal," the same man told him. "It is almost like sacrificing ourselves." The bear was honored, and apologized to, and its bones were kept whole; but the bear was not given as a sacrifice, and neither were corn or flowers or things of that kind. Only the dog, the animal dearest to the people, was fit to stand in a man's place before the powers. The fall hunt has already shown one such gift, the dog given to the water at the river's mouth for a blessing on the winter's hunting. There was another at the other end of the year's danger: when a war party was ready to leave the village, its last act before the road was the dog feast. The head alone was eaten, and only by the men who were going, and to take that meal was to pledge oneself to meet the full fortune of war, death or worse, without turning back. The animal that pulled the sled and slept by the fire was the same animal a man ate to say that he was ready to die.

The dog was the only animal the people had made wholly their own, but it was not the only one they ever tamed. Kohl watched a canoe come in with a cage lashed on top of the load and two tamed falcons riding in it, and he was told the people often tamed falcons, and eagles and gulls and ravens besides. A wild creature taken young could be gentled and kept, and children kept such pets. But a tamed falcon was one bird gentled to one hand. It was not a kind of animal bred and carried down the generations the way the dog was. Between the wild animals, which were hunted and honored, and the one animal that was fully theirs, the people drew a clear line, and the dog stood alone on the near side of it.

So the dog held a place no other animal did. It worked beside the people every day of their lives, the one creature that had thrown in its lot with theirs, and precisely because it was the dearest and most useful of all the animals, it was the one they could give back when the debt they owed was greatest. The most valued companion of the camp and the most solemn of its sacrifices were the same animal.

The Sugar Bush



Spring began in the snow and was referred to as the ice-break-up moon. In the winter camp, when the cold had held for months and the game was thinning, Nodinens remembered her father reading the turn of the year off his notched stick and saying it plainly. "One month after another month has gone by," he would tell them. "Spring is near and we must get back to our other work." The other work was sugar. They wrapped the dried meat in tanned deerskin and packed the furs on sleds, and they left before the winter had fully let go. "We started off in the snowstorm," Nodinens said, "and went to the sugar bush."

The sugar bush was a place owned only in the spirit of tradition: the forest was considered adopted by a tribe when they returned to it each season the sap runs. Each group of relatives had its own portion of the maple forest, the same trees year after year, and Densmore, who wrote Nodinens's account down, recorded that the tools were left waiting between seasons. The birch-bark utensils "were stored from year to year in a small lodge, near the large lodge where the sap was boiled." A family came back in the late-winter snow to a camp that was already outfitted for the work. "When we got to the sugar bush," Nodinens said, "we took the birch-bark dishes out of the storage and the women began tapping the trees."



Boiling maple sap down to sugar over the fire, the all-night work of the sugar bush.

Warren, revealing the same season, described the division of it: the women in the sugar bushes among the maples, and the men scattered off in small bands after the furred animals whose pelts were finest in that season.

Then the boiling began, and it did not stop. "The sap kettles were kept boiling all night," Densmore wrote, "and the season was a busy one for all in the camp." It takes a great deal of sap to make a little sugar, and the Ojibwe had a story about why.



Tending the kettles among the maples.

Andrew Blackbird, the Odawa writer from the Michigan shore, set the story down as it was told. The trickster Wenabojo, who shaped much of the world and called the people his nephews, once tasted the sap of the maple and found it ran nearly pure syrup. "Ah, that is too cheap. It will not do," he said to himself. "My nephews will obtain this sugar too easily in the future time and the sugar will be worthless." And so, in Blackbird's telling, he diluted the sap with water "until he could not taste any sweetness therein," and said, "Now my nephews will have to labor hard to make the sugar out of this sap, and the sugar will be much more valuable to them in the future time." The all-night kettles were the labor the trickster had built into the tree. The sweetness was there, but it had to be revealed from the water by fire and a concentrated effort… and the story held that this was the point.

The making had its stages, and Densmore recorded them in order. The sap was boiled down to a thick syrup, strained, put back in the kettles, and heated slowly. When, through days of toil, it had thickened right it was worked in a wooden trough "with a paddle and with the hands until it was in the form of granulated sugar." If

they wanted hard sugar instead, the thick syrup was poured into molds to set, into "little birch-bark cones, dishes, or other receptacles, including the upper mandible of ducks' bills, which formed a favorite confection for children." A child of the sugar camp was given sweetness in the shape of a duck's bill, cast from the bird itself. It is the kind of detail that does not survive unless someone troubles to write it down, and fortunately someone did.



Cakes of hard maple sugar and a makuk filled with the same.

Near the sugar camp the winter met the spring, for that mixing of warmer days and freezing nights was the pump that kept the sap running, and it was a short season. A food cache had been laid down the previous fall and left buried through the cold, and now it was opened. Nodinens remembered what came out of it: "There were cedar-bark bags of rice and there were cranberries sewed in birch-bark makuks and long strings of dried potatoes and apples." While the women boiled sugar the men fished through the ice, and the women also took the inner bark of the cedar, which, she said, could only be gotten in the spring. The sugar camp was not only sugar. It was the first gathering place of the new year, where the last of the old year's stores were eaten and the first new work was done.

What all that labor produced was, in the Ojibwe kitchen, used in a way closer to salt than to candy. Maple sugar seasoned nearly everything. Densmore recorded that it went into "fruits, vegetables, cereals, and fish, being used more freely than the white race uses salt," that it was eaten plain as a confection, that it was

dissolved in cold water for a summer drink, and that it was mixed into concoctions to make the medicine go down, especially for children. A family's winter meals, months later and miles away, would carry the taste of these spring weeks. The sugar was packed into birch-bark makuks and stored and carried and traded. Blackbird, writing of his own people's travels, remembered the long bark canoes setting out loaded with sugar and furs and dressed skins.



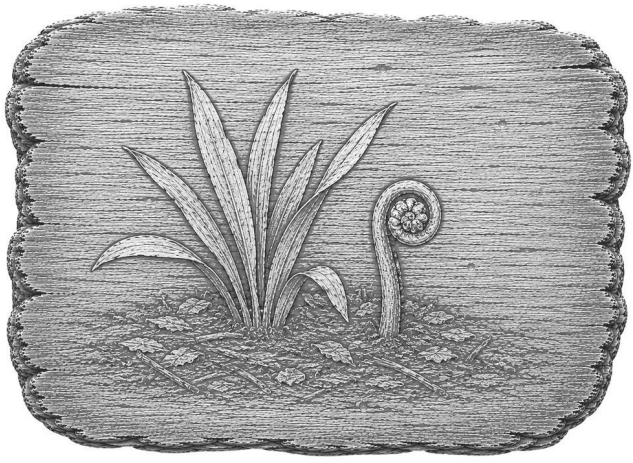
A birch-bark makuk, decorated and sewn, of the kind sugar was packed into.

The sugar season also opened the year's account with the spirits. There was a custom, Densmore noted, "which began with the season of making maple sugar and lasted throughout the industrial year," of offering a portion of the first fruit or the first game to manido. The family gave a feast, and the host "spoke to manido," asking for safety and health and long life, and everyone at the feast was given a little of the first fruit before the meal. "Some of this special food," she added, "was usually put on the graves." The first sweetness of the year was not eaten until a share of it had been set aside, for the spirits and for the dead.

And then, as the moon's phase transitioned, the sap run slowed. Toward the end, Nodinens remembered, there was a great deal of thick syrup that came from what they called "the last run of sap."

The trees stopped giving, the weather warmed, and the work of the sugar bush was done for another year. The dried meat and the last of the winter stores had carried the family through it, and the thick late syrup and the dried fish would feed them through the next stretch of the year, the weeks when they moved to the lake shore and turned the ground and made their gardens. The sugar was made and stored, the first fruits were offered, and the year turned green again.

The First Green



The sugar was the first made food of the new year. The first growing food came soon after it, when the ice went out and the ground began to green. All winter a family had eaten what it had dried and stored, much of it mixed in with a prior year's sugar harvest... and though a new crop of maple syrup was sustaining and delicious, there was something fresh again pushing up out of the wet spring ground, and the Ojibwe of the Wisconsin and Minnesota lakes knew where to look for it.

The first and best of the greens was the wild leek. It grew in the damp woods in broad flat leaves, and it was gathered in the spring, Smith was told, "when it is round and plumper than in the fall." The Ojibwe called it Wenabojo's onion, the plant the culture hero had "pointed out for food," and they knew it by its smell, which was the smell of a skunk. That smell left a mark on the map. The Ojibwe word for skunk, and for this plant, stands behind the name Chicago, though the name is usually traced through the neighboring Miami-Illinois word for the same skunk-scented plant. The leek itself was somewhat bitter; the smaller wild onion beside it was sweet. Both the Flambeau and the Pillager Ojibwe, Smith wrote, "like the Wild Onion and Wild Leek in the spring as an article of food." What was not eaten fresh was dried and kept, the way the rice and the sugar were kept.

After the leek came the ferns. In the spring the young fern shoots pushed up with their tops still coiled, and the coiled tips, Smith wrote, were "about like asparagus tips." The Flambeau gathered them for soup. First they threw the tips into hot water for an hour to drive out the ants that clung to them, then put them in the stock and thickened it with flour, and the flavor, Smith was told, "resembles wild rice." These were bracken ferns, not the ostrich fern fiddlehead of a modern menu, but the coiled young shoot was the part they ate.

The fern fed more than the soup pot: deer liked them too. It is recorded that a hunter stalking deer in the spring would eat nothing else but ferns, because the doe was feeding on the same young fronds and he wanted his breath to match hers. The truth of the tale may be that of legend or exaggeration; a hunter living today may verify the claim. However, Smith was told that a man living wholly on the fern "claims to be able to approach within twenty feet without disturbing the deer, from which distance he can easily make a fatal shot with his bow and arrow."

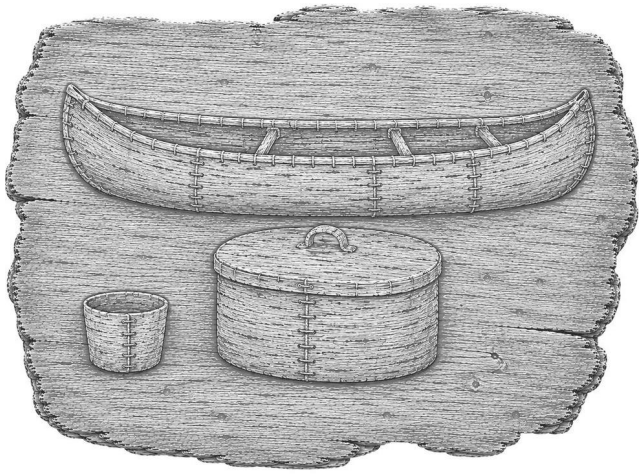
Other greens went into the same spring pots. The Flambeau cooked marsh marigold leaves with game. They cooked the flowers and young shoot tips of the milkweed with meat, where they turned soft and slippery like okra, and they dried milkweed flowers to drop into winter soup. The young leaves of the large-leaved aster were picked while they were still tender; the Flambeau said they were good to eat and good for a person at the same time, food and medicine in one leaf. There was even a food taken from the pine: in the spring the Ojibwe stewed the young catkins of the white pine with meat, and though a person might expect them to taste of pitch, Smith was assured they were sweet, with no pitchy flavor.

One spring green tied straight back to the sugar bush. When maple sap soured, it turned to vinegar, and the Flambeau dressed their greens with it, cooking young dandelion leaves with pork or venison and the soured-sap vinegar. Though still debated, the dandelion was a newcomer, a plant that had come with the Europeans, and so was the pork. Willing to adopt new foods (if not

new people) that entered their environment, here the people clearly demonstrated folding a new plant into an old habit... the spring gathering of fresh leaves. But the vinegar, whether made on purpose or discovered by accident, was made from the same sap that had run a few weeks before.

After a winter of dried meat and stored rice, the first greens were the first fresh, living food of the year, and several of them were taken as medicine as much as food. The ethnographers who wrote them down did not record the names of the women and children who did the gathering, but they named the plants and they named the season. When the leeks and the ferns came up, and winter's hardships began to fade into memory, the people were once again content, anticipating the season of plenty the next moon would bring.

The Vessels



Modern households depend upon hundreds of containers, yet we rarely notice them. Cupboards, drawers, baskets, bottles, jars, cans, buckets, refrigerators, and freezers quietly store, protect, preserve, and organize nearly everything we own. For the Anishinaabe, those same needs existed, but every container had to be fashioned from the materials the land provided.



A stand of birch, the tree whose bark made nearly every vessel a family used.

The maple sugar, the wild rice, the dried berries, the pounded meat, the water itself: all of it needed a container, and so did the family, which had to be carried from one camp to the next. The material that did most of this work was birch bark. It was light, it could be folded and sewn, and once its seams were sealed it held water. The people took it from the tree in the spring, when the bark, Densmore was told, was "most easily removed from the tree."



An open makuk, the folded and sewn bark box that held everything from sugar to rice.

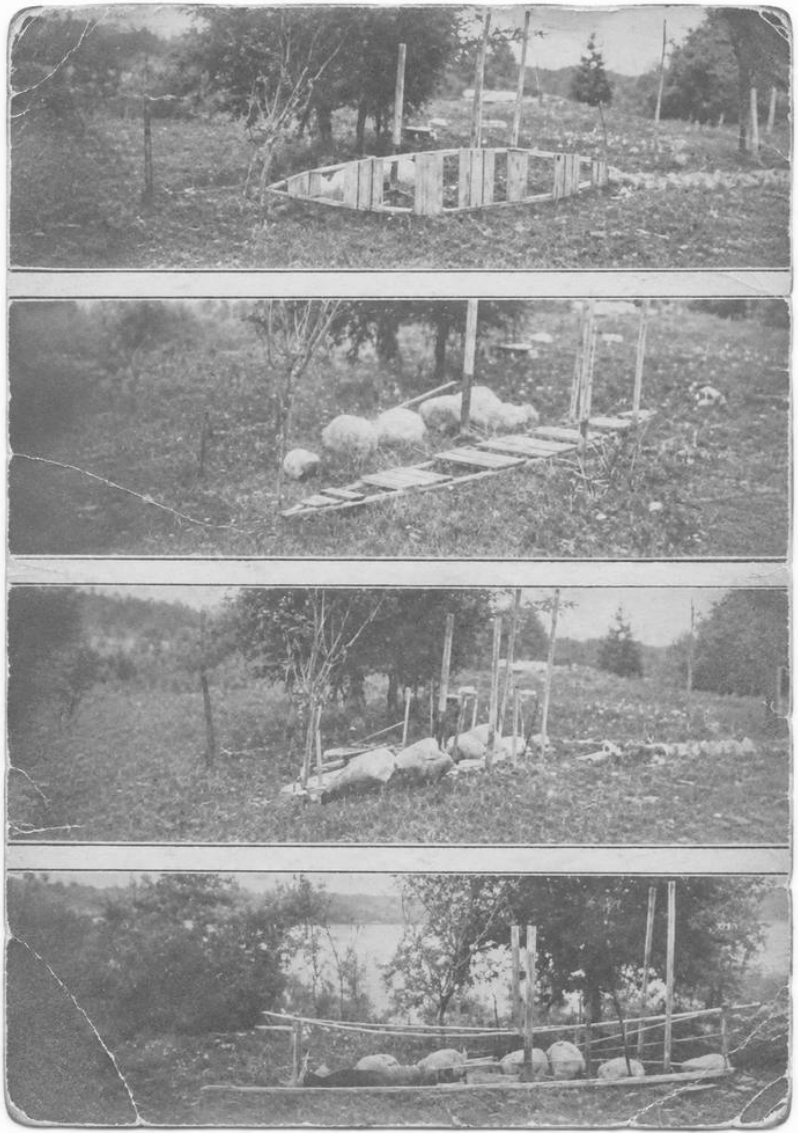
The commonest vessel was the makuk, the birch-bark box. It was made of bark folded and sewn at the corners with the inner bark of the basswood or with split spruce root, and a lid could be sewn on to close a full one. The makuk came in every size. "The makuk varied in size," Densmore wrote, "from those holding a small quantity of sugar to those holding 100 pounds or more." A small one held a child's portion of sugar; a large one held the winter's rice. Some were fitted with handles and used as buckets to carry sap. A berry-picker's makuk was made to hang from the belt, and she emptied it as she filled it into a larger one with the white bark left on the outside. A well-made makuk, washed and dried, lasted five or ten years.



Bark dishes and empty sugar cones, waiting to be filled.

Around the makuk was a whole family of smaller ware. There were shallow trays for winnowing rice and drying food; for these, Densmore noted, the women used "unsplit bark, sometimes comprising six layers, making them strong and not likely to leak." There were birch-bark dishes to catch the sap under the spile, and birch-bark cones of hard sugar for the children, "fastened together with strips of basswood bark so that the group resembled a cluster of berries." The sugar was also pressed into carved wooden molds cut "in shape of various animals, also of men, and of the moon and stars."

Not every vessel was bark. Broth, Densmore wrote, "was drunk from wooden bowls made from the knots of hardwood trees," which were hard and would not split. Spoons were carved of maple, or cut from birch bark, or made from a clamshell. The tool behind the wooden ware was the crooked knife, the same bent blade a hunter used on his bow and arrows, pulled toward the hand to hollow a bowl or shape a paddle. The bark vessels were made watertight with pitch. Smith watched it done: "The vessels are rendered waterproof by the application of pitch secured by boiling Jack Pine cones." A cracked seam on the trail was mended with balsam gum.



The stages of building a birch-bark canoe.

The greatest of the bark vessels was the canoe. Its hull was birch bark, stretched over a frame of cedar ribs and thwarts, sewn with split spruce root, and sealed at every seam with pitch. The bark for it was cut in the early spring, when it came away from the tree most easily. It was said that Wenabojo had taught the people to make the canoe, and a good maker was, in Densmore's word,

"highly respected," for the craft "must be learned by observation and experience." A canoe was light for its size. A boat that would carry four or five people, the Mississauga writer Peter Jones said, "can be borne on the shoulder of one man," and on a portage the maker tied the paddles to the thwarts and carried the whole hull over his head.



A finished birch-bark canoe.

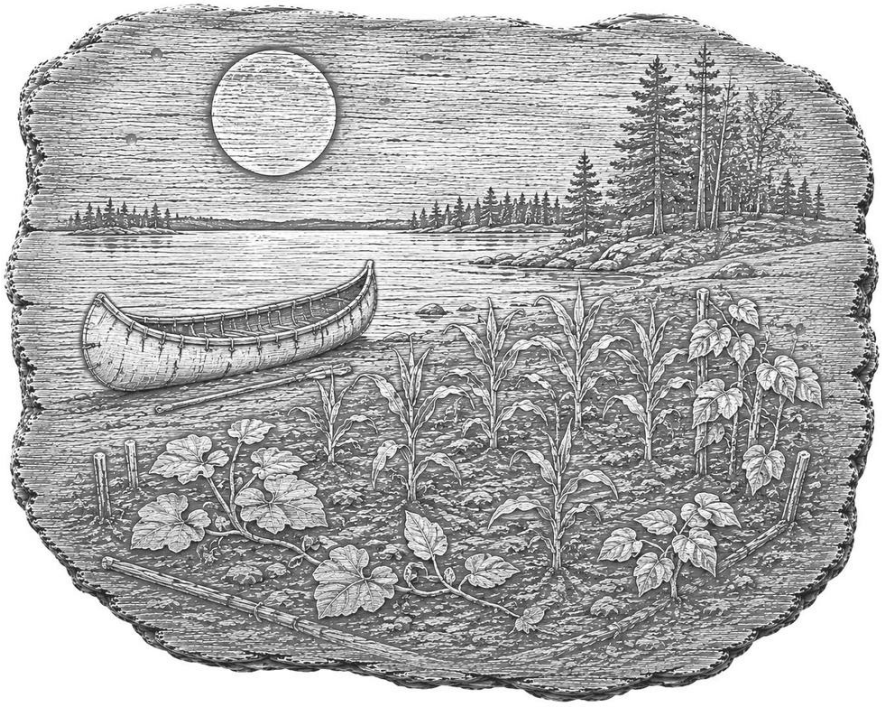
Loaded, the canoe was the family's moving house. "In loading such a canoe," Densmore wrote, "the bottom was first loaded heavily and then the children alternated with the bags of clothing and household equipment in the middle of the canoe. There were always two paddles, one for the man who sat in the front and the other for the woman who sat in the stern." Kohl watched one such family land in the Apostle Islands after seven days and a hundred and fifty miles of water. The wife sat "buried beneath a pile of parcels and boxes. Among them lay a dog, with three pups, and on the top of all the plunder was a large cage, with two tamed falcons in it. The gunwale of the boat was only a few inches above the water." Out of it came a makuk of maple sugar for the grandmother, a bag of dried venison, and bales of deer and beaver skins, all of it brought over portages and rapids, Kohl wrote, "in a dry and healthy condition."



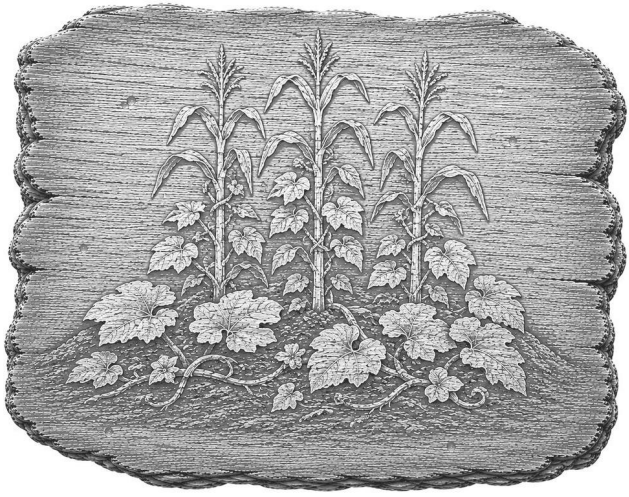
A birch-bark canoe drawn up at the shore.

It was nearly all one material. The same birch bark that was folded into a cup for a child's sugar was stretched into the hull that carried a whole family and its winter's food across the lakes. From the smallest vessel to the largest, birch bark held, protected, preserved, and carried nearly everything a family living from the land depended on.

Part Four: The Flower Moon



The Gardens and the time of Plenty



With the coming of the warm moons, the people gathered once again. During the winter they had lived in small hunting camps deep in the woods, and they remained divided while making maple sugar in the spring. But as the Flower Moon gave way to the berry moons, families returned to the lake shores to plant, gathering once more into their summer villages.

It may be observed that no one owned the earth they utilized…only through practicality was the land divided, and the concept of ownership was a feature of colonialism. During the times we speak of the land was vast and unbroken and the creator provided everything the people wanted or needed: ownership was an abstraction the Indigenous people did not embrace.

At Arbor Croche, on the Michigan shore of Lake Michigan, the Odawa lived on the lake only for this time. Andrew Blackbird, who grew up there, put it plainly: "All the Indians of Arbor Croche used only to stay there during the summer time, to plant their corn, potatoes, and other vegetables." When the crops were in the ground the summer village was a settled place, spread along the water, each family with its own patch of worked earth.

Nodinens remembered the same arrangement far to the west at Mille Lac, where each family had a bark house along the lake shore and its own garden beside it. They planted their crops, and when the planting was done the work was given over to the spirits and to a straw figure. The Midewiwin, she recalled, "made a feast, and asked the Mide manido to bless the garden," and then, she said, "a scarecrow made of straw was always put in a garden." The blessing and the scarecrow did the same work by different means, and both were set out and the corn was left to grow.

What the summer poured forth from the gardens, Blackbird remembered from his boyhood as sheer abundance. Sixty years back, he wrote, the Arbor Croche country was mostly grassy plain, and it carried "such an abundance of wild strawberries, raspberries and blackberries that they fairly perfumed the air of the whole coast with fragrant scent of ripe fruit. The wild pigeons and every variety of feathered songsters filled all the groves, warbling their songs with seeming joy and feasting upon these wild fruits of nature." "I never knew my people to want for anything to eat or to wear," he wrote of those summers, "as we always had plenty of wild meat and plenty of fish, corn, vegetables, and wild fruits."

The passenger pigeons that came over in summer flocks were another of the season's foods, taken in nets raised on poles.

The berries marked the passing weeks. The Ojibwe measured the summer moons by the fruit that ripened in them, and Peter Jones, the Credit River minister, set the names down: the Strawberry Moon of June, the Raspberry Moon of July, the Huckleberry Moon of August. The woods and shores, Jones wrote, held "blackberries, huckleberries, strawberries, raspberries, gooseberries, black currants, wild grapes, and marsh cranberries," and the women picked them as they came ripe and dried them for the cold months. Nodinens remembered gathering them and putting them "in bags for winter use." Some of the summer's sweetness was eaten warm off the bush, and some was carried forward, in a bag, to a winter camp months away and hundreds of miles inland.

In a rather straightforward manner, summer was the season that winter's existence was predicated upon. William Warren, in the diction of his century, called it the women's time of rest, and then in the same breath named the work of that rest: the making of "lodge coverings and mats for use during the coming winter, and in picking and drying berries." The mats that would wall the winter wigwam, the bark bags that would hold the winter food, the dried berries themselves, all of it was summer's work against the cold to come. The rest Warren saw was a season of steady making, and the people doing the making were mostly the women.

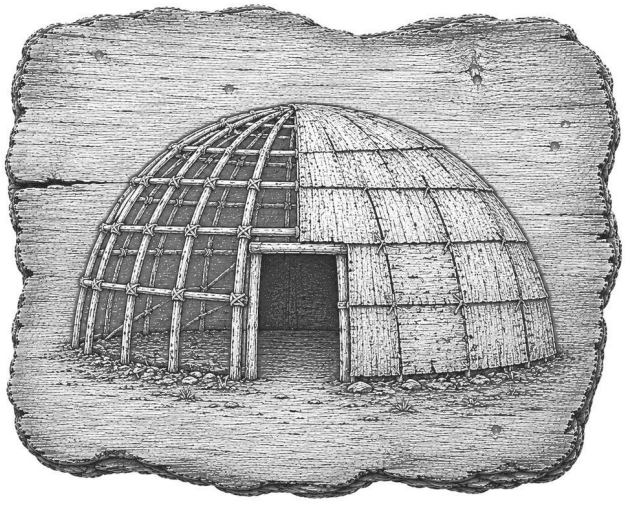
Because the village was settled and close for these months, summer was also when the young were taught and the camp took its ease. In his father's great summer lodge, sixty or seventy feet long, grown people even came to learn the alphabet he had made for their language. The boys had the long days for their games, the ball game the Odawa called Paw-kaw-do-way, foot races, wrestling, shooting at marks. And on the warm nights nobody stayed inside. In summer, Nodinens said simply, "we frequently slept in the open."

Being gathered was itself one of the summer's uses. Through the cold months the bands had been scattered across a hundred miles of hunting country, and only in the warm months were they all in one place. So the summer carried the work that a whole people could do only together. It was the season of the Midewiwin, whose ceremonies needed the community present; the season when the leaders held their councils; and the season when young people who had wintered far apart met, courted, and married.

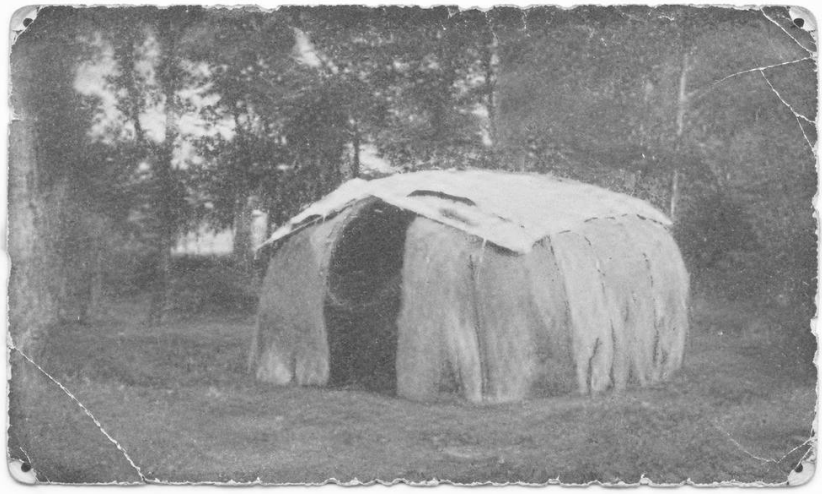
As the moon cycle progressed, the gardens became ripe. The corn and the potatoes and the pumpkins that had been planted in the spring and blessed and guarded by the straw figure were gathered in, and the berries were dried and bagged, and the summer's plenty began to turn into the winter's store. Blackbird's people dried their corn by fire, beat it from the cob, winnowed it, and sealed it away in a cylinder of elm bark set deep in the ground, to keep, as he said, "for winter and summer use." The season of gathering-together and growing was closing, and ahead lay the

hardest work of the year and the longest journey, when the whole village would move to the rice lakes for the fall. But that was still to come. For now the nets floated with whitefish, the coast smelled of ripe fruit, and nature's abundance always provided enough for the people who lived in harmony with the land.

Bark, Mat, and Lodge

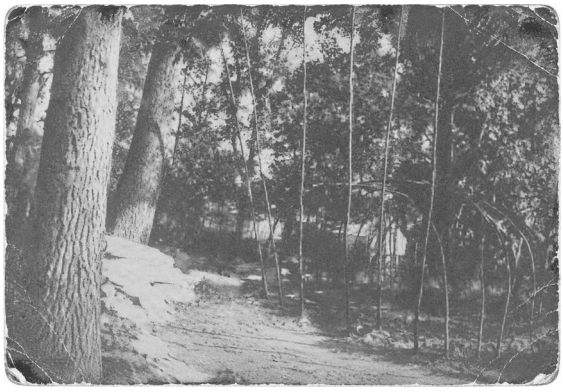


A family did not carry its house from camp to camp. It carried the covering and left the frame standing. The poles of a lodge were cut, bent, and lashed once and then used for years; when the family moved on with the season, it stripped off the mats and the bark, rolled them up, and took them along, leaving the bare frame in the clearing until it came back. "The framework was left on a camp site," Densmore wrote, "and the coverings carried from place to place." A house was really two things: the frame, which stayed, and the covering, which went along with the people.



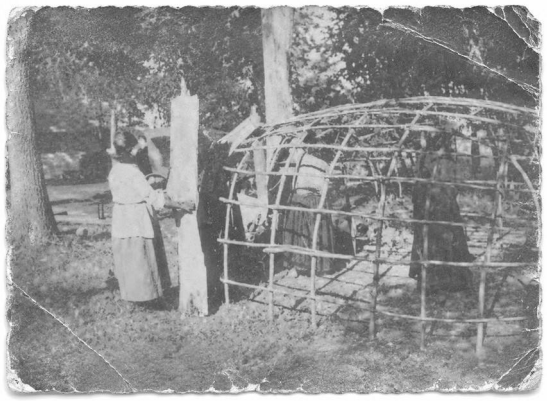
A bark-covered dome wigwam, the true home of the Great Lakes people.

Among the Anishinaabe the commonest house was the wigwam, a dome of bent poles. A worker planted a ring of ironwood poles in the ground, bent them over, and twisted and lashed them together overhead, tying every crossing "with freshly cut strips of the inner bark of the basswood tree." Two hoops of pole ran around the dome to hold its shape, and a smoke hole was left open at the top. The lower walls were hung with woven mats, and the roof was covered with long rolls of birch bark, "commonly about 10 or 12 feet long." It was a warm house. For winter, Densmore noted, "a second row of mats was frequently placed around the entire lodge, overlapping the first."



The bent-pole frame of a wigwam, left standing when a family carried off its covering.

Densmore watched a wigwam raised at Mille Lac one June, and the constructing of it was shared work but predominately a women's task. A woman soaked yard-long strips of basswood bark in a pail, split them into ribbons half an inch wide, and tucked the ribbons into a cord at her waist so the loops stood ready to hand. A man drove each pole into the ground and bent it down over her head, and she tied it fast. "All the work was done by women," Densmore wrote, "except that of driving the poles in the ground, bending them down, and holding them in position while they were tied in place."



Raising a wigwam: the poles driven and bent while the covering is tied on.

The mats that made the walls were a craft of their own. They were woven of cattail or bulrush gathered from the marsh, and the

reeds could be cut only at one time of the year, when they were ripe. The reeds were boiled, bleached, and sometimes dyed, then woven on an upright frame with basswood twine. The weaving could be done only while the reeds were damp, because dry reeds cracked, so the work was done in a dim, damp lodge kept for the purpose, or outdoors in the wet of early morning and evening. Kohl once boarded with a mat-maker and watched her keep her reeds soft with the dew. "Every night she laid her work out in the dew," he wrote. "The next morning she brought it in, and plaited a bit more, till the sun rose too high."



A lodge on the summer ground.

The roof was made of rolls of birch bark. Several large sheets of bark were sewn edge to edge with cedar bast into a long panel, "resembling," Kohl wrote, "the cloth in our tailors' shops," with a thin lath sewn along each end so the panel could be rolled up without tearing and carried like a bolt of cloth. A roll of bark was light. It was, Densmore noted, "often more convenient" for the women to carry a few bark rolls to a temporary camp "than to take time for gathering the heavy sheets of elm or cedar bark" for a house they would use only a few weeks.



Weaving, a summer craft done while the reeds were still damp.

Making and mending these coverings was summer work, because summer was when the materials could be gathered. Birch bark peeled cleanly from the tree in the warm months, and the reeds ripened in late summer. So it was at the summer village, before the moving season came round again, that a family made new mats and bark rolls and mended the old. The dome wigwam and the long bark-roofed lodge, not the Plains tipi, were the true homes of the Great Lakes region's Indigenous. The tipi, Densmore was told, the Chippewa "probably adopted from the Sioux," and it was never the emblem here that popular pictures have since made it.

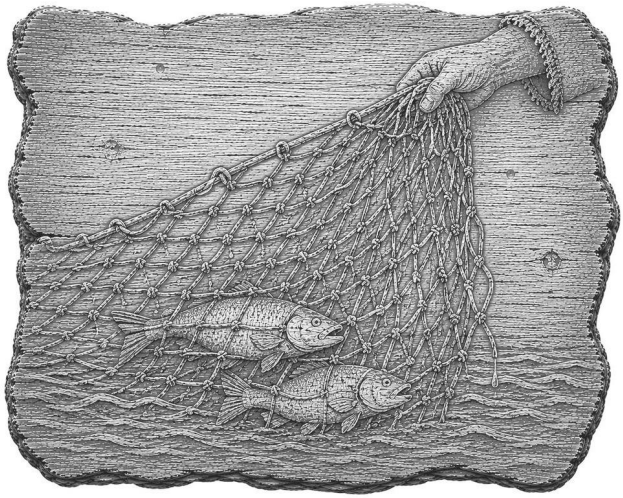


Mats and coverings at the lodge.

Inside, a family kept its order. "The one unfailing rule," Densmore recorded, "was that the youngest persons should live in the middle of the lodge, where they must pass their elders in entering or

leaving." The point, presumably, was to remind the young, every time they came and went, to give way to their elders. Beds of cedar boughs and rush mats lined the walls, spread with blankets and hides at night and, in the day, "rolled up and used as seats." And when the season turned and it was time to move to the rice camp, the family took the house apart the way it had put it together: the mats unhung, the bark unrolled and rolled again, the whole covering loaded into the canoe. Only the frame stayed behind, a ring of bare poles in the clearing, standing empty until the family came back and covered it once more.

Nets and the Catch



The most promising contrivance of the summer was the net. It was set in the evening and lifted at dawn, and it always came up full. Today it is hard to imagine a full net in a river such as the Credit, in the unfortunately named city of Mississauga, Ontario. A Mississauga person would not recognize the land named after his nation, and he would be warned off from eating any fish that lived in its waters. This river, like all rivers in the Great Lakes region, suffered a habitat loss as total and as tragic as the loss of the Indigenous people who made this place their home. But just a few generations before, the earth's arteries flowed clean and abundant, and nets were the tool of choice to reap nature's embarrassment of riches.

Andrew Blackbird, remembering the harbor of his Odawa boyhood, wrote that the fish there were so thick that when you raised the anchor stone in the morning "your net would be so loaded with delicious whitefish as to fairly float with all its weight of the sinkers," and along the line of it "you see the fins of the fishes sticking out of the water in every way." The net was the work of the women. "Fishing, except in the coldest winter," Densmore wrote, "was the work of the women, who placed the nets in the water at night and took them up in the early morning, spreading

and drying them." Every camp had its spreading pole and its row of drying stakes.



Fish nets set by the women, spread and dried after the night's fishing.

The net itself was made by hand from plant fiber. The people twisted it from the inner bark of the basswood and the cedar and from the stalk of the nettle, which made the finest and strongest cord. Wooden floats held the top edge up, and stones tied on basswood line held the bottom down. A net was cleaned after every use, and sometimes soaked in a broth of sumac leaves to take the fish smell out of it, because it was said that a fish would not go near a net that carried the odor.

The largest fish were not netted but speared, and the best time for it was a summer night. A man fixed a torch of blazing birch bark in the bow of his canoe, and the light "made the water transparent to a great depth," so that he could see a fish well below him while the fish could not see him behind the glare. Kohl watched the Ojibwe strike fish fifteen feet down by torchlight. They called it wasswewin, fishing by light, and so many canoes carried their torches out on some lakes at night that the lakes took their names from it. One was Wag-im-ing, the Lake of Torches.



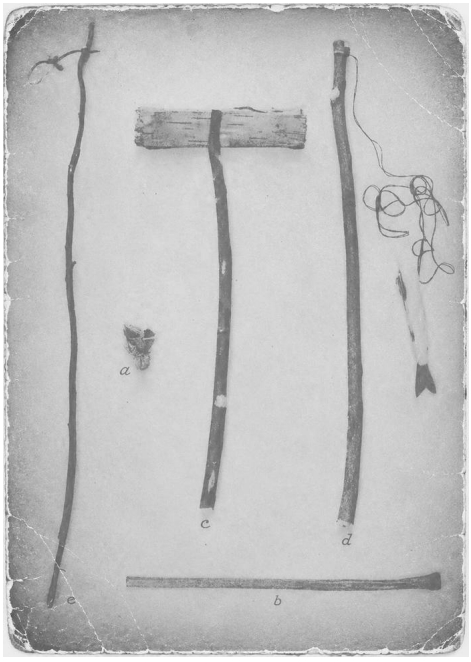
Nets drying on stakes and poles by the water.

The biggest fish of all was the sturgeon, "the king of fish" in the old stories; a fish five or six feet long was only a medium size for it, and it was taken at the spring run by a work of engineering. Mrs. Mary Warren English remembered it from her childhood on Lake Superior. "In the spring, as soon as the ice went out, the sturgeon... came from Lake Superior and went up these rivers," she told Densmore. "In order to catch them as they returned to the lake the Indians constructed a framework across the river," and strung it with basswood cord "back and forth until it formed a stout netting through which the fish could not pass. When the fish came down the river the Indians, seated on the framework, caught them with hooks and killed them with clubs."

The rivers gave up more than the lakes did. Every fall the Atlantic salmon ran up the rivers of Lake Ontario in numbers that are hard to picture now, the Credit and the Humber and a dozen others, and the Mississauga who lived along them took the fish as they came. The runs were thick enough to feed more than people. Bears came down to the water to fish the shallows, the way they still do on the salmon rivers of the Pacific coast.

What was not eaten fresh was dried. A fish was split down to the backbone, hung over a rail, and dried on a rack over a slow fire or strung on a line of bark in the sun, and it was packed away without salt, which the people did not have. For winter the fish were frozen whole and stacked. And there was a delicacy: fish partly dried, boned, pounded soft, and mixed with new maple sugar, packed

into a makuk. On these lakes, Kohl noted, people even sprinkled maple sugar over their boiled whitefish.



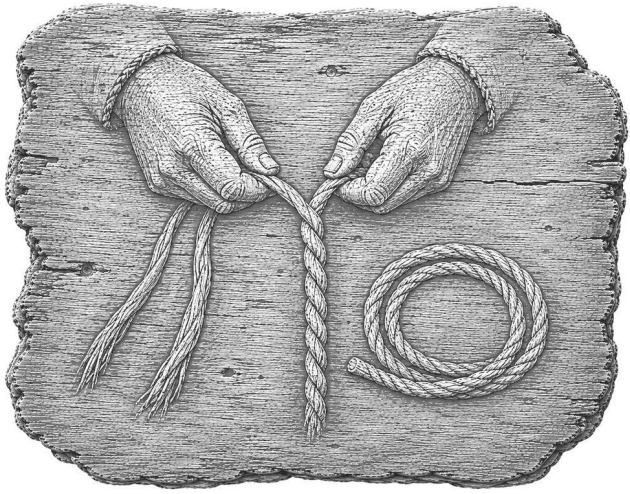
A basswood-loop partridge noose, and a packet of medicine used to draw fish to the net.

The net took more than fish. In spring, when the passenger pigeons came over in flocks, the men set the same nets up on poles to catch them out of the air. "They came in flocks," Nodinens remembered, "and the men put up long fish nets on poles, just the same as in the water, and caught the pigeons in that way. We boiled them with potatoes and with meat." Smaller birds were taken by hand. A boy could catch a partridge with nothing but a loop of basswood fiber on the end of a stick, for the bird, Densmore was told, was so unwary that it would sit on its branch while the boy reached up and dropped the noose over its head. Ducks were shot with blunt arrows.

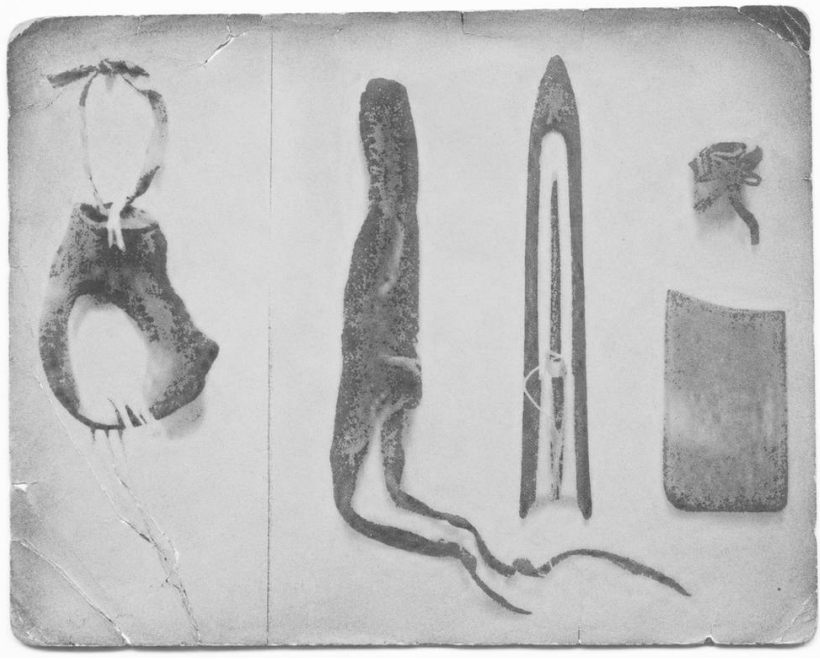
The pigeon net and the fish net were the same. One tool took the harvest of the water and of the air. Now the water can no longer fill a net, and the fish in it are poisoned with toxins; the air is not much cleaner, and is increasingly devoid of life. The passenger

pigeon that once came over in those spring flocks was hunted to extinction within Nodinens's own lifetime, the last of the species dead by 1914, some years before she sat and described how her people had caught them. The sturgeon is endangered in all its former waters, the Atlantic salmon is gone from Lake Ontario, and the people and the bears too have been pushed to the margins. That life, which the Great Lakes region's Indigenous surely believed would provide sustenance for endless generations to come, is gone.

Cordage



Behind nearly every technology in this book is a piece of string. The net that took the fish, the mats that walled the lodge, the poles lashed into a wigwam, the lids sewn onto the full makuks, the sheaves of standing rice tied off before the harvest, the bowstring, the snare, the cradle lacing: none of it held together without cord, and all of the cord was made by hand. "One of the most important articles in the economic life of the Chippewa," Densmore wrote, "was the twine made from the fiber that lies between the bark and the wood of the basswood tree."



The pelvic bone of a bear, worn smooth from drawing fiber through it to soften cord.

The basswood's strength and versatility combined with its abundance made it the tree of choice. In summer, when the sap was up and the bark peeled easily, a woman cut into a tree as high as she could reach, ran the cut down to the ground, and pulled the bark off in a sheet. The sheets were cut into strips and sunk among the reeds at the lake edge to soak, or ret, for about ten days, until the rough outer bark loosened. "The rough outer bark was easily detached," Densmore wrote of the strips lifted dripping from the water, "and the soft yellow fiber or inner bark heaped in the bottom of the boat." To loosen the fiber further, the strips were drawn back and forth through a hole worn in the pelvic bone of a bear, work that "in old times, was usually done by children."



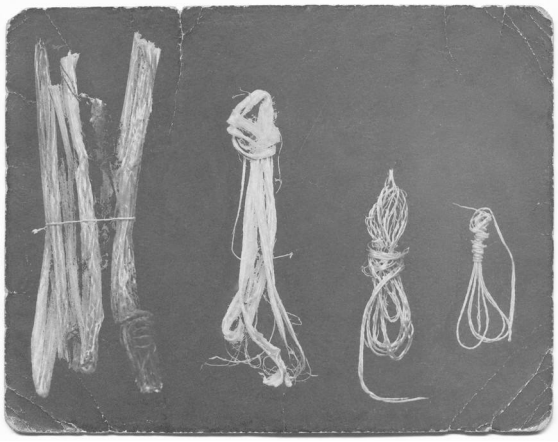
Gathering and stripping the inner bark that made the everyday cordage.



Preparing fiber for twine.

Then the fiber was spun into cord, and it was spun on the maker's own leg. The method was the same everywhere it was seen. A woman took two lengths of fiber, held them a few inches apart against her bare shin, and slid the flat of her other hand back and forth over them until they twisted together into a single cord. At the end of each yard she combed the fibers out with her fingers, added two fresh lengths, and spliced them in so smoothly that the join could not be found. Densmore watched it done on the bare leg above the knee and called it "dexterous and surprisingly rapid." A woman could make a great deal of cord this way in an evening.

One ball of basswood twine, it was said, was enough to tie up a whole canoe-load of rice.



A fiber stalk and the coarse and fine twine twisted from it.

Basswood was the everyday cord, but it was not the only one. The fiber of the nettle, taken from stalks left to dry standing in the field, made a finer and stronger thread, "as important as basswood bark to the industries of Chippewa women," and the best of it was woven into cloth. The oldest twine of all, it was said, was made from the outer skin of the bulrush, two strands twisted into a cord and two cords into a small rope. The strongest was dogbane, gathered in the fall, "one of the strongest native fibers, stronger even than the cultivated hemp." Deer sinew, split fine and rolled between the lips, made the cord for a bowstring or for fine sewing.



Winding a woven belt, the thumb used as a hook.



Yarn woven on upright sticks in geometric patterns.

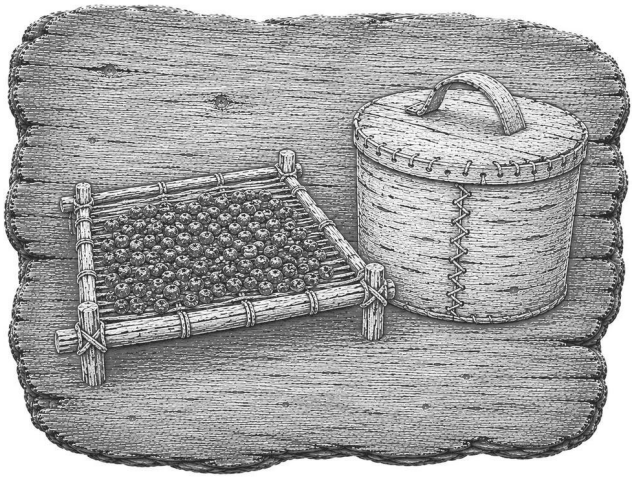
From these threads came everything that had to be tied, sewn, netted, or woven. The same basswood twine that lashed the wigwam poles was the crosswise thread of the reed mats, passed between the hanging rushes a strand at a time. It sewed the tops onto rice bags and the covers onto makuks. It had a quiet virtue for lashing, because wet basswood bark shrinks as it dries, so a binding tied wet pulled itself into an ever tighter joint. The finest fibers were finger-woven, without a loom, into bags and sashes, the warp strung and the weft worked through by hand. And for a small job, to tie a packet or a bundle, a woman simply wet a strip of bark by drawing it between her lips, and tied it off.



Weaving a mat on an upright frame with basswood twine, the cord that held so much together.

It was the humblest craft in the camp, and the one that was most utilized in daily life. A net is only knots in a line of cord; a mat is only cord and reed; a lashed lodge is only poles and cord. Almost everything the people made, they made with string, and almost all of that string was made the same way: two fibers at a time, rolled down the length of a woman's leg, a yard, and then another yard, and then another. The uses for it were inexhaustible, the making recurrent, and it was essential to everyday living in the Great Lakes region.

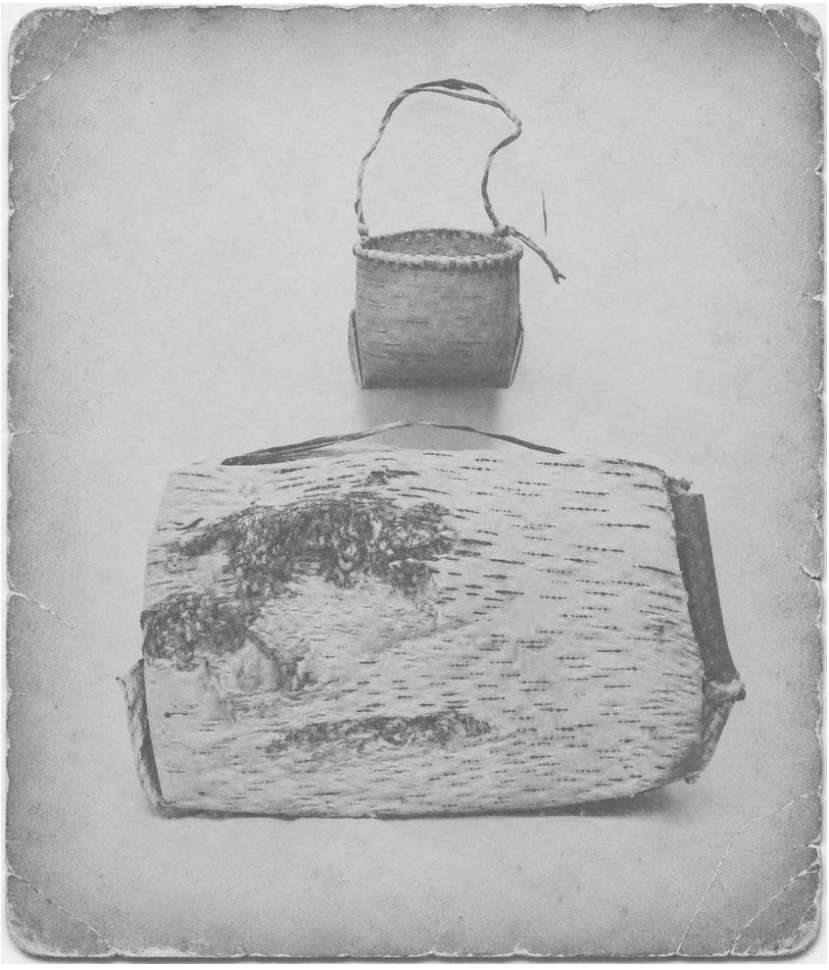
Keeping the Summer



The people marked the cycles of summer by what fruit was ready to harvest. The Strawberry Moon came first, then the Raspberry Moon, then the moon of the blueberries, each named for what ripened in it. The women went out with birch-bark baskets made to hang from the belt, larger at the top so the berries could go in fast, and emptied them into a great makuk with the white bark left on the outside. But fresh fruit does not keep, and the majority of it was not eaten fresh. The summer's sweetness was worth having in the winter, and so a large portion of it was incorporated into winter supplies.

Most berries were simply dried. "Blueberries, chokecherries, and June berries were always dried whole," Densmore wrote, "on frames made of slender reeds." Drying shrank them hard: "Four makuks of fresh berries usually made one makuk of dried berries." A dried berry was boiled soft again when it was wanted, and eaten with maple sugar or cooked into meat. The chokecherry, small and stony, was "pounded, stones and all," as Densmore records, and dried into cakes. Crushing the stones was the whole point. A chokecherry pit holds a cyanide-bearing compound, and pounding the fruit whole released that poison as a gas, which the long drying then carried off into the air, leaving the cake both safe and

keeping. Today we can name the chemistry; the people did not need to. That the method worked was all that mattered when a family lived solely on what nature provided.

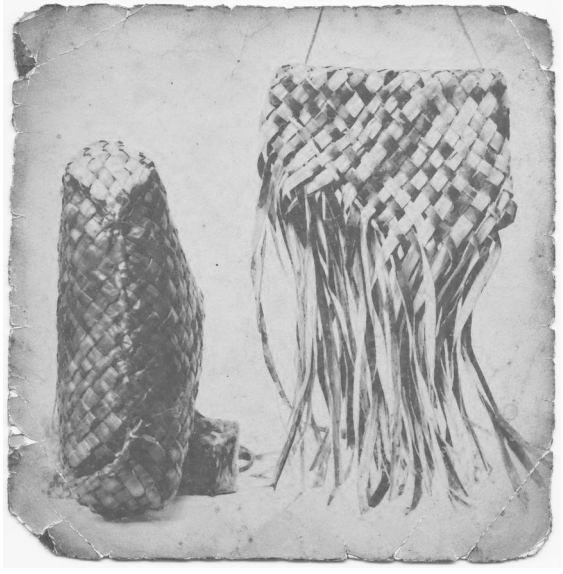


A birch-bark makuk of the kind berries were gathered and dried in.

The softest fruit was made into cakes. Raspberries were "boiled down" to a thick paste, spread in little patches on sheets of birch bark, and set in the sun until the water was gone, and then the cakes were "piled one upon another and tied in packets." Kohl watched the same thing done with wild plums, boiled and stirred thick and spread "for the thickness of an inch" on a sheet of bark to dry into "a tough, leathery substance, which they roll up and

pack in their makuks." Packed away in the ground, he wrote, it "keeps sweet a long time, and in winter they cut off pieces, which they boil with dried meat."

The oak gave a harvest that also took real skill to make edible. The acorn was once a staple; every Ojibwe Smith spoke to "told of their former dependence upon acorns for their soup stock." But most acorns are bitter with tannin and cannot be eaten as they are, and the people had a way of washing the bitterness out. They boiled wood ashes in water to make lye, put a quantity of acorns into a woven bark bag, and leached the tannin out by "washing the whole bagful in several changes of warm water." The acorns were then dried, and later pounded and ground into a meal that was boiled into mush and sweetened with maple sugar. Some oaks were kinder than others: the white oak's acorns needed no washing at all, while the red, the bur, and the black had to be leached.



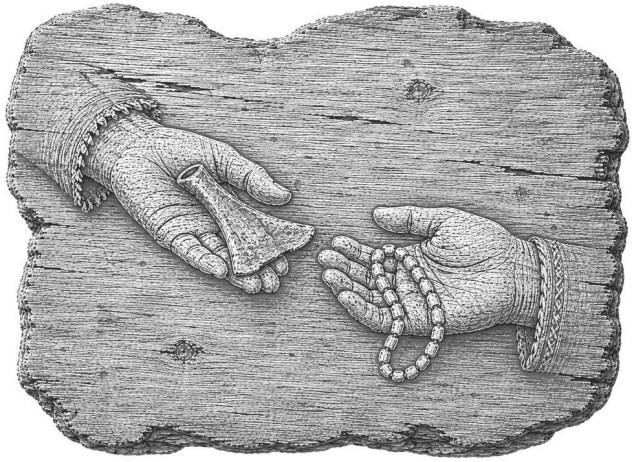
A woven bag, the sort that kept the summer's dried food through the winter.

The nut trees were gathered too, though the sweetest nuts were eaten on the spot. The hazelnut the Ojibwe called the bear nut, and the Flambeau were "especially fond of the newly gathered nuts before the kernel" hardened. The beech gave sweet nuts that everyone liked, but, as Smith noted, they were "never plentiful

enough to store," and so they were simply eaten fresh, in the fall woods.

By the end of the warm moons the summer harvest had been turned into something that would last. The berries were dried, the soft fruit was made into leather cakes, and the acorn meal was stored in woven bags, all of it sealed into makuks and buried in the caches with the rice and the sugar. Months later, in the dead of the Freezing Moon, a family hundreds of miles inland would open a packet, cut off a tasty piece, and boil the berries of July into the winter's meat, remembering a summer it had left behind.

Trade



The Great Lakes region provided the people nearly everything they needed, and what it did not give, they got by trade. The lakes and woods were rich, but a few things could not be found in them, and those came from far away, carried hand to hand along routes older than any European map. The Americas had much in plenty, and when an Indigenous trader arrived with a new tool that outperformed the local ones, its value to the whole tribe was plain to every individual. And it was not only tools that were traded, but food, seed, weapons, hides, beads and baubles, anything and everything that caught the eye. This is the way of people the world over. Trade was not new when the traders came. It was one of the oldest things the people did.

The clearest sign of the old trade was seashells, a thousand miles from any sea. The small white shell called the megis, which lay at the heart of the Midewiwin and was the emblem of the whole religion, came from a distant ocean. So did the dentalium and the wampum, the shell beads strung into necklaces and worked into the belts that sealed a treaty or carried a message. None of these grew anywhere near the Great Lakes; every one had been passed from people to people across the length and width of the continent. And the lakes had something to send in return. Along the south shore of Lake Superior lay native copper, pure enough to

hammer cold into knives and awls and ornaments, and the people had been working it and trading it away for a very long time before anyone wrote their history down.

Then the Europeans came, and the trade grew into something larger and changed the daily life of the country and the shape of the land and water itself. Now the people had furs the newcomers wanted, the beaver above all, and the traders had goods the country could not make for itself. Metal came first: the kettle that replaced the bark vessel over the fire, the iron knife and awl, the light trade tomahawk, and the gun. Then cloth, the trade broadcloth that Densmore says came in four grades, and the wool blanket that went over the old fur robe. Then glass beads by the thousand, and silver arm-bands, and ammunition. The old crafts took the new materials in without breaking stride: the iron point went into the arrow, the copper kettle went to the sugar bush, and a trade blanket worn thin was cut down for hoods and socks.

The people paid in pelts, but they paid in food as well. The Odawa of Arbor Croche grew corn "for the market," Henry noted, provisioning the trade from their gardens. Farther west, the rice and the sugar and the dried fish fed the traders themselves; without the country's own food the trade could not have moved at all. "The fish and the wild rice are the chief sustenance of the traders," one early account put it, "and without them the trade could scarcely be carried on." The rates were set in furs. Around 1820 a makuk of maple sugar was worth four beaver skins, a sack of rice was worth two, and a beaver skin was reckoned at two dollars.

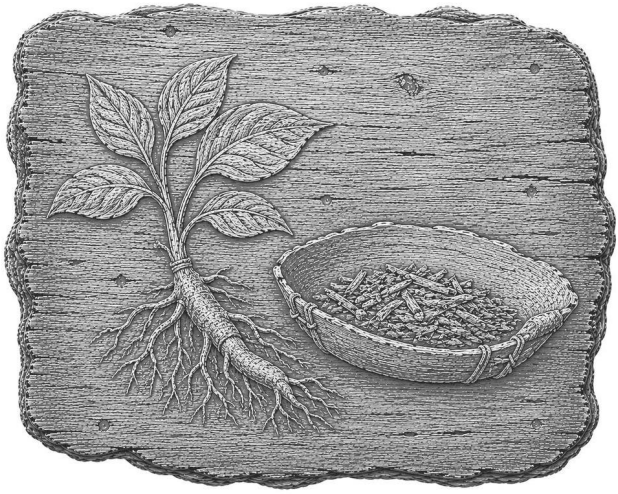
Underneath all of it was the older idea of the gift. As a matter of custom, a bargain among the people was sealed the way a peace treaty was, with the pipe smoked and the wampum belt laid down, and a present given was a present expected back. Trade was not only the getting of goods. It was a way of holding the far-flung people of the lakes together, so that a person of one totem was owed hospitality by his kind a hundred miles from home. But all this was before the colonists arrived. The trade that filled the

country's few wants came in the end to take far more than it brought.

Trading may be part of what it means to be human, but so too is the unfortunate characteristic of greed. Unscrupulous characters soon filled the trading routes, taking advantage of a people who had no concept of owning land and no written law, and no tradition of profiting at a neighbor's expense. Companies like the Hudson's Bay Company took advantage of the country's rich resources, and of an Indigenous people who were not wise to the profit motive so common among Europeans. Corrupt traders found easy pickings, as self-serving as traders among foreign nations have been at any time in human history. The demand for fur in the old world overrode a cultural wisdom passed down for thousands of years.

The very people who had lived with nature, who depended on a pristine land, found themselves decimating the animal populations through over-trapping and over-hunting, and the old ways of never taking more than could be used were set aside. And worse still, with the useful goods and the honest traders came whisky, which the country had never lacked and should not want, and behind the traders came the treaties. George Copway, who watched his own people's land signed away, had no soft word for the men who did it; he called them "land-sharks, called traders." Even salt, unknown in the old days, arrived at last as a clause in a treaty, five barrels a year for five years, payment for a piece of the north. The same summer canoes that carried the pelts out to the posts came back with the goods that changed the country's people and its habitats, and, in time, with the treaties that took the country itself.

Treating Sickness



The people said their medicine came to them in dreams. A healer's power and much of his knowledge were given in a vision, and the plants themselves were understood as a gift. But the knowledge was not only dreamed; it was tested, over a very long time, against the one thing that cannot be argued with. "The use of plants by the Indians was based upon experiment and study," Densmore wrote. "The Indians say that they received this knowledge in dreams, but the response of the physical organism was the test." What came down through the generations was a body of remedies that worked, often for reasons no one living could have named.

There were two kinds of healer. The Mide, a member of the Grand Medicine society, cured with herbs and with the power of songs, and had made a special study of the compounding of herbs. The other, the djasakid, worked on the mind, by startlement and the shaking of a closed lodge and the calling of the animal spirits. Both were paid; in the old days a person would not pass on what he knew about medicine, even to his own family, without a gift in return. And a plant was never taken for nothing. Before a root was dug, tobacco was laid in the ground beside it and the plant was spoken to. Gagewin, a healer at White Earth, told Densmore the words he used: "You were allowed to grow here for the benefit of

mankind, and I give you this tobacco to remind you of this, so that you will do the best you can for me."



Main'gans, whose feet were lost to frostbite in boyhood and whose legs were amputated below the knee with a common knife, the healing 'perfect.'

The herbs were prepared with care. Roots and leaves were boiled, steeped, or scalded, and pounded fresh or dry into poultices and compresses. The strength of a dose was fitted to the medicine and

to the patient: one root, the calamus, was so powerful that the amount given was measured against the length of the patient's own index finger, whether the patient was a child or a grown person. Remedies were often built of many plants together, as many as twenty in a single medicine, each chosen for its part. Much of this knowledge was held close by the people who owned it, and the whole subject is so large that it would take other books to set it down in full. It is enough to say that some of these healers, the equals of any western physician, gave their whole lives to the medical arts, the plants and the practical craft alike.



Main'gans in the regalia of his people.

Alongside the herbs stood the sweat lodge, a small dome where water thrown on heated stones filled the air with steam, used to drive sickness out and to purify; in winter a family might build a little one in a corner of its own lodge.

The way the people treated a wound shows the knowledge at work. They reached first for the healing barks. A writer who watched the Cree, farther north, judged their dressings of juniper and balsam bark "as good an application to wounds as a people unversed in

antiseptic application and ignorant of the existence of bacteria could devise." The Chippewa had their own. A man named Wezawange made a healing pulp from the inner bark of the white pine, the wild plum, and the wild cherry, boiled soft, mashed, dried, and moistened again when it was needed, and it was laid on any wound or on a fresh cut, and used above all on old wounds that had gone bad. A broken bone was set and splinted, and the best splint was thick birch bark, the kind used for canoes, heated and bent to shape until, Densmore wrote, it was "as rigid as plaster of Paris," and bound on with basswood twine.



A bag in which prepared medicines were kept.

They went further than dressing when they had to. Main'gans, whose feet had been ruined by freezing when he was a boy, had both legs amputated below the knee by a man using nothing but "a common knife," and the stumps were dressed with dry pounded cherry bark; "the healing," Densmore was told, "was perfect." Wezawange, cutting away the dead flesh of a gangrenous wound, worked by a rule that reads like something out of a later century. Everything, he said, "must be very clean, care being taken

especially that the knife or remedies did not come in contact with rust." He could not have told anyone what a germ was. He kept the rust off the blade all the same, and the wound came clean.



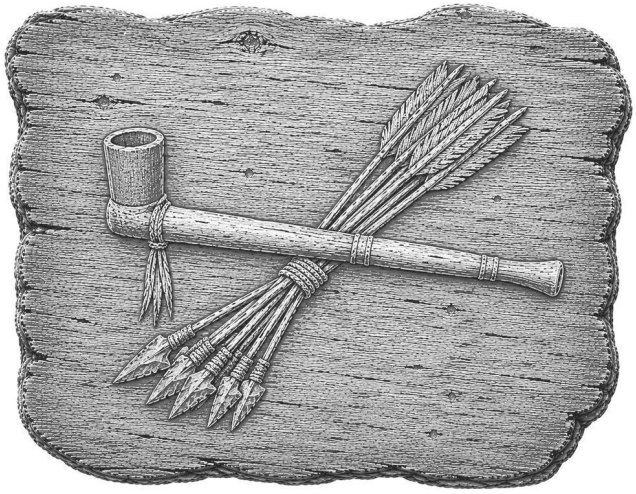
A medicine pole standing on the ground of the medicine lodge.

For all of this, our record does not show these people sewing a wound shut. They dressed it, poulticed it, splinted the bone, and cut away what was dead, but the stitched wound is not there. That does not prove they never closed a cut; it may only be that no one wrote it down. Other peoples on this continent did close wounds by a means our own surgery never used: in South America a healer would press biting ants along the edges of a cut so that the jaws clamped it shut, then break off the bodies and leave the heads in place. What the Chippewa record shows is the dressing and the healing, and both were good.

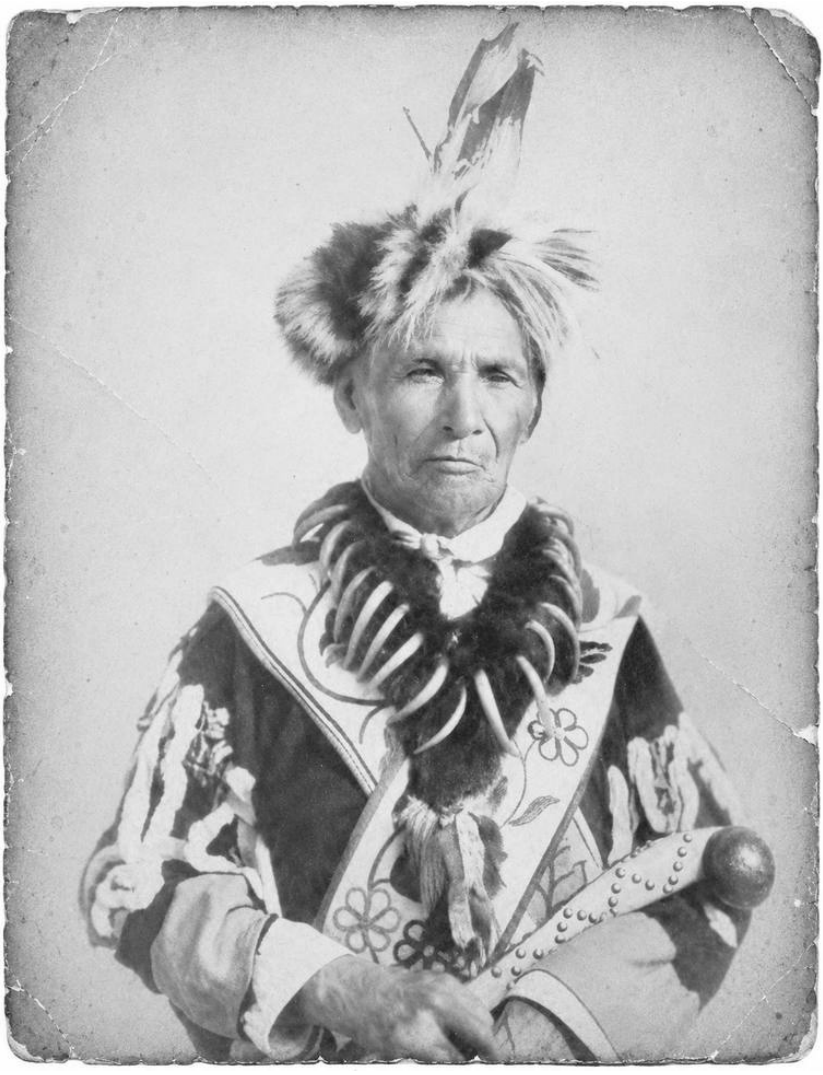
The dream and the experiment had arrived at the same place. A people who had never heard of a germ knew to keep the rust from the knife; a people who could not name the compound in a bark knew that the bark would heal a wound; a people who said their medicine had been given to them in sleep had proved every part of it, over long years, against the plain evidence of whether the sick

got well. Gagewin thanked the plant for doing its best for him. It usually did.

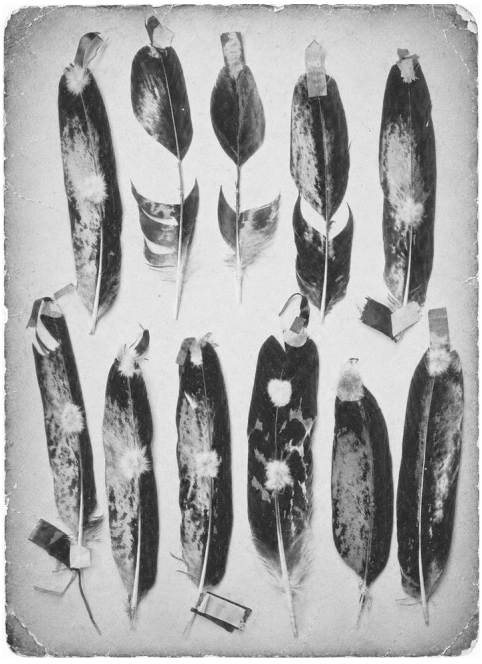
The Wisdom of War



Just as trading is a universal phenomenon among the people of this world, so too is hostility ubiquitous among neighbors. One would like to believe that a life lived in harmony with nature was free from the human folly that plagued European history. The unsettling fact is that war in the Great Lakes region was a natural part of the year, like the hunt and the harvest. In the warm months, when the sugar was made and the lakes were open and travel was easy, some of the men left the summer village and took the war road. For the Ojibwe of the western lakes the great enemy was the Dakota, the Sioux, whose country lay to the west and south, and the two peoples fought along the moving line between them for generations. Frances Densmore, who took the war songs and the war stories down from an old warrior himself, set the matter plainly: "War between Indian tribes was an occupation rather than a calamity."



Odjib'we, "the last great warrior of the Mississippi Band," who gave Densmore the war songs and stories that carry this chapter.



War-honor eagle feathers, each one standing for a scalp, notched to tell how the deed was done.

It was not the tribe that went to war but a party of volunteers. Any warrior of standing could raise a following on his own reputation, sending a messenger through the villages with tobacco to call men to him. The usual reason was revenge. When a man was killed by the Sioux his relatives were bound to answer it, and the death of a Sioux was felt to restore the one who had been lost. Under the particular griefs lay an older and simpler thing, which Densmore named without flinching: tribal pride, a tally of the dead that each side kept and each side meant to keep in its own favor.



A war club.

A war leader's authority rested on two things, the trust of the men who followed him and the power of his dream. The greatest of Densmore's informants was Odjib'we, "the last great warrior of the Mississippi Band," blind and old in the home at White Earth when she knew him, who had led war parties against the Sioux in his strength. As a boy he had fasted and dreamed of a woman who gave him guns made of rushes; when the Sioux fired them at him, only harmless horseflies came out, and the woman told him he would be a great warrior and would always be protected. She gave him a song, which he could not bring himself to sing until the eve of his first fight, when the dream came back to him clear. The dream was the source of a warrior's courage and his luck, and it was his most private possession.



The war drum, called the drum of the braves.

Deeds in war were counted exactly, and worn with pride. A warrior's eagle feathers each stood for a Sioux scalp, notched if he had killed and scalped the man himself. The reckoning was precise: four feathers could be counted for one dead enemy, one for the man who killed him, one for the man who scalped him, and two for the men who had helped. The war drum was called the drum of the braves. The making of a warrior was hard. On his first

expedition a recruit slept apart in the rear and ate the poorest of the food, and the old warriors, as one of them remembered, "treated the beginners as though they were nothing but animals," until he had been in a fight and earned his place.



A warrior in the posture of a scout.



Watching for the enemy.

A party that had taken a scalp came home in triumph. Runners went ahead with the news, and the warriors stopped at the last camp to dress in their finest and rehearse their songs. As they neared the village they fired their guns, and the women came out to meet them. The scalps were handed to a woman who led the party in, and each was stretched inside a small hoop at the end of a pole. Then came the victory dance, often lasting till daylight by the light of bonfires, and the honor songs, which were composed and sung by the warriors' own wives and mothers, the scalp held high as they danced.



Shaking hands: a Chippewa and a Menominee at the making of a peace.

But the war had limits, and the people kept them. Even while it raged, the winter hunting truces held: Ojibwe and Dakota camps a few miles apart would smoke the pipe of peace, exchange visits, and now and then a man of one people would take a man of the other as an adopted brother. And when two tribes made a real peace, the ceremony was as careful as a battle. A pipe-bearer led the way, followed by four women; each side sang the names of the other's leaders in praise; and at the end the Sioux fired their guns into the air and did not reload them, and the Ojibwe did the same. Before guns came to the country, the same peace was sworn with the war cry, raised and let fall. There was even room, in the songs,

for the enemy's grief. One that Densmore recorded was made for a Sioux woman who took up an ax to defend her children against an Ojibwe attack and was killed with all of them; the words honor her, for defending her children she "fought for us all." It was composed by Odjib'we's own father. War also took captives. Women and children especially were sometimes carried off, and a captive could be enslaved, or treated harshly, or adopted into a family to take the place of someone who had died, and so in time become one of the people.



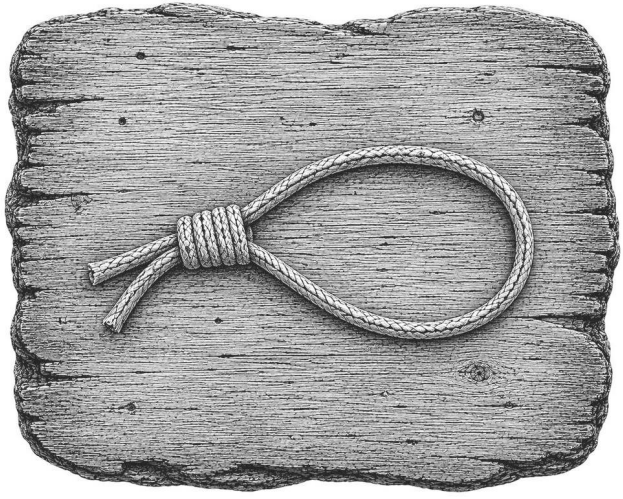
In the posture of looking for the enemy.



The peace gathering, where each side sang the other's leaders' names.

So war was an occupation, with its own honor, its own hard training, its own griefs, and its own limits and its own wisdom, held in check by the pipe and the truce and even by a song for a dead enemy. Odjib'we, who had lived all of it, was remembered at his death in words that respected the whole of it: "when war was glory he led his people to victory over the Sioux. May he rest in peace." It was a thing the people of the Great Lakes region did. It is a thing all people in this world do.

Taking Captives and Becoming Slaves



The war road brought back more than scalps and honor. It brought back people. A war party that struck an enemy camp carried off women and children, and sometimes men, and what became of a captive afterward was one of the hard facts of the old life. It is not a comfortable subject, but it was a real one, and a book that tells the war honestly has to tell this part too.

Among the peoples of the Great Lakes a captive did not have a single fixed fate. There were three roads. A captive might be killed, in revenge for a relative the enemy had taken. A captive might be kept in a servile place in the household, set to the heavy and thankless work, a person owned rather than related. Or a captive might be adopted, taken into a family to fill the place of someone who had died, and this last was common enough that it shaped the whole practice. When a family lost a son or a brother, the grief was not only private. It left an empty place in the family and the clan, and a captive could be raised into that place, given the dead person's name, and in time become a full member of the people.

So the line between a slave and a relative was thin, and it was crossed by adoption. The clearest account comes from the trader Alexander Henry, whose life was saved by exactly this. After the attack at Michilimackinac in 1763, Henry was a prisoner among

men who might kill him, and the Ojibwe Wawatam, who had earlier taken him as a brother, stood up in the council to plead for him. He asked the others to imagine their own dearest friend "in the condition of a slave, a slave exposed every moment to insult, and to the menaces of death," and he reminded them, "long before the war began, I adopted him as my brother. From this moment he became one of my family." The adoption held, and Henry lived. A man who might have been a slave, or a corpse, became instead a son and a brother.

This is worth being clear about, because what the tribes did was not the thing that word would later come to mean. Captivity among the Great Lakes peoples was cruel to those it killed and hard on those it held, but it was not, in the main, a permanent and inherited condition. A captive's children were not born slaves. A captive could be adopted up into kinship and lose the mark of the captive entirely. The taking of captives was bound up with grief and revenge and the filling of a family's loss, not with the buying and selling of human beings as goods.

That distinction did not survive the coming of the Europeans.

When the French and then the British built their trade across the Great Lakes, they brought a market for everything, and they made a market in people. A captive who might once have been adopted or held in a household became, to a European buyer, a thing that could be sold. The French had a word for an enslaved native person, "panis," taken from the name of a distant Plains people who were among the first so traded, and it came to stand for any Indigenous person held in bondage. Captives were carried eastward and sold, and enslaved Indigenous people were kept at the trading towns, at Detroit and Michilimackinac and Montreal, as property under the law. The demand drew the tribes into supplying it, the way the demand for fur had drawn them into over-trapping. A practice that had been about loss and replacement was turned, for profit, into a trade in human lives.

And the trade did not stop at one people. The same colonial world that bought and sold captured Indigenous people also carried Africans across an ocean in chains and held them in bondage in

the same towns and on the same farms. In the settlements of the Great Lakes, enslaved Black people and enslaved Indigenous people worked side by side, owned by the same masters and bound by the same law. Forced labor, indenture, and the outright ownership of one human being by another were built into the colonial order that spread over the country, and the Indigenous people of this land and the Africans brought to it were both caught in it. It is a sordid history, and a long one, and it did not end when the trading posts closed.

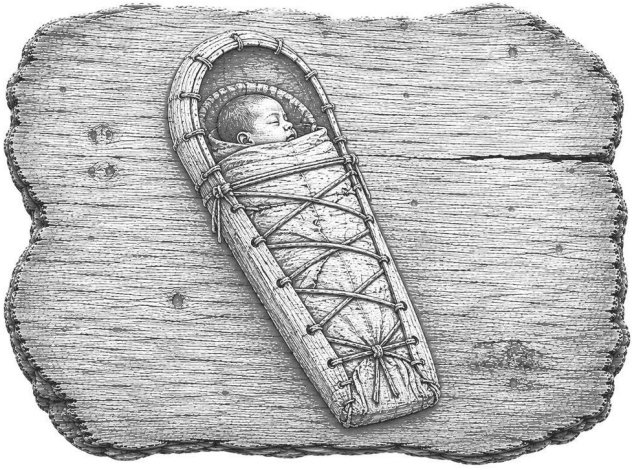
It is easy to want to look away from all of it, from the captives the tribes themselves took and from the far larger and colder system of slavery the newcomers built. But the honest account holds both, and holds them at their true weights. Among the people of this book, the taking of a captive was an act of war and of grief, and its usual end was death or adoption into a family. Under the trade that came after, a captive became a commodity, and a person became a price.

The war road had always brought back people. What changed, when the newcomers came, was what a person could be turned into once they were taken.

Part Five: The Turning of a Life



The Cradle and the Little Ones



A new baby spent almost the whole of its first year laced to a cradleboard. In this society, mothers were seldom separate from their infants. The baby went wherever its mother went. Families were not large. The average, Densmore was told, "was two or three children," and each one was carried, tended, and watched over with great care from the day it was born.

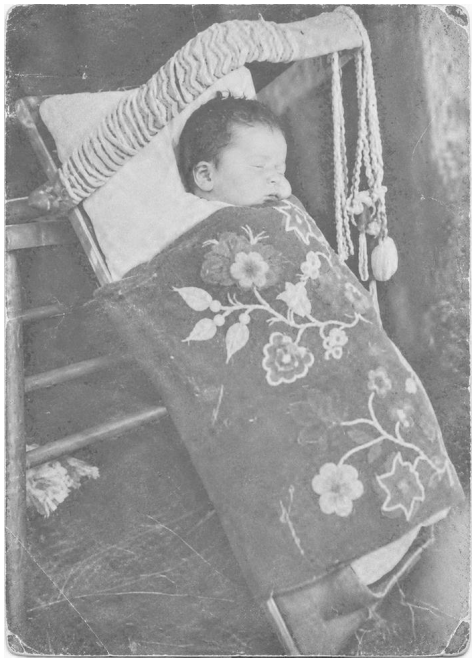


A mother carrying her baby on a cradleboard on her back, where a child spent almost all of its first year.

It seems that conditioning the child from the earliest moments was part of their culture, as birth itself was met with noise. A baby born in the night was announced with noise, as much of it as could be made. By the time Densmore recorded the custom that noise was made by firing guns, but before guns reached these lakes it

would have been shouts and whoops. The point was the din itself. Then two clans, the father's and another, wrestled for possession of the child, throwing water and flour-and-water at each other until "everybody was wringing wet." The winners carried the baby four times around the fire, singing "We have caught the little bird." It was done, Densmore was told, "to make the child brave from hearing so much noise as soon as it was born."

The cradleboard was a flat board about two feet long, with a rest for the feet and a bent hoop arching over the head. A baby was held in it "most of its time for the first year of its life." It was packed with soft moss, gathered from the cranberry marshes, dried over a fire, and pulled apart until it was as soft as wool. The moss was warm, and was changed as the need arose. In cold weather the baby's feet were wrapped in rabbit skin or the down of the cattail. The child was laced in snugly, and the lacing had a purpose beyond holding it still. "Care was taken," Densmore wrote, "that the arms as well as the legs and back should be straight," so that the person would stand straight for life. One Chippewa told her, with some pride, that "an Indian never stooped except for age."



A cradleboard with its beaded wrappings and arching hoop.

The board was made to be carried. A mother slung it on her back with a strap across her chest or forehead and took the baby with her to the rice, the berries, and the garden. Set down, it could be leaned upright against a tree or a lodge pole, where the baby could watch her at work, or hung from a branch and rocked. Indoors a blanket was sometimes slung as a hammock and swung to a lullaby. A mother even kept the baby's age on the board itself, cutting a small notch in it for each day that passed.



A cradleboard, the flat board with a footrest and a hoop over the head.

The hoop over the baby's head did more than hold a cloth against the sun and rain. Things were hung from it. There were toys, small white shells and a little birch-bark cone filled with maple sugar that the child could suck. There was the gift of the person who had named the child. And there were charms, among them two small webs woven of nettle twine and hung on the hoop to "catch everything evil as a spider's web catches." The dreamcatcher sold in shops today descends from a cradle charm like this one, hung over a baby's face.

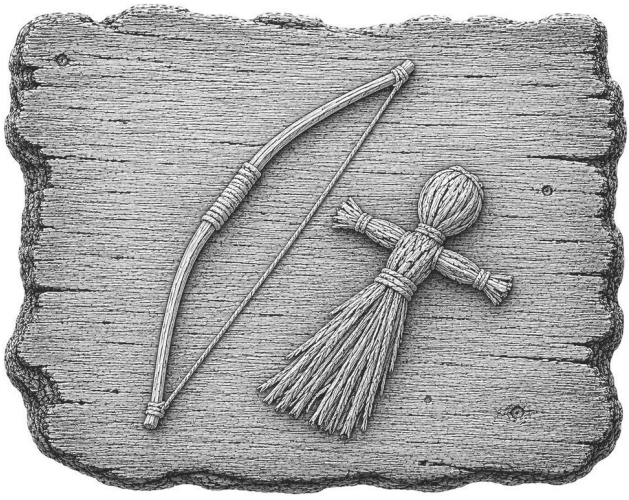
A baby was nursed a long time, until it was about two years old, and then weaned onto fish broth or wild rice boiled very soft. Above all it was kept content. "Chippewa women," Densmore wrote, "never allowed a baby to cry if this could be avoided," and a fretting child was picked up, fed, or rocked at once.



A woman with a cradleboard among the work of the camp.

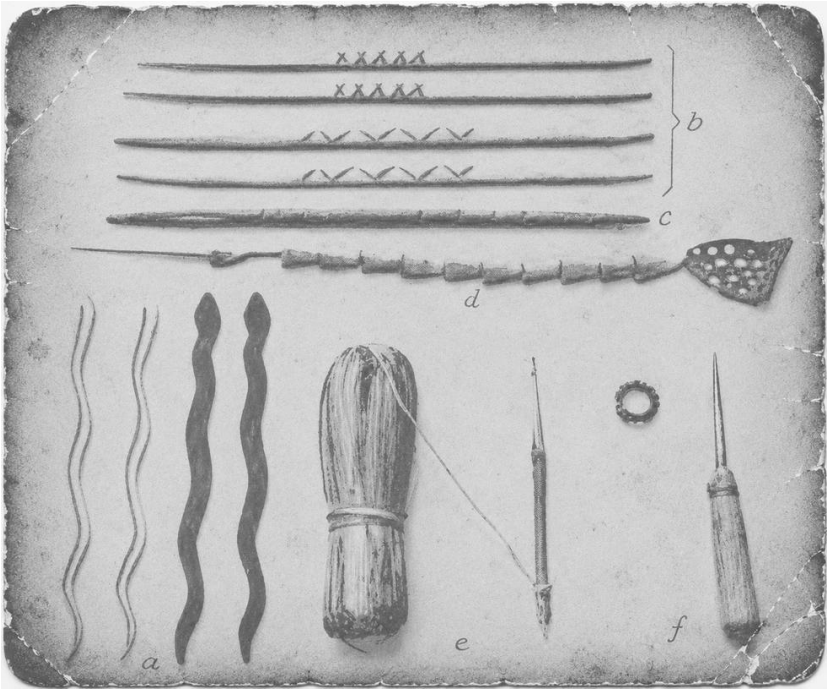
For that first year the cradleboard was the baby's whole world, and the child was seldom set down far from its mother. When at last it could walk and left the cradleboard behind, it stepped out on its own feet into a country it had already crossed a hundred times, carried, on its mother's back.

The Children



A child left the cradleboard and stepped into a world that was, for a few years, mostly its own. It had chores to learn and a place to grow into, but before all of that it had the run of the camp and the shore and the woods, and a long stretch of years given over, more than any other time of life, to play. To watch how the children played is to watch the whole year in miniature, for a child played at the work it would one day do.

In the warm months the children lived half in the water. "The children were like ducks," an old woman told Frances Densmore, "in-and-out of the water all day. They never stopped to take off the little clothing they had on, and their clothes dried on them when they came out of the water." Girls swam as well as boys, and all of them were expert. The summer camp on the lake shore gave them the long days and the open water, and a child who was not carrying wood or minding a smaller one was as likely as not to be in the lake.



Implements of Anishinaabe games recorded by Densmore, among them the snake game, slid across the snow and ice.

Much of their play was made by their own hands, and nearly all of it copied the work of the grown. A little girl was given a doll, and the dolls were made of whatever the country offered: of willow withes bound into a figure, of twisted grass, of a strip of slippery-elm bark, of bulrush root. The simplest of all was a tuft of pine needles cut square and stood upright in a shaken tin, where it trembled as if it were dancing. The girl who dressed her doll was taking her first lesson in a woman's craft, for her earliest beadwork was the decorating of the doll's clothes, the straight lines before the harder patterns. She made little mats of rushes as her mother made the big ones, and floated ducks of bulrush root on a pool. A boy's first toy pointed the same way. "As soon as a boy was able to hold anything in his hands," Densmore was told, "he was given something resembling a bow and arrow, and taught to go through the motions of shooting." Long before he could hit anything, a boy was a hunter in rehearsal.

Beyond the toys were the games, and the people had many. Some were games of chance, played with marked bones or plum stones or a moccasin to hide a token under, and these the grown played too, sometimes for high stakes. Others were games of skill and strength, and these were the children's schooling in another form. There were foot races and wrestling and shooting at a mark. There was the great ball game, played with a netted stick and still played today under the name lacrosse, which taught a boy to run and to dodge and to take a hard knock without anger. Even the smaller games were fitted to a child's hand. The bunch-of-grass game the women played was made in a lesser size for the children: a small twist of grass was tossed into the air and caught on the point of a stick, and the catch was the whole of the skill. A girl's grass and stick were tiny, but she played it just as her mother did. Through all of it a child learned to be quick, to be strong, and to lose without a sulk.

Winter did not stop the play; it only changed it. On the snowy banks the boys coasted downhill, each standing upright on a short board strapped to one foot. Out on the flat snow and the smooth lake ice they played the snow snake, a game of throwing rather than sliding. A snow snake was a long, polished wooden rod, and a boy threw it low and hard so that it ran skimming along a packed track of snow or ice, the winner being the boy whose snake ran the farthest. Throwing it well took a strong and accurate arm, which was the skill the game built, and a short snake was made for a small boy and a long one for a big boy. Warren remembered the boys of his own boyhood out on the lake ice, "throwing before them their shosh-e-mans, or little snow slides."

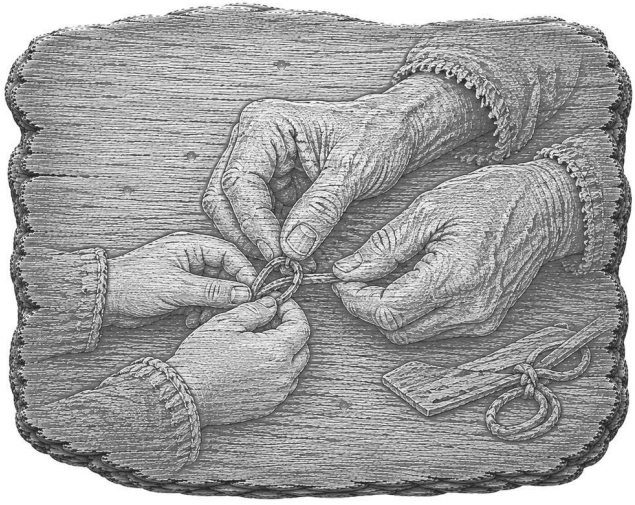


The bowl and marked dice of the plate game, one of the games that filled the long winter evenings.

The line between the play and the work was never sharp, and it was meant to blur. A child was given real work as soon as it could do it, and the work was not so different from the games: the toy bow became the hunting bow, the dressed doll became the sewn dress, the little mat became the lodge covering. And the world a child played in was not empty of spirits. Children were taught to call to the butterflies, and to watch for the Spirit of the Woods, and to know that the small creatures of the country were there and were to be minded. A child came to know the land and its life by living in it at play, the way it would later come to work in it.

So the years of a child were not idle. They were filled with nature's natural adventures. The running and the swimming and the games built the body; the dolls and the toy bows and the little mats trained the hands and the eye; and the whole of it made a person who knew the land and its offerings before anyone had sat down to teach it. When at last the child set the toy bow aside and took up the real one, or set down the doll and took up the awl, the work it turned to was already half familiar, learned in play in the same woods and the same water.

Teaching the Young



The Indigenous of the Great Lakes region informed generations through an oral tradition. Everything they knew about the land and the year, the whole body of skill this book has been describing, lived in the minds and the hands of living people. And unlike western civilization, whose old are sheltered in specialized homes, where they sit idle to await their end in isolation, the Anishinaabe elderly had a clear role within the tribes as educators of the young. In this society, where old-folks-homes were a foreign concept, it was the elders who functioned as the repositories of information. A child who wanted to know how to set a snare, read the sky, tap a maple, or sing a sick person back to health learned it from someone older, by watching and by doing, and the oldest people earned their life's lessons. Reaching old age in this land proved the method was fit to be passed on. Teaching the young was the most important work a community did, because it was the only way any wisdom survived.

The teaching went on all year, belonging to no single season. And though it was called an oral tradition, in reality it was done less by telling than by showing. A boy learned to hunt by going with his father and watching him. "For years I followed my father," Copway remembered, and he learned to read the whole country as he went,

for the sky, the sound of far water, the clouds, and the winds "were to be noticed." A girl learned at her mother's side, carrying wood, rolling birch bark, tending the sugar and the rice, and sewing beadwork onto the clothes of her doll. Children were given real work as soon as they could do it, and they learned the work by doing it next to someone who already knew how.

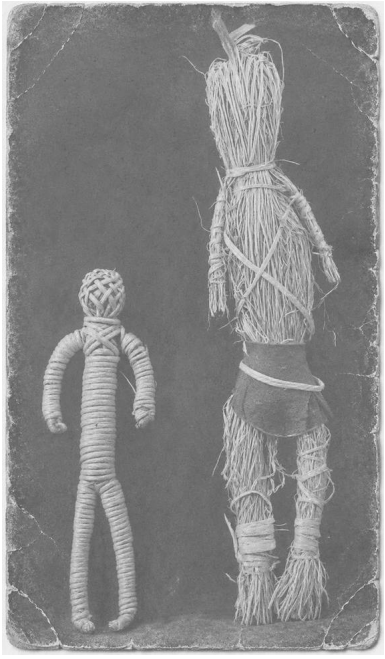


Tom Skinaway of Mille Lac, who told Densmore he had to fast ten times before his vision came.

The teaching began before a child could walk. Presumably, for reasons known only to the people, the dried navel cord was sewn into a small case and tied to the cradleboard, kept there "for the securing of wisdom for the child." As the child grew, the lessons

were matched to its age, and some were lessons in character rather than skill. One taught patience with the first strawberries of the year. An old man would fill a spoon with the berries and lift it toward a child's mouth, then draw it back, four times over, before letting the child eat, and the same was done "with the first of every product of nature, even to the wild rice of the autumn." A child learned to wait, and to take the first of a thing as a gift rather than a right.

Not all knowledge could be shown. Some had to be received. From early childhood the old people told a child to "try to dream and to remember what you dream," preparing it for the fast it would make at the edge of adulthood. Alone, and going without food for days, a young person waited for a dream that would bring a guardian spirit and a direction for life. It did not always come at once. Tom Skinaway, an old man at Mille Lac, told Densmore that he had "to try ten times" before the dream came that gave him his name, Bi'jiki, the buffalo, for the strength and endurance it promised him. What a person saw in that fast was private, held close for a lifetime, and it was the one kind of knowledge the elders could not hand over. They could only teach the child how to go and seek it.



A child's doll, dressed in beadwork the way a girl learned the craft at her mother's side.

Teaching happened even in the naming of a child. The family asked a respected elder to give the name, and with the name the elder passed on the benefit of his or her own dream, the guardian power and good fortune it had brought, as a blessing to the child. And a child was not taught by its family alone. The whole village had a hand in it. Blackbird, the Odawa writer, remembered his father's great summer lodge, sixty or seventy feet long, as "a regular school-house, with my father as teacher." At night in the camp a crier, "a man of exemplary life," walked the circle of lodges and spoke aloud the next day's plans and, with them, counsel on how a person should live. A child grew up inside a whole community of teachers, and the oldest of them were the ones it was wisest to listen to.

So the knowledge moved down the generations by watching and doing. It seems obvious that the eldest of the tribe, who had lived through the greatest number of years, also had the greatest wisdom to impart. A growing mind learned the essential

knowledge from these very individuals. And in time that child grew old and became the one the young now watched. The people kept no books because they did not need them. They kept their elders.

Becoming a Woman



A child grew, and at a certain age the two paths of a life divided, and a girl crossed from childhood into womanhood by a passage of her own. This book has told the year through its moons. A woman kept a moon as well, a rhythm of her own body that the people understood through the moon in the sky, and her crossing into that rhythm was marked, as the boy's crossing was, by a going-apart and fasting.

When a girl came to her first maturity, she went into seclusion. "At the time of her maturity," Densmore recorded, "a young girl was required to isolate herself for four days and nights. Her mother made a little wigwam for her at some distance from the lodge." There she stayed alone. In the old days she took no food at all through the four days; in later times an older sister or another woman of the family brought her a little. She kept certain observances while she waited, not touching her hair or her body with her hands but using a small stick made for the purpose. It was a hard passage and a solemn one, and the people treated it with respect, as the crossing to adulthood was a significant change in status among the clan.

It was more than a marking of the body. Like the boy who blackened his face and fasted at the edge of manhood, the girl in

her little wigwam was fasting for a dream. The vision-fast was not the boys' alone. Densmore was plain about it: parents instructed "both girls and boys concerning the importance of this dream," and the dream a young person found in that fasting was "of greatest importance in the life of the individual, though he or she might have other dreams." So the girl, alone and hungry for four days, waited as her brother had waited, for the guardian spirit and the power and the song that would be hers. A woman had her own manidoo, sought and found in the same way.

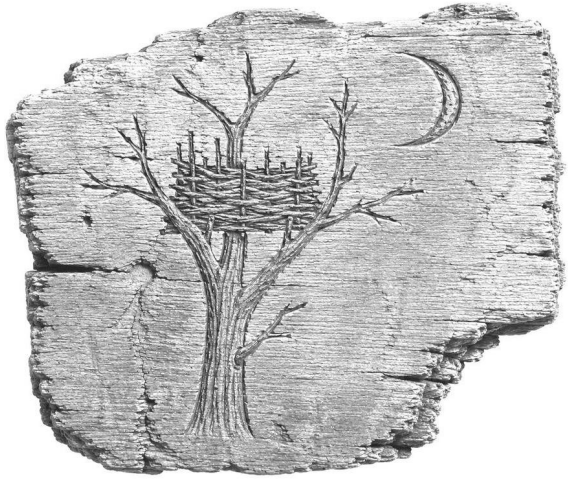
When the four days were over a feast was given, and the girl came back to the camp a woman. She took up a woman's work and a woman's standing, and the reader of this book already knows what that work was, for it has filled these pages: the rice and the sugar, the hides and the mats, the nets and the cord, the gardens and the berries, the cache and the cooking fire. The girl who came out of the little wigwam was stepping into the labor that carried a family through the year.

Her first moon, however, was not a single passage that ended when the four days were over. It marked the beginning of a rhythm that would return throughout her womanhood. The people understood that recurring time as part of the same order of moons that governed the year, and a woman's monthly time had its own observances and its own place within the life of the people. The separation of the first moon had opened a door into womanhood; thereafter, the rhythm returned with her, a private cycle within the larger cycle of the year.

In time she married, and in time she bore children. The birth was attended by the older women, and much of what the people did at a birth has already been told, in the chapter of the cradle: the noise made to greet the child, the cutting and the keeping of the navel cord, the sphagnum moss and the cradleboard. What belongs here is the woman's own place afterward. A mother was the center of the lodge. She presided over its fire and its food, and her daughters kept their places always next to her, and the household turned around her as the smaller work of the camp turned around the women's hands... it was a life that was hers to manage.

So the passage was real, and it was honored. A girl went alone into a small wigwam at the edge of the camp, kept a hard fast, waited for her dream, and came back a woman, with a moon of her own and a life of work and children before her. The book has counted the year by thirteen moons. A woman's own life turned by a moon as surely as the year did.

Becoming a Man



The girl's passage into womanhood came in isolation, with a rhythm her own body kept. The boy's passage was also earned in isolation but not one constrained from his natural environment. It was a going-apart and a fast, but where the girl waited in a little wigwam at the edge of the camp, the boy went out alone into the woods, and where her crossing was marked upon her body and accompanied by a revelatory dream, his was marked by a vision he had to earn.

A boy was prepared for it from early childhood. His father told him, as Densmore's informants remembered, that "ever since the oldest times the Indian boys had blackened their faces and fasted and waited for their dream," and a small boy made little practice fasts that led toward the real one. Then, at the edge of manhood, the boy went out to seek his vision quest in earnest. He blackened his face with charcoal and went away from home: kept from having the necessities of life to trigger his transcendence. Sometimes his father took him a good distance off and, as Densmore recorded, "made a nest for him in a tree," and "left the boy there several days, going occasionally to see if he was all right." Alone, deprived and hungry in the high nest or the far

camp, the boy waited, as his sister had waited in her wigwam, for the spirit to come to him in a dream.

The father insisted that he persevere, for it was not thought a small thing, and it did not always come at once. "It was not unusual," Densmore was told, "for a boy to make several attempts before he secured a dream, but complete failures were very rare." A boy might go out and come back with nothing and go out again, and the old people did not count that a failure but the ordinary difficulty of a hard and necessary thing. When the dream did come, it brought what the girl's brought her: a guardian spirit, a power, a song, and often a true name, held close and seldom spoken for the rest of his life. The vision a boy found in his fasting guided the whole course of his living, and it was his own, the one possession no one could take from him or give him.

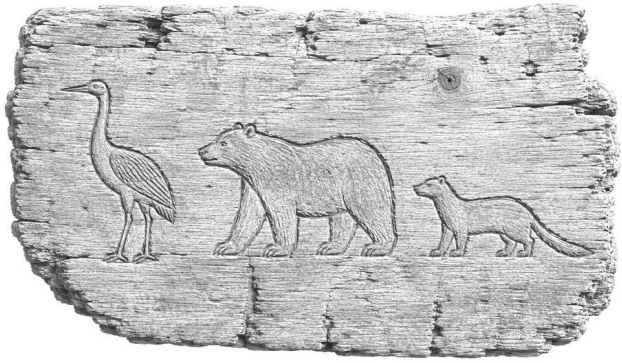
The making of a man had an earlier mark as well, one that came long before the fast, and it was not a dream but a kill. A boy shot at birds and small creatures almost from the time he could hold his little bow, and much of that was play. But the first living thing he truly brought down, his first real kill, was a thing the people marked. When a boy killed his first game, a feast was held for it. He did not simply eat what he had taken. He gave a feast in its honor and asked the old men to celebrate it, and they "talked to the manido" over the boy's first success and the life still before him. The rule was the same first-fruits rule that governed the first rice and the first berries: the first of a thing was not kept for oneself but offered and shared. Densmore set down one man's memory of it that catches the whole custom in a small and human way. Henry Selkirk said the first game he ever killed was a wild canary, and he "hung it up to wait until he had enough food to give a feast in honor of the event, but it was so long before he had enough that the little bird dried up." A boy became a man not when he first took something from the world, but when he first gave the killing away.

After the dream and the first ritual dispatch, the young man took his place among the men. He went to the hunt in earnest, where the skill this book has described was now his to learn and to

perfect. And some, in the warm moons, took the war road, where a young recruit was tried hard, "treated," as one old warrior remembered, "as though they were nothing but animals," until he had been in a fight and earned his standing. Whichever way his life ran, he now stood among the grown, a man with a dream behind him and a place within the clan to fill.

So the boy's passage, like the girl's, was a real, marked passage. He blackened his face and went out alone to earn a dream, and he gave away his first kill to become a provider, and he came back from both a man. The girl came into her womanhood; the boy went out and found his. Between the two of them, going apart and coming back changed, the people became their next generation, as the year continued its cycle.

The Order of the People



This book has followed the work of the year: the making and the taking, the hunt and the harvest, the hide and the net and the cache. But work alone does not hold a people together. Behind the labor was an order, a way the people were bound to one another, and it was not the order of a state. There were no courts, no written laws, no police, and no king who could command. What held the Great Lakes people together was kinship, carefully understood and long remembered, and a leadership that could persuade but could not compel.

The clan was what held the community together. William Warren, the Ojibwe historian who gathered his people's past from the memory of their old men, set the system down plainly. The people were divided into "grand families or clans, each of which is known and perpetuated by a symbol of some bird, animal, fish, or reptile which they denominate the Totem or Do-daim." A person was born into a clan and carried its mark for life. The Crane, the Loon, the Bear, the Marten, the Catfish, the Moose: each was a doodem, and every child took the doodem of its father, for the totem, Warren wrote, "descends invariably in the male line."

The clan was not a mere name. It set the two firmest rules of a person's life: whom they could not marry, and whom they had to treat as family. No one could marry inside their own doodem. To do so, Warren was told, was "an offence equivalent among the

whites to the sin of a man marrying his own sister," because all who shared a totem were held to share one blood. So a Bear married a Crane or a Loon or a Catfish, never another Bear, and the clans were laced together by marriage in every generation.



Prominent Chippewa men at a ceremonial gathering, photographed by Densmore. A person's standing among the people rested on conduct and the respect of others, shown in assemblies like this.

The same rule reached far past the village. A person of the Crane clan was kin to every other Crane, Warren wrote, "both in his own and all other tribes," a hundred miles from home and among people who spoke a different dialect. A traveler who came to a strange village had only to name his doodem to find relatives in it, a fire to sit at, and food set before him. This was the web that held the scattered bands of a wide country together, in a life that wintered them a hundred miles apart and gathered them only in the warm moons. The clan was a kinship that crossed the distance the seasons put between people.

Some clans carried a character with them. By tradition the Crane and the Loon were the clans of the speakers and the chiefs, the Bear was numerous and stood for war and for guarding the village,

the Marten and the Moose for the hunt, the Catfish and the other fish clans for teaching and for long life. These were leanings, not laws, and the people did not hold to them everywhere the same. But they gave the loose gathering of families a shape, so that a council was not a crowd of equals shouting but an old and understood arrangement of who spoke to what.

Leadership rested on the same footing of respect rather than force. A band had its chief, and the office ran in a family line; when Curly Head, "the civil and war chief of the Mississippi Ojibways," died childless, his chieftainship passed, by his own dying request, to a man he named to succeed him, the chief remembered as Hole-in-the-day. But the line held only as long as the man in it was worth following. There were two kinds of leader, and often two different men. The civil chief led the village in its ordinary life, by counsel, by generosity, and by his voice; the war leader was raised for a raid on his reputation alone and laid his authority down when the party came home. Neither could order a free man to do anything. A chief led those who agreed to follow him, and no others.



Endusogiwig, a Chippewa man in the dress of his people, photographed by Densmore.

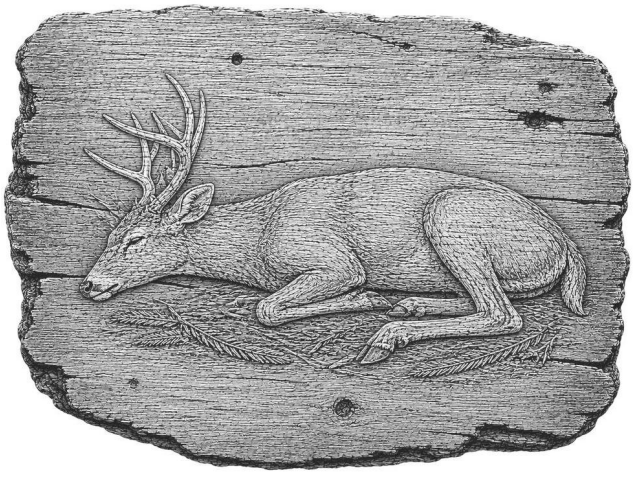
So the people governed themselves by talk. When a question had to be settled, the men gathered in council, and the matter was decided not by a vote or a ruler's word but by speech, and by the weight of the speaker and the ancestors behind him. Warren himself once interpreted at such a council, called to answer a question of precedence, "who was the hereditary chief of La Pointe." An old chief of the Crane clan, Tug-waug-aun-ay, rose and told the long tradition of his people, and closed it: "These are the words of my ancestors, who, from generation to generation, have repeated them into the ears of their children. I have done." When he finished, Warren remembered, there ran through the lodge "the universal whisper, 'It is true; it is true.'" That whisper was the government. A thing was decided when the old men agreed that it was true.

A wrong, too, was answered without a court. There was no jail and no judge. A theft or an insult was a matter between families, settled under the plain pressure of a small community where everyone was known and no one could live apart from the sharing. A killing was the hardest case. It fell to the dead person's kin to answer it, either by taking a life in return or by accepting a gift laid down to cover the loss, and the elders worked to compose such a quarrel before it hardened into a feud. In a society where survival depended heavily on mutual obligation and cooperation, prolonged internal conflict was itself a threat to survival. Therefore disputes had to be contained through kinship, compensation, mediation, and consensus rather than allowed to develop into cycles of retaliation.

It must be noted that tribes of different regions have vastly different customs. The nature of the Great Lakes region is such that, at times, gatherings became quite large but at other times families were more isolated. The order that held the Anishinaabe people, a seasonally mobile culture, was not written on paper or kept with a whip. It was carried in the memory, in the mark of a clan, the line of a chief, and the words of the old men in council. The people were held together not by a power set over them but by the ties running among them: born into a clan, married out of it,

owed to their kin across a whole country, and led only by those they agreed to follow.

Marriage



The young man had earned his dream and the young woman had kept her four days apart, and in time each of them married.

There was no grand ceremony to it, no words said over the couple by a priest, no exchange of rings. In the Ojibwe language the very word for marrying, wiidige, meant to live together, and a husband or wife, wiidigemaagan, was named simply as the person one shared a home with. We would call it common-law, without the law. The language made a marriage out of the living-together itself, and not out of a ceremony. And unlike the birth of a child or the fast of the young, the marriage asked no rite and no priest, and the creator was not called upon over the couple. Despite that, the union of two Anishinaabe was no less of a sacred commitment. Obviously, it was a life shared between man and woman as profound and meaningful as in any world culture. A marriage among these people was a quiet and practical joining of two lives and two families, and it began not with a rite but with a courtship, a gift of meat, and the taking up of a lodge.

Courtship had its customs, but each individual decided how to approach it based on their talents. In the evenings a young man might play the courting flute, a soft and carrying music, though a girl was never allowed to leave the lodge in answer to it. When

passions became serious, he might be inclined to show his merit to the woman's family by performing a task, equally skilled as playing the flute. Densmore set it down simply: he "killed a deer or some other animal and brought it to the girl's parents." The gift said what the flute could not. It showed that the young man could hunt, and would provide, and meant to keep a family. If the girl's parents thought well of him, they asked him to stay and share the feast, and that sharing was the answer. It "was understood," Densmore wrote, "as an acceptance of his wish to marry their daughter."

So a marriage was made as much by the families as by the couple, and it was shaped by the older rule of the clans. A person married outside the doodem, always, into another clan and another line, so that a marriage laced two families together where they had not been kin before. And the families looked in a match for the same thing the whole life of the camp depended on. They wanted a young man who could provide and a young woman who was skilled and industrious, for a household stood on his hunting and her craft together. Nodinens remembered her mother pressing the lesson on her, that she must learn to make the mats and the bags and the moccasins, "so when you have a home of your own you will be industrious." A good marriage was a working partnership before it was anything else.

The marriage itself was undramatic. The young couple simply began to live together, sometimes slipping away quietly for a few days first, and more often than not they settled near the woman's people. A man usually lived with his wife's family, Densmore noted, and a girl commonly stayed at home a while after her marriage before the couple built a lodge of their own. There was a kindness in the arrangement that one account catches well. An old woman remembered a marriage at Bad River in 1848, where the bride's mother "built a wigwam for the young couple near their own, making it as pretty as possible and furnishing it with new floor mats," and when the young people were ready they "quietly took up their abode". That was the wedding: a new lodge, made ready by a mother, and a couple moving quietly into it.

Not every marriage was one man and one woman. A man of ability, a good hunter who could provide for a larger household, might have two wives, and in older times, it was said, a few had more. Densmore visited such a household at Grand Portage and found it, in her words, living harmoniously. One Chippewa told her that many men had two wives, that "the man sat between them," and that where there were several one was the "head wife." It was a part of the old life, and the ethnographers recorded it as it was.

And like modern matrimony, occasionally a couple were not suited to each other in temperament: a marriage could end. It was not held together by a law or by a vow that could not be broken. If a couple in a lodge of their own could not get along, Densmore was told, the wife simply went back to her parents, and that was the end of it. What held most marriages was not a rule against parting but the weight of everything built around them: the children, the joined families, the shared work that fed them both, and the whole web of kin that a partnership had tied a little tighter.

So a marriage was quiet at its making and practical at its heart. As in any culture it began with fascination and love, and hope for a future together: a deer laid before a girl's parents, a feast shared, a lodge set up near her mother all demonstrated the commitment to a relationship between man and woman, as old as humanity. Hunting, sewing, making, creating, child rearing; all the tasks required to survive on the land, filled the years. The young man and woman who had achieved their dream quest came together, and from their joining came the next generation of the people.

Death



Every life came at last to its final passage, and the people faced this last one as they had faced every rite of passage. Death was not to be feared among the Anishinaabe. They had an ancient, cultural understanding of what death was and what the dead required of the living. A death was a grief, but not a mystery, and like so many peoples of the world, they held that death was not an ending. The dead were believed to have had a destination, a spiritual road to walk, and the living had traditional duties to perform to help them along that road.

The body was prepared and buried with care. Before the traders brought sawn lumber, the dead were wrapped, Densmore wrote, "in very heavy birch bark and tied with basswood cord," and laid in a shallow grave, often in a sitting posture and facing the west, the way the soul would travel. With the body went the tools of the person's own life, so that the dead would not set out empty-handed: with a man his pipe and tobacco, his flint and steel, and if he had been a good hunter his gun; with a woman her axe and her kettle and her moccasins. Over the filled grave the people built a little house of birch bark, and these grave houses stood, singly and in groups, throughout the Chippewa country. As the grave was closed, the mother or another near relative danced slowly around the open ground, and the burial was done.

Anishinaabe tradition avowed that the burial was only the beginning of the dead person's journey. The soul set out on a long westward road, the road of souls, and walked four days to reach its end. The living knew the road from the old accounts, and Warren stated it this way: along the way stood a great strawberry "like a huge rock," from which the traveler took a handful and ate; farther on lay a rolling and sinking bridge that turned to a serpent behind whoever had crossed the bridge; and at the end was a country of plenty, where the dead who had gone before were waiting, and welcomed the newcomer "singing and dancing." To honor this belief, for the four days of that walk the living helped. For four nights they fed a fire at the grave, Densmore recorded, "to aid the spirit, the purpose of the fire being for warmth and for cooking," and they set food beside the flames, so that the soul on its road would have light and warmth and something to eat. An old man's words over his dead daughter, which a missionary wrote down, confirm the sincerity of his belief in a single sentence: "Your feet are now on the road of souls, my daughter."



A grave under a covering of birch bark, the older form: the dead were wrapped in heavy birch bark and the filled grave covered the same way.

The people's faith in their beliefs was not given to them by a book, and on a clear night they believed they could look up and literally see them. The northern lights, in a tradition Densmore recorded, were the dead themselves, "ghosts rising and falling in the steps of a dance," the women among them dressed in bright clothing and the warriors carrying their clubs. The dead were painted before burial to join that dance, one the living could watch on many nights of the year. A family that had buried someone had only to

look up on a cold clear night to see, in the moving lights, the place their relative had gone to.

The living held the dead close for a while before letting them go. A relative might make what Densmore's informants called a spirit bundle. Soon after a death, Densmore recorded, that relative "cut a lock of hair from the back of the dead person's head," wrapped the lock in birch bark, and kept the lock as the heart of the bundle. On the night of the burial they carried the bundle to a fire and "sat and talked," and then took the bundle home, and for a time the bundle held a place in the lodge, the dead person still among the family in that small and tender way, until at last the bundle was given up.



Grave houses of sawn boards, a later form that appeared only after the traders brought milled lumber; before that the grave was sheltered in birch bark, as above.

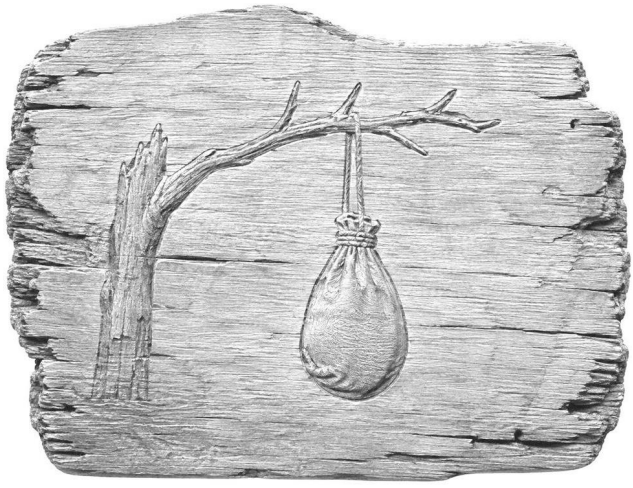
Grief was given its full measure. A widow above all mourned her husband for at least a year. Densmore vividly described her state of grief: she "did not go to any public place, she wore ragged clothing, clipped her hair across the ends, combed her hair very seldom, and wore it unbraided," and if she cast off the signs of mourning too soon the husband's relatives would reproach her. A person could set the mourning aside sooner, but only at a heavy cost, and by one of two means. The first was the costly rite of the Mide, the Grand Medicine, which a family might have performed for either a man or a woman. It was costly in a literal way. A family spent the better part of a winter gathering the price of it, dried

choice meats and the best pelts it could obtain from the traders, and laid the whole store, with tobacco, before the four old men of the Midewiwin chosen to conduct the four nights of the rite. To lift a year of mourning early, a family gave away much of what it had. The second was the war road, which a man could take to lift his mourning by avenging the dead, but which was not open to a woman. A widow, having no way to the war road, most often kept her full year unless her family could afford the rite.

Even the food left at a grave stayed within the web of obligation that had held a life. The food was not wasted and not forbidden: a poor person, a member of the dead one's clan, or a friend could take that food, and would leave an offering of their own in its place. What a person had owned, and what was laid out for the journey, stayed inside the same world of kin and obligation that had held the person in life.

The Anishinaabe's concept of death was much the same as any worldly human philosophy with regard to this disquieting subject: for the Anishinaabe, death changed the relationship; it did not erase it. The living prepared the body, tended the fire, mourned, remembered, and helped the dead along the road they believed lay ahead. The dead, in turn, remained present in memory and in the northern lights that marked the winter sky. A life that had been lived among kin did not become meaningless when it ended. The people carried their dead with them, until grief had its season and the living were able to look again toward the year ahead.

The Sacred Medicine



Almost everything in this book has recorded a spiritual tone that portrays the Indigenous way of life. Tobacco was laid in the ground before a root was dug. The first rice and the first berries were offered before the people ate. The bear was apologized to, its bones gathered unbroken and kept from the dogs. The rice was left to seed the lake beds again. None of these were idle habits. They were the outward signs of a single belief about the world: that the offerings in nature were alive with spirit, were given and not merely found, and were owed something in return. Behind the whole practical year stood this compact, and following this convention was integral to the people who inhabited it.

At the center of their belief was a great spirit, held in the deepest reverence and rarely named. Warren, writing as one of the people, called it Ke-che-mun-e-do, and described a veneration with nothing to equal it: "They seldom even ever mention his name unless in their Me-da-we and other religious rites, and in their sacrificial feasts; and then an address to him, however trivial, is always accompanied with a sacrifice of tobacco." The Ojibwe of Wisconsin, Huron Smith recorded, laid their tobacco for Grandmother Earth, for Wenabojo who had taught the people their arts, and for Dzhe Manido, the kind spirit. Around and below this great power was a world of lesser ones, the manidog, who took

the forms of animals and of things in the sky. The manido in the shape of a bear, and the manido of the animals that live in the water, were the ones a healer most wished to dream of, for they held the knowledge of medicine.

It should be said plainly that the belief did not fit the shape a European expected of a religion, and that the record reflects this. When Densmore asked her Mide teachers directly, they did not use the term the missionaries had chosen for God. They spoke instead of the Mide manido, the Grand Medicine spirit, and of the four manido at the cardinal points, and of the multitude in animal form. Whether one begins from Warren's great spirit or from Densmore's manidog, the substance is the same. This was less a religion of worship than a religion of birthright and a sacred relationship, concerned less with a named god above than with how a person was to live among the powers that filled the land.

A person met those powers most directly alone, in the fast of first manhood or womanhood, which the earlier chapters have followed. The dream that came in that fast gave a guardian for life, and the dream itself, Warren wrote, "guides in a great measure his future course in life." A dream was not idle sleep. An Old World scholar might call it a beatific or prophetic vision. Eastern spiritual traditions refer to it as transcendence. To the Indigenous it too was taken as a real way of knowing, as real as tracks in the snow, and a man whose fasts had been long and faithful was believed to see what others could not. Warren tells of the Mide priest Whole Ribs, who dreamed of pale spirits from the east and set out and found the first white men, and of a war chief who kept his people from the day's hunt because his guardian had warned him in the night that the enemy was near. The song that came to a person in such a dream was never sung lightly. It was, an informant told Densmore, a person's most sacred possession.



O'dini'gun, a member of the Midewiwin and one of the people who gave Frances Densmore her account of the old medicine.

The knowledge that a whole people had gathered this way, over a very long time, was a tradition held by a society, the Midewiwin, which the whites came to call the Grand Medicine. What it was for was stated as plainly as anything in the record by Gagewin, a Mide of White Earth: "The Midewiwin is not so much to worship

anything as to preserve the knowledge of herbs for use in prolonging life. The principal idea of the Midewiwin is that life is prolonged by right living, and by the use of herbs which were intended for this purpose by the Mide manido." It was this supreme understanding the people lived by, and, in other words, exactly what the title of this book has claimed for the whole body of Anishinaabe wisdom: an institution whose purpose was to keep the knowledge and pass it on. Its teachings were also its people's law, setting a member against lying and stealing and, in later years, against liquor, and enjoining proper conduct toward women. Men and women both belonged, and both could rise through its degrees, the ranked steps of the society. A member climbed them one at a time, each step earned by further instruction and a further gift, and each one opening more of the guarded knowledge than the step before.

The people's oldest wisdom was carried on rolls of birch bark, the figures scratched with a bone point and the lines rubbed with red. This was not writing in the European sense. The marks did not spell out words or fix a speech on the page; each figure was a prompt for the memory, standing for a song or a stage of the rite, which a trained Mide who already knew the words could read back and an untaught person could not. Among an oral people the rolls did not replace what was carried in the head. They held the order of it, and kept the songs and the ancient language safe when a single memory might fail.

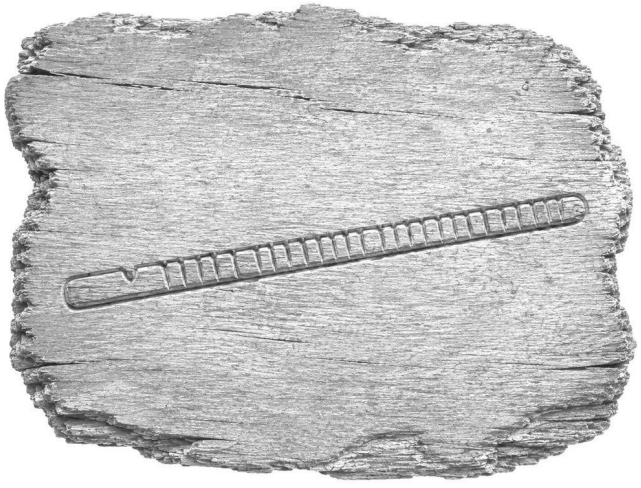
Warren, who was Ojibwe and was told of the etiquette by an old Mide priest, would not distill its ceremony, and said he stood only "on the threshold of the Me-da-we lodge." Its secrets, he wrote, were "as sacredly kept as the secrets of the Masonic Lodge among the whites." That restraint was not the European observer's alone; it belonged to the Indigenous people whose rite it was, and today, still does. What can be honestly told is the purpose and the place it held within the life of the people.

The person who carried all of this was the healer, and the healer was above all a spiritual figure. An earlier chapter set down the herbs and the wound-craft, the practical medicine. But the plants

were only half of it. There were two kinds of healer, Densmore recorded, and they worked by two different powers. The djasakid, the seer, cured by working on the mind, in the shaking tent and by the calling of the animal spirits, and before he began he would tell the story of his own dream as the warrant for what he was about to do. The Mide healed with herbs and with the power of the songs, and set his confidence not in his own dream but in the power of the Midewiwin, handed down through many faithful generations before him. Before either one touched a sick person he prayed, or as the record has it, "talked to the manido." A healer might be a man or a woman; one of Densmore's own teachers, Na'waji'bigo'kwe, was a woman more skilled than most in the old medicines. And the tools of the calling were themselves treated as holy. A healer's medicine bag, Warren wrote, "contains all which he holds most sacred," and was not kept in the common lodge but hung outside in the open air on a tree, "where even an ignorant child dare not touch it."

So the tobacco laid in the root-hole and the Mide lodge were not two different things. They were the same relationship, kept at two scales. The one was a single person paying a single debt to a single plant; the other was a whole society keeping the wisdom of that debt, and of ten thousand others like it, alive across the generations. To know how the Anishinaabe lived, it is not enough to know what they made and how they fed themselves through the year. All of it rested on the belief that the world was a gift held under obligation, and on the people whose promise was to remember what was owed.

What the Wisdom Was



This book has attempted a reconstruction. From a scattered and incomplete record, it has set out the everyday knowledge of the Great Lakes Anishinaabe as a whole, and presented it in the order in which the people themselves lived it, by the moons of the seasonal round. What the reader has followed, chapter by chapter, is not a collection of isolated customs but the working parts of a single system of living. It is worth stating plainly, at the end, what that system was.

It was, first, a complete subsistence technology, fitted precisely to the environment surrounding the Great Lakes region. The people drew their food from four sources across the year, the rice, the hunt, the sugar, and the water, and they maintained for each the full craft of attaining their needs and the further, harder craft of preservation. The drying and the rendering and the caching, the tanning of hides, the twisting of cord, the folding of bark into vessels: these were not crude expedients but refined techniques, each solving a real problem of the northern woodland with the materials the woodland gave. A people who could preserve a winter's meat without salt, waterproof a canoe with boiled pitch, and read a lake closely enough to know which of its water would

ripen its rice last possessed a technology, in the exact sense of the word.

It was, second, a system for governing the use of that environment so that the environment was not exhausted. They lived with the land. This is the part most easily missed and most worth attention. The people did not take all of the rice; they left the bed to seed itself. They took bark without killing the tree, dug a root and set an offering in its place, apologized to the bear, and returned the first of every harvest before eating freely. Framed as ceremony and obligation, this was, in its practical effect, a working discipline of resource management, a set of rules that held human demand inside the limits at which the plants and animals could renew themselves. The people did not use the modern language of sustainability, but the practice was precisely that, and it was ancient.

It was, third, a social and political order, and a functioning one. And if truth be told, it holds most closely to the governing structure of what the modern term "libertarian" now means: although with a non-judicial, less materialistic inclination. Membership in a clan fixed a person's kin and marriage across the whole of the country; leaders governed by counsel and consent rather than by command; disputes were settled through the families and the elders without courts or jails; and a rule of sharing spread the risk of a failed hunt across the whole camp. It was, fourth, a means of carrying all of this forward through the passages of a single life, from the cradleboard through the coming-of-age rituals, marriage, and the work of the adult years, to a death that returned the person to the memory and the kinship of the people. The knowledge reproduced itself, generation after generation, in the raising and the teaching of the young.

These four things together, the technology, the ethic of restraint, the social order, and the means of transmission, made a body of knowledge that was sophisticated, coherent, and tested. Its claims were checked against results over a very long time: in fact thousands of years longer than its old world counterpart, if the modern anthropologists are to be believed. A medicine was kept or

discarded according to whether the sick recovered; a method of preservation was trusted because the food did not spoil; a rule of the harvest survived because the harvest returned. This was empirical knowledge, arrived at by observation and experiment. The fact that it was carried in the memory and the hands of living people, and in a spoken language, rather than in written books, does not make it less of an intellectual achievement. It simply makes it a different kind of record, and a more fragile one.

That fragility is why the wisdom could be forgotten. A library can be neglected for a century and read again; a body of knowledge held only in people and their language cannot. When colonization broke the transmission, through dispossession and the treaties, through the collapse of the animal populations the fur trade drove, and through the residential schools and the long suppression of the language and the ceremonies, it did not merely change the people's circumstances. It broke the process by which the knowledge passed from the old to the young. What survives, and what this book has been built from, is a fragmentary record: the accounts of the few insiders who wrote their people's lives down, Warren and Copway and Blackbird and Jones, and the notebooks of the outsiders, Densmore and Jenks and Kohl, who set down what they could gather from the last elders who still remembered the old year in full.

The reconstruction is therefore partial, and this book has tried to be honest about that. It holds to the Great Lakes and does not borrow the customs of other peoples; it keeps to the documentary record and marks the places where that record is silent, where the sacred is deliberately left unreproduced, and where modern knowledge or the author's own judgment has filled a gap.

What is recovered is worth recovering, and not only as history. The organizing principle of this whole body of knowledge was that a people must live within the renewing limits of the systems that feed them, and must return something for what they take. That is precisely the knowledge the industrial world has lacked, and its absence shows now in the same waters and forests this book has described, emptied of the fish and the birds and the great animals

that the old economy did not exhaust in thousands of years. The wisdom in these pages is not a quaint survival of a vanished people. It is a tested model of a durable relationship between a human society and the land that sustains it, set down here so that it is not lost entirely.

This book began with an old woman at Mille Lac, remembering how her father kept the year on a notched stick, and it has followed that year through all of its work and all of its passages. Set down in full, that year was a complete and hard-won body of knowledge: a way of living well, and of going on living, in one demanding and abundant country, held by a people who understood that they belonged to the land, and not the land to them.

The Words, the Peoples, and the Names

This guide gathers the words in this book that are not English, the peoples whose country and knowledge it describes, and the men and women whose voices and records it draws on. The pronunciations are plain English approximations only, a starting point and not an authority. Most of these words belong to Anishinaabemowin, the Ojibwe language, which is spoken across many communities that do not always say a word the same way. Some spellings here are the modern written standard; others are the older spellings of the people who wrote the words down in the 1800s and early 1900s, kept as they set them, and marked with a dagger. Those who wish to hear the words as speakers say them should go to the source; the Ojibwe People's Dictionary carries recordings by first-language speakers.

Key. In the brackets, CAPITALS mark the stressed syllable. *ah* as in father, *ee* as in seen, *oo* as in boot, *uh* as in about, *ih* as in pin, *ay* as in day, *j* as in jar, *zh* as the s in measure. A dagger (†) marks a spelling read from an old writer's own notation, not confirmed with a speaker.

Words from the Language

Anishinaabe [uh-nish-in-AH-bay]: the people this book is about, the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Mississauga together; the word means, roughly, "the original people."

Anishinaabemowin [uh-nish-in-AH-bay-moh-win]: the Anishinaabe language.

Bi'jiki [bih-JIH-kih]: "the buffalo," the dream-name given to Tom Skinaway after his fast, for strength and endurance.

djasakid [JAH-suh-kid] †: the seer, the healer who worked on the mind through the shaking tent and the calling of the animal spirits.

doodem [DOH-dem]: the inherited clan mark, an animal by which a person was born into a family and bound to kin across the whole country (Warren's spelling, **Do-daim** [doh-DAME]).

Dzhe Manido [jay muh-nih-DOH]: the kind spirit, the creator.

Ke-che-mun-e-do [kay-chay-muh-nih-DOH] †: Warren's name for the Great Spirit, held in the deepest reverence and rarely spoken.

makuk [muh-KUK]: a folded and sewn birch-bark box, used to store and cache food, from a handful of sugar to a hundred pounds of rice.

manido [muh-nih-DOH]: a spirit, or a spirit-power (plural **manidog** [muh-nih-DOHG]); **Mide manido**, the Grand Medicine spirit.

megis [MAY-gis]: the small white shell that is the emblem of the Midewiwin.

Mide [mih-DAY]: a member of the Midewiwin.

Midewiwin [mih-DAY-wih-win]: the Grand Medicine society, which kept the sacred knowledge and the knowledge of healing herbs (Warren's spelling, **Me-da-we** [may-DAH-way] †).

nobigidaban [noh-big-ih-DAH-bun] †: the flat toboggan, the load-drag of the winter move; the one Ojibwe thing whose name English kept.

panis [PAH-nee]: a French word for an enslaved Indigenous person, taken from the name of a distant Plains people among the first so traded.

Paw-kaw-do-way [paw-kaw-DOH-way] †: the Odawa name for the ball game now called lacrosse.

shosh-e-mans [SHOH-shuh-manz] †: "little snow slides," the boys' thrown snow snakes.

wasswewin [WAHSS-way-win] †: fishing by torchlight, the birch-bark flame carried in the bow of a canoe at night.

Wenabojo [way-nuh-BOH-joh]: the culture-hero and teacher of the old stories, who shaped much of the world and gave the people their arts (also **Nanabozho**).

wiidige [WEE-dih-gay]: to marry, meaning literally to live together.

wiidigemaagan [wee-dih-gay-MAH-gun]: a husband or wife, named as the person one shares a home with.

wigwam [WIG-wahm]: the dome-shaped bark-and-mat lodge that was the true house of the Great Lakes people.

The Peoples

Anishinaabe: the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Mississauga, closely related peoples of the upper Great Lakes who shared a language and a way of life.

Cree: the people of the country north of the Great Lakes.

Dakota, also **Sioux**: the people to the west and south, on the prairie's edge; the Ojibwe's long adversary in the contest for the rice lakes and hunting grounds.

Flambeau: an Ojibwe band at Lac du Flambeau, Wisconsin, whose plant knowledge Huron Smith recorded.

Menominee [muh-NOM-in-ee]: neighbors of the Ojibwe in Wisconsin, around Green Bay.

Mississauga [mis-ih-SAW-gah]: of the north shore of Lake Ontario and the Credit River in Ontario; the people of Copway and Peter Jones.

Odawa [oh-DAH-wah] (Ottawa): of northern Lake Michigan and the Straits of Mackinac; Blackbird's people, at Arbor Croche in Michigan.

Ojibwe [oh-JIB-way], also **Chippewa** [CHIP-uh-wah]: the most numerous of the three; the country of Lake Superior, the upper Mississippi headwaters, northern Michigan, Wisconsin, and Minnesota, and northern Ontario. Most of this book's knowledge is theirs.

Pillager: an Ojibwe band at Leech Lake, Minnesota; the band of the chief Flat Mouth.

The People in This Book

The Indigenous voices whose words carry the book:

Blackbird, Andrew J., Mackawdebenessy (c. 1815–1908): an Odawa of Arbor Croche, Michigan, who wrote *History of the Ottawa and Chippewa Indians*.

Copway, George, Kahgegagahbowh [kah-gay-GAH-gah-boh] (1818–1869): a Mississauga of Rice Lake, Ontario, who wrote his own life and his people's traditions.

Flat Mouth, Esh-ke-bug-e-coshe [esh-kay-BUG-ay-koh-shay] †: the aged head chief of the Pillager Ojibwe at Leech Lake, who traveled to sit with the young Warren and called him grandson.

Gagewin [GAH-gay-win]: a Mide of White Earth, Minnesota, who gave Densmore the meaning of the Midewiwin and the words a healer spoke to a plant.

Jones, Peter, Kahkewaquonaby [kah-kay-WAH-kwoh-nah-bee] (1802–1856): a Mississauga of the Credit River, missionary and author.

Main'gans [MAIN-gunz]: an Ojibwe man whose frost-ruined legs were amputated below the knee with a common knife, the healing "perfect"; a Densmore informant.

Na'waji'bigo'kwe [nah-WAH-jih-big-oh-kway]: "woman dwelling in the midst of the rocks," an Ojibwe medicine woman more skilled than most in the old remedies.

Nodinens [noh-DEE-nens]: a Mille Lac Ojibwe woman who, at seventy-four, narrated the whole turning of the year to Frances Densmore. Her account threads this book from the first page.

O'dini'gun [oh-DIN-ih-gun]: a member of the Midewiwin and a principal informant to Densmore on the old medicine.

Odjib'we [oh-JIB-way]: a Mississippi-band Ojibwe, the last great warrior of his band, who gave Densmore the war songs and the stories of the war road.

Skinaway, Tom: a Mille Lac Ojibwe who fasted ten times for the vision that named him Bi'jiki.

Warren, William W. (1825–1853): born at La Pointe, of Ojibwe and New England descent; he gathered his people's history from the old men before it was lost and wrote it down as *History of the Ojibway People*.

Wawatam [wah-WAH-tum]: the Ojibwe who took the trader Alexander Henry into his family and adopted him as a brother.

The recorders, outsiders who wrote down what they saw and were told:

Densmore, Frances (1867–1957): the American ethnographer whose Bureau of American Ethnology bulletins on Chippewa customs, music, and plants are this book's chief source.

Henry, Alexander (1739–1824): a fur trader whose account of his travels records the country of the 1760s and his adoption by Wawatam.

Kohl, Johann Georg (1808–1878): a German traveler whose *Kitchi-Gami* recorded Lake Superior Ojibwe life from his visit of 1855.

Smith, Huron H. (1883–1933): the ethnobotanist who recorded the plant knowledge of the Flambeau and other Ojibwe.

Tanner, John (c. 1780–1846): taken captive as a boy and raised among the Ojibwe and Odawa for some thirty years; his narrative gives lived detail from inside the households.

Plates

The historical photographs in this book are public-domain plates from the Bureau of American Ethnology, reproduced in black and white with an aged treatment. They are credited below by their original source.

Frances Densmore, Chippewa Customs, Bureau of American Ethnology Bulletin 86 (1929).

Plates 1, 4, 9, 10, 19, 21 (portrait of O'dini'gun), 22, 26, 28, 30 (graves and grave houses), 40 (implements used in games), 42 (portrait of Nodinens), 44, 45, 46, 47, 48 (portrait of Endusogiwig), 53, 54, 57, 58, 59, 60, 64, 69, and 74.

Frances Densmore, Chippewa Music — II, Bureau of American Ethnology Bulletin 53 (1913).

Plates 1 (Odjib'we), 5, 7, 9 (Main'gans), 11, 14, 22, 23 (prominent men at a gathering), 37, 39, and 40.

Frances Densmore, Uses of Plants by the Chippewa Indians, Bureau of American Ethnology 44th Annual Report (1928).

Plates 28, 33, 35, 37, 38, 40, 41, 45, and 47.